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THE ENGLISH MILLINIUM

Authorized Version

THE INVISIBLE TEACHER

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GoProEnglish

The English Millinium

***Road to 2020 UTME ENGLISH
GRAMMAR INDEPENDENCE***

***A complete guide on
Grammatical Accuracy, Oral,
and Syntactic Rules***

English Millinium

Indispensable Guide to UTME & P-UTME

About

This is an Indispensable guide to UTME & P-UTME students who desire to blast through the exams with flying colors. The Millinium English e-book(s) includes the crucial part of Dele Ashade's Invisible Teacher and other authoritative grammatical expositions ranging widely from grammatical functions and names which isn't included in the popular Invisible Teacher. This book is strictly for sale and not to be shared.

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Compressed and Compiled by Kolawole Adebowale

The
INVISIBLE TEACHER
of

JAMB'S *'Use of English'*

Barry Kolawole

DELE ASHADE

LEXIS and STRUCTURE:

CONCORD:

AGREEMENT BETWEEN STRUCTURAL ELEMENTS

One of the characteristic features or qualities of the English Language is that, it obeys the rules of agreement. Agreement? Between what and what? In grammar---- or sentence formation----it is essential that some words should agree with other words. This kind of agreement can come in different structural forms:

Subject (doer of action) can agree with *verb* (the action) e.g.

The man knows (not know)
The men know (not knows)

Remember that in a sentence, there are four major structural parts. The **Subject**, the **Predicator** (verb), the **Complement** (object) and the **Adjunct** (adverbs). So, words from **Subject** should agree with the **Predicator** and also with the **Complement** and in other ways. Here are a few examples of problems associated with Structural Agreement. Which of these is correct?:

1. God **know** / **knows** you.
2. God **bless** / **blesses** you (someone prays for you).
3. Dandy, alongside his friends **runs** / **run**, everyday.
4. Nigeria **beats** / **beat** Cameroon.
- 5.

Now, the Types of Agreements and their Laws.

- 1. NUMBER AGREEMENT

Here, you are to consider the number of people who perform an action to be able to choose the type of verb, for example:

The men (at least 2) plural:) + verb (that should be plural, e.g. are)

The men → → → are

Not: The men is here. X (wrong)

For the purpose of this topic, we hereby list out verbs and their numbers:

- **is / was / has / had** (singular helping verbs)

- **is / was / has / had** (singular helping verbs)
 - **are / were / am / have / had** (plural helping verbs)
 - **goes / takes / speaks / writes** (singular principal verbs)
 - **go / take / speak / write** (plural principal verbs)
- Note:** It means that a singular principal verb is used with singular helping verbs and a plural principal verb is used with plural helping verbs.

Note: It means that a singular principal verb usually carries an **s** after the verb. Look up again. You should NOT add an **s** to a plural principal verb. Do you understand? There are two Laws under the number agreement by which we mean, is it singular or plural?

There are two Laws under the number agreement by which we mean, is it singular or plural?

Law 1a: Choose a singular noun (subject) when you have a singular verb. e.g.
singular noun: **The teacher** (one person) + **beats** (singular verb).
Not: **The teacher** (singular noun) + **beat** (plural verb). Do you understand?

Law 1b: Choose a **plural subject** when you have a **plural verb**. e.g.
plural noun = **Teachers** + **beat** (plural verb) Not:
Teachers + **beats**

↓ ↓
plural singular

• **LAW 2: INDEFINITE PRONOUNS IN AGREEMENTS**

Whenever you find the following words acting as subject, you must choose a singular helping verb or a singular principal verb to agree with it, They are:

everywhere / everybody / everyone / everything
somewhere / somebody / someone / something
nowhere / nobody / noone / nothing
anywhere / anybody / anyone / anything

So, it means you cannot say:

Everywhere **look** dark (because, **look** is a plural verb) but the law says you must use a singular verb: **looks**:

Everywhere **looks** dark ✓ (correct).

You can also say:

Everyone has (not: have) a name. This is because with **everyone**, the verb we need is the singular helping verb **has** not the PLURAL helping verb **have**.

• **LAW 3: ADDITIONAL - INFORMATION AGREEMENT**

Additional information can be information that appears in a bracket or separated by dashes, e.g.

- a) The man (not his children) **is** here
- b) The man — not his children — **is** here

In **a** and **b** above, **not his children** is additional information. The rule is: wherever there is additional information, you should choose what the main, real information (before the brackets / dashes) is, as your subject, then see if it is singular. If so, choose a singular verb. But if it is plural, choose a plural verb.

In the above examples, you will not choose **children** (which is plural) as the subject because it is only additional information.

Look at this: The teachers (not the principal) **is / are** here. Choose one! Good!! **are**! This is because **principal** (which is singular and which is additional information) is not our subject but "The teachers" which is plural, therefore attracting **are**, not **is**.

• **LAW 4: AGREEMENT WITH EACH**

Wherever **each** is used, go ahead to add a singular noun and a singular verb

= **each** + **singular noun** + **singular verb**
 ↓ ↓ ↓
 Each boy (not: boys) knows (not: know) the man

- **LAW 5: AGREEMENT WITH EVERY**

Wherever you find every, add a singular noun and a singular verb

Every + **singular noun** + **singular verb**

↓ ↓ ↓
 Every day (not: days) looks fine
 not: every days look fine X (wrong)

- **LAW 6: AGREEMENT OF EVERY AND FIGURE**

In Law 5, we have stressed that, wherever we have **every**, the next noun must be singular. However, in some sentences, a figure may come after **every** before a noun, e.g.

Every **ten** + boys ... that come / comes here ...

In this case, you are not to choose a singular verb as of rule 5 but because **ten** is plural, choose a plural verb: **come**, not comes

- **LAW 7: BODMAS AGREEMENT**

BODMAS—**B**rackets, **O**f, **D**ivision, **M**ultiplication, **A**ddition, **S**ubtraction—is a mathematical principle. In English, sentences involving these six processes will be expressed in either singular or plural verbs, both are correct, e.g.

---Ten multiplied by ten **is** or **are** one hundred

---Nine minus five **is** or **are** four

Both **is** and **are** above, are correct in the two sentences.

- **LAW 8: AGREEMENT OF QUANTITY**

When any type of quantitative measure is involved, e.g. **frequency** of doing something (ten times) or **percentage** or **length** e.g. five kilometres or amount of **money** e.g. five hundred naira or **weight** e.g. 60 kilogrammes, use a **singular verb** e.g.

----60 kilo **is** (not, **are**) too heavy to carry

----85% **makes** (not, **make**) a good grade

- **LAW 9: SELECTION AGREEMENT**

Where one or two or any figure or number is selected from among a larger unit (a plural noun), it is the number selected (whether singular or plural) that will determine the VERB e.g. I have ten teachers. One of them is wicked.

Do I now say:

One of my **teachers is / are** wicked

Because we selected **one**, we should choose **is** which is a singular verb like **one** or, **One** of my teachers **goes** to cinema everyday

Both **one** and **goes** are singular.

Always remember that in this situation, because there are many teachers (but I am talking about only one of them) we should use **teachers** (not, teacher):

One of my **teachers** knows me

But

Two of my **teachers** **know** (not, knows) me

- **LAW 10: AGREEMENT WITH *EITHER***

Either means, one of any two things already mentioned. If one of the things is singular and the other is plural, which one should be regarded as the subject, to enable you pick the corresponding or appropriate "singular" or "plural verb". e.g. either the **principal** or the **teachers** **pray** / **prays** everyday.

Notice that **principal** is singular but **the teachers** is plural. So, which one will you regard as the subject for the purpose of choosing between **pray** and **prays**?

The law says, choose the one after **or**, as your subject which, here, is eh? yes, right: **the teachers**. Good! **The teachers** is now the subject, and it attracts **pray** (not, **prays**) because **teachers** and **pray** are both plural. Understand? Great!

- **Law 11: Agreement with *NEITHER***

Neither means, not any one of the two things or people mentioned is valid.

The law of agreement in relation to wherever you find **NEITHER** states that, it is the noun after **NOR** that determines the choice of the verb e.g. Neither Mrs. Adiukwu nor her triplets — alive (a) are (b) is

Her triplets comes after **nor** and so, becomes the subject, which is plural, making it possible to have the plural helping verb **are**. Clear? Right! However, where **neither of + them** is involved in the statement, put a **singular verb** after them. Neither of them **has** ... **None of them** also follows this law

- **LAW 12: PRAYER IN AGREEMENT**

Wherever a prayer, wish, resolution, suggestion or recommendation is involved in an "agreement" statement, the plural helping / principal verb must be used, e.g. (May) God **forbid**! (not, God forbids)

Normally, God is singular and should have attracted **forbids** (singular principal verb) but because it is a wish or a prayer, **forbid** is chosen.

Consider: We hereby recommend that Joyce **stop** / **stops** the programme.

Remember, this is a recommendation, so simply choose **stop**, a plural verb instead of the singular **stops**

Try solve the following:

- (a) It is suggested that my principal **trace** / **traces** out the house of the sick student.
- (b) God **blesses** / **bless** you!

It is our opinion that the new Miss Nigeria **marries** / **marry** immediately after her reign

• **LAW 13: AGREEMENT WITH MASS COUNT**

Mass Count nouns are the following: water and all other liquids; information, equipment, news, traffic, advice, fruit, furniture, cloth, all abstract nouns, including training, progress, happiness, sadness, joy; damage, baggage, luggage, work, etc.

Simple Law: for each of them, use a singular helping verb or a singular principal verb. e.g. Information **makes** (not **make**) the world go round.

Remember, however, that you are not expected, under any circumstance, to put an s at the end of any word called mass count noun, e.g. some **informations** X (wrong) but some **pieces** of information.

▪ **LAW 14: AGREEMENT WITH AND**

The verb to be chosen in a sentence where there are two or more noun (phrase) or pronouns which are joined together by **and** is simply a plural helping verb or a plural principal verb, e.g.

---The boy, Mary, the young twins **and** I **have** a mission

---All the teachers, our parents **and** principal **want** success for us

▪ **LAW 15: AGREEMENT WITH ALL**

There are two things that **all** can mean at any time. First, it may mean "everything", as in:

All that I've been saying **does** (not, **do**) not make sense to him (here, **all** means all my ideas, points and possibly persuasion) and the **all** therefore means **everything**. In this case, use a singular helping or principal verb like **does**.

When, on the other hand **all** appears, it may mean **all the people**, as in:

All have (not, **has**) gone (**all the people** + **have**) use a plural helping or principal verb as may be appropriate, here.

• **LAW 16: WHO IN AGREEMENT**

Sometimes, when **who**, **that**, **whose** or **which** is used, confusion about the choice of appropriate verbs sets in, e.g.

One of the girls who ----- impregnated ----- died

(a) was / have (b) were / have (c) was / has (d) were / has

The law provides that the **who** will refer to the noun or pronoun that comes before it and that noun or pronoun must become the subject. In the example above, **who** refers to "the girls" which is now our subject and it attracts **was** (plural of 'was') but "one" of them "**has**" died.

- **LAW 17: "ALL BUT" IN AGREEMENT**

Where **all but** appears, the agreement question is settled by considering what comes after **but**, as the subject.

All but Jimmy knows (not, **know**) him.

- **LAW 18: AGREEMENT, WITH "MANY A"**

Consider this: Many a woman **loves / love** the man.

Where 'many a' is used in this way, ignore the **many** and regard **a** as the "determiner" which is singular in effect, and this means that a singular helping or principal verb must be chosen:

Many a woman loves the man ✓ (correct)

By implication of meaning, the clause above shows that many women love the man. Take note that, after **many a**, the next noun or noun phrase must be singular: many a woman (not, women)

- **LAW 19: UNMARKED PLURALS IN AGREEMENT**

The following are plural words but they do not carry an **s** at the back so, it is not easy to know. You are to treat them the way you treat plural words. They include: police, vermin, gentry, folk, youth, cattle, clergy, people (a nation), e.g.

UME 1993 question 84:

The vermin on his body ----- hideous (a) makes the lunatic look (b) make the lunatic look (c) makes the lunatic to look (d) make the lunatic to look. Choose ...
ehn? again? Right: **B. B!** Treat other words listed above as such.

- **LAW 20: PLURAL FIGURES IN AGREEMENT**

Ten children **is** (not: **are**) enough for me

Three months **is** enough for the job (not: **are**)

When figures such as the above are used, in the position of the verb, a singular auxiliary verb (not: main verb, e.g. goes / comes) should be used. Singular auxiliary verbs include **is** and **was**

- **LAW 21: BLOCK PLURAL GROUPS**

Some categories of things and people are sometimes identified using **The + a** description of the group, without showing them as plurals. They are plurals and should be regarded as such. They include: **The poor** (= the poor people) **the handicapped**, **the aged**, **the young-at-heart** etc. The handicapped **are** (not: **is**) suffering (or use a main verb without **s**) e.g. **know**

- **LAW 22: "A - NUMBER - OF" AGREEMENT**

When **a number of** is involved, a plural verb, e.g. *have, go, speak, are, were* must be used, e.g.:

A number of houses + have (not: has) been demolished. This law also governs a range of; a survey of

- **LAW 23: ABSTRACT NOUNS**

When an abstract noun or idea is in a sentence, it is regarded as singular and attracts verbs such as **is / was / has / had / goes / takes** etc e.g. 1979 q 91: The benefit one gets from watching plays ----- comparable to that found in taking a university course in drama (a) is (b) was (c) were (d) are (e) are being.
Answer = is (a)

- **LAW 24: NUMBER REALITY IN AGREEMENT**

Some words do not show plural number yet they are plural nouns and plural verbs should be put in front of these nouns. **Class, club, team Nigeria** etc are some of these. It is correct to say Nigeria beat (not beats) Ghana in the U – 21 soccer fiesta. This is because of the "reality" of eleven people being in one team here called "Nigeria". Eleven people = plural. Nigeria = only one = singular. We are to consider the "real" number to be able to choose the verb "eleven people".

- **LAW 25. SIAMESE SUBJECT IN AGREEMENT**

As the name implies, Siamese (from Siamese twins) means, "two – in – one". Where one person is seen in two personalities, the **singular verb** must be used, e.g. The President is also the Minister of Petroleum, so we can have: The President and Minister **is** (not: are) coming tomorrow. (the will not come before Minister otherwise, Minister becomes a separate person from President)

- **LAW 26: THE THEORY OF NEARNESS / PRINCIPLE OF PROXIMITY**

When there are two or more nouns or pronouns, and there is confusion as to which one will be chosen as the subject, this theory says, it is the noun or pronoun nearest to the space for the verb that must be regarded as the subject, e.g.

My friends, Shola, our principal, the teachers or I ----- going to London.

(a) is (b) are (c) am. Answer = **am** because **am** is nearest the gap. We usually say, I am, not I is / are

- **LAW 27: FALSE SUBJECTS IN AGREEMENT**

When a singular subject is accompanied by other (seeming) subjects, (e.g. **Lola**, with **her brothers**) it is the main subject: **Lola** that will stand as the subject and so, a singular verb must be chosen. **With** in the statement only introduces the "attachment" of false subjects. Other words that introduce false subjects are, as well as, **in conjunction with, alongside, together with** etc. It is the noun or pronoun that comes **BEFORE with** or the other false subject introducers (above) that is regarded as the true subject.

LAW 28: PERCENTAGE WITH PLURAL COUNTS

When a particular % is mentioned with a **plural count** noun in a statement involving **of**, (e.g. **ten percent of the students**), the verb to follow must be a **plural one**, e.g. *speak, take, see* (not: *sees*), *have, were, are* etc. Compare this with Law 8 e.g. 40% of the teachers **know** (not: *knows*) me.

Past Question References

2006 question 26

The police claim that a number of stolen cars ----- recovered

- (a) have been (b) has been (c) has being
(d) have being

Solution: Use Law 22

2004 question 38

Each of the houses ----- a new look

- (a) have got (b) have (c) has
(d) were given

Solution: Apply Law 4

2003 question 33

Three quarters of the people in the village ----- killed but only half of their huts ----- affected

- (a) were / were (b) was / was
(c) were / was (d) was / were

Solution: Apply Law 28

2003 question 38

Four weeks ----- enough for the police to conclude their investigation

- (a) were (b) is (c) are (d) has been

Solution: Use Law 20

2002 question 91

The quality of your questions which ----- always attracted attention ----- never been in doubt

- (a) have / has (b) have / have (c) has / has
(d) has / have

Solution: Notice the use of **which** which is a marker of relative clauses. Apply Law 16

2001 question 77

Neither Agbo nor his parents ----- the meeting now

- (a) attended (b) attend (c) has attended
(d) attends

Solution: Notice **neither ... nor** in the question. Apply Law 11.

Take note of **now** (to show that your answer should be in present tense).

2001 question 80

The government which ----- recruiting --- workers suddenly stopped doing so.

- (a) are / its (b) was / its (c) is / their
(d) were / their

Solution: Apply, as you did with question 91 of 2002, Law 16.

1998 question 84

Two young boys have been caught with parts of the stolen machine but ----- admitted stealing it

- (a) neither of them has
(b) neither of them have
(c) none of them has
(d) none of them have

Solution: Use Law 11

1996 question 74

The Emir and Conqueror of the enemy territories ----- next week

- (a) arrives (b) are to arrive (c) arrive
(d) are arriving

Solution: Use Law 25

1995 question 73

The teacher with his wife ----- here

- (a) were (b) were to be (c) are (d) was

Solution: Use Law 27

1994 question 90

Sixty percent of the unskilled workers -----
yearly by the company

- (a) are retain (b) is retained
(c) were retained (d) are retained

Solution: Use Law 28

Additionally, when something happens
yearly (as indicated above) the present
tense is applicable.

1994 question 70

A range of options ----- available to the
political parties during the recently
concluded elections

- (a) were made (b) is made (c) are made (d)
was made

Solution: Apply Law 22

1994 question 65

The police ----- happy about the
dwindling crime rate

- (a) says they are (b) say it it
(c) say they are (d) says it is

Solution: Apply Law 19

1993 question 90

The helpless ----- our sympathy

- (a) require (b) requires

Solution: Apply Law 21

1993 question 74

Some of the food ----- spoilt

- (a) is (b) are (c) were (d) have

Solution: Apply Law 13. **Food** is an
uncountable noun

1992 question 88

One of the ----- selective marking of
errors

- (a) school of thought suggests
(b) schools of thought suggest
(c) schools of thought suggested
(d) schools of thought suggests

Solution: Apply Law 9

1992 question 86

Our principal and chairman of the
occasion ----- just arrived

- (a) has (b) having (c) have (d) had

Solution: Use Law 25

1992 question 81

a survey of opinions on how pupils feel
about their teachers ----- carried out

- (a) has been (b) have been (c) are being
(d) is been

Solution: Grammatically, **is** cannot
ever go with **been** but
with being. Use Law 9

1992 question 75

Ahmed is one of the boys who always ----
-- good work

- (a) does (b) would do (c) do (d) done

Solution: Apply Law 16

This is because of the use of **who** (a
relative pronoun) in the question

Note: Other past question references on this topic include:

1991 questions 72, 71, 69, 66 and 54. 1990 question 62. 1989 questions 95, 83. 1987
questions 82, 79 and 66. 1986 questions 92 and 91. 1984 questions 98 and 89. 1980
question 81. 1979 question 91. 1978 question

QUESTION TAGS

When we speak, we may sometimes want to emphasize the message we are passing. To achieve this, we use two forms of statements:

a) **A declarative statement.**

This is a statement that says what you know or believe, e.g.: Today is Friday.

b) **A question, e.g.:**

- Is it?
- Aren't you? Etc

Statements: Positivity and Negativity

A statement is positive if it does not have the **not** particle as in:

Today is Friday (positive statement----no **not** in the clause)

A statement is negative if it carries the negative particle **not** e.g.:

Today is **not** Friday (negative statement)

Questions: positivity and negativity

A question is positive If it does not carry the **not** particle, e.g.:

- Is it?
- Will she?

A question is negative if it carries the **not** particle, e.g.:

Isn't it?

Won't she?

Do you understand? Great!

To form tag structures, a statement and a question must come together. The following are the rules for joining them together:

1. When there is a **positive statement**, there should be a **negative question** following it, e.g.:

(a) We are learning English grammar (positive statement)

(b) Aren't we? (negative question)

Notice how **we** and **are** in a above are transposed in **b** (above)

2. When there is a **negative statement**, there should be a **positive question** following it, e.g.

She will not come home (negative statement) +
Will she? (positive question)

3. If there is no *is /was/are/ were/ am; Has/have/ had; do/does/did; will-would/may-might/shall-should* etc. in the statement, use **do** or **did** or **does** to form the tag,

For example: (a) he **is** here
(b) **Isn't** he?

In **a** and **b** (above), **is** changes to **isn't** in **b**.
BUT, look at this:

(a) She speaks good English

What will the **b** part be like? Would you say:
(b) **Speakn't** she?

NO! use **doesn't** (since you can use **do/does/did**): you "speak" in **a**, then, in **b**, you will use **don't**; as in:

They **speak** good English

~~Don't they?~~

Also if it is: they **spoke** good English,
You will use **did** (you know, **spoke** is past tense; **did** is also past tense. It should be this way:

(a) They **spoke** good English

(b) **Didn't** they?

Do you understand?

4. if **used to** appears in the statement, use **did** or **didn't**,
for example: (a) she **used to** cry like a baby (in the past)

~~(b) Didn't she?~~

5. When you are asked a question that demands a **yes** or **no** answer, do not use **not** with **yes** or a positive idea with **no** for example:

(a) You do not like to fail? (Meaning, do you like to fail?) The **b** part should not be:

(b) **Yes**, I do not want to fail . Simply say:

(b) **Yes**, I **do** OR, **No**, I **do not** (I don't).

6. Whenever **there** is used as the subject of the clause, you should return **there** in the second part, for example:

(a) ~~There~~ is one egg on the table

(b) Isn't ~~there~~? (correct).

Do not say: "Isn't it?"

7. If the statement involves a mild command such as "let us..." the second part should be **shall** + the subject of the clause, for example:

(a) **Let's** (let us) travel tomorrow

(b) **Shall we?** (correct)

8. If **must** or **should** or **ought to** is used in a sense that means **necessary**, the statement or question that follows will be **need** or **needn't**, for example:

(a) **Must** he greet his teacher by prostrating? (Is it necessary?)

(b) No, he **needn't** (not; "no, he **mustn't**")

9. When **do you mind** is used, it means **do you think it is bad if ...** for example:

(a) Do you mind a piece of cake (do you think it is bad if I give you a piece of cake?)

(b) No, I don't (think it is bad if you give me) so, Mr. A. (above) will give the cake to Mr B.

Past Questions and Answers

1978 QUESTION 76

The managing Director did not pay his staff last month _____. (a) didn't he (b) had he not (c) is not it (d) did he (e) has he

Answer: The statement is negative, so the question should be ...? Yes! Positive.

1978 QUESTION 87

You would have thought that somebody would have informed me _____. (a) shouldn't they (b) wouldn't you (c) I should think (d) you agree (e) isn't it

Answer: Here you have a positive statement, so, the second part should be a negative question "you **would** ..." starts the positive statement above, so your answer should start with the negative form of **would**. Do you agree? Good!

1979 QUESTION 38

She doesn't have to attend the lecture
_____. (a) doesn't she (b) is she (c) has she (d) does she (e) isn't it

1994 question 58, 72

1997 question 75, 76

1999 question 80

2000 question 72

2001 question 54

2003 question 71, 48

2009 question 79

2008 question 81

2006 question 35

2004 question 40, 35

OTHER PAST QUESTIONS FOR YOUR PRACTICE ARE:

1979 question 51

1980 question 56

1981 question 90

1983 question 90

1984 question 72

1987 question 84 1998 question 98

UNDERSTANDING THE MEANING OF WORDS IN EXAMINATION QUESTIONS THE WORD-FORMATION METHOD

One important aspect of the UTME is the set of question which asks you to find the word nearest in meaning (synonym) or find the word opposite in meaning (antonym) to the one candidates are given.

Candidates can understand the meaning of words by many means. They are the following:

(a) Studying Word Meaning

Candidates can know the meaning of words by learning direct from dictionaries. Such candidates would put conscious effort in learning different words from English learners' dictionaries. Not only the meaning of a word could be learned. You are also advised to learn the **usage** (how to put the word in a sentence correctly); the **word-class** (what part of speech the word is, that is noun, verb, adjectives, etc; the **interaction** of the word with other words in any given sentence; the **spelling** of the word and finally, the **pronunciation** of the word.

(c) Studying Philology and Etymology

Philology and *etymology* are areas in the study of language which deal with the history of the origin of words and their diachronic development, for example, how the word 'nice' had moved from being a word of insult hundreds of years in the past, to a word meaning 'good', in present day English. Etymology also has to do with the origin of each word and how it came to be an English language word. There is no opportunity for most candidates to study philology and etymology but you may wish to explore two methods of arriving at the correct answer under these types of question.

The methods are:

- a. *The Word-formation principle*
- b. *The positivity/negativity method*

To determine the meaning of a strange word, one may analyse the word. First, take note of the following concepts in the word formation principle:

(i). **Synonym:** A word which has the same meaning as another word.

E.g. **begin** = *commence*
buy = *purchase*

ii. **Antonym:** A word which is opposite in meaning to another word, e.g. **boy** = *girl*
wise = *foolish*

iii. **Polyseme:** A word which has many meanings, e.g. *class*, *bridge*
One cannot say the meaning of the words above unless the words are each put in the context of a sentence.

- iv. **Homophone:** This is a word which has the same sound as another, for example,
sheer Vs Share
cease Vs seize
seat Vs Sit
stationery Vs stationary

(c) Word – Formation Concepts

To form words or understand English words, these concepts should be learned.

- **Root**

Like an atom in chemistry (which is the smallest, indivisible particle of an element), the root of a word is the smallest, indivisible part of a word which is being analysed with word formation principles, e.g.

- i. **Full Word:** *intercontinental*
Root : *continent*
- ii. **Full Word:** *Maladministration*
Root : *Administer*

The *root* is also called the *base-word*.

- **Prefix**

This is any letter(s) that come *before* the root, e.g.

- i. **Full word:** *intercontinental*
prefix : *inter*
- ii. **Full word:** *Maladministration*
Prefix : *Mal*

Is this clear?

- **Suffix:**

This is any letters that come *after* the root, e.g.

- i. **Full word:** *intercontinental*
Suffix : *al*
- ii. **Full word:** *Maladministration*
Prefix : *tion*

NOTE: i.

Not all English words have root, prefix and suffix

- (ii) Before looking for the prefix or suffix, you should first have found a meaningful root, such as in the two words above.

Take note that words that cannot be analysed for *root*, *prefix* and *suffix* will be understood by studying philology, etymology or by learning the meaning of such words from a standard English language dictionary such as the *Oxford Advanced Learners' Dictionary of current English*.

IMPORTANCE OF THE WORD FORMATION CONCEPTS

Why do we learn about roots, prefixes and suffixes? We learn them because they can give us clues to the meanings of the words whose meanings we do not know, ordinarily. Each prefix has its own meaning. Knowing what prefixes and suffixes mean

leads us to the meaning of the word, for example; in the table below, you will find that **hyper** means *more than normal*, so, what is the opposite of **hyperactivity**, as in

"the boy's *hyperactivity* was discussed at the meeting".

Now, all you need do is find:

The root = act/active
Prefix = hyper (more than normal)
Suffix = (v)ity

The meaning of **hyperactivity** therefore is, *acting or working at a rate higher than normal*.
The opposite, therefore is *passivity*, that is, *not active / dullness*.

What is important now is to learn the meanings of prefixes, as found in the table below.

PREFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE
poly-	Many	polygamy, polytechnic
Auto	Self	Automatic, autocratic, autonomy
dis-	Opposite of/not	Disloyal, distrust, disengage
pro-	In support of/not	Pro-African, pro-slavery
under-	Too little/not enough	Under-estimate, under-privileged
non-	Not	Non-partisan, non-native
uni	One	Unilateral
mono	One	Monotechnic, monolithic
proto-	Original/first	Prototype
sub-	Below/less than	Submarine, submerge, substandard,
mal-	Not well/bad/badly	Malnutrition, malodorous
a-	Not / deficient/in/lacking in	Asexual, asymmetry
trans-	From one place to another, across	Trans-national, trans-atlantic
Dis-	To deprive of/reverse an action	Dis-enfranchise, disqualify
semi-	Half	Semi-desert, semi-circle
un-	Opposite of/not	Unassuming, unsteady
ultra-	Beyond/more than ordinary	Ultra-modern, ultra-high
Mis-	In a wrong way/astray	Mis-lead, mis-govern
super-	High/above/better	Supernatural, superstar, superstructure
multi-	Many parts/eclectic	Multi-dimensional, multi-party
de-	To bring action back	De-robe, demote, de-emphasize
in-	The opposite of	Inappropriate, indisciplined
vice-	Assistant/deputy	Vice-chairman, vice-president
Pan-	Together/all	Pantheon, pan-African
pseudo-	Not real/false/imitation	Pseudonym, pseudopodium
out	Do something faster, better or more than...	Outnumber, outclass, outdo
inter	Between	Intercontinental, international
over-	Too much	Over-react, over-see, over-stress

arch-	Very high/great	Arch-enemy, arch-bishop
ex-	Of before/former	Ex-prisoner, ex-minister
fore-	At the front/before/prior	Fore-father, forelegs
hyper-	Beyond normal/extremely	Hypertension, hyperactive
counter-	Against/go in opposite direction	counteract
co-	With the same as	Co-tenant, co-ordinate
neo	New/modernized	Neologism, neocolonialism
bi-	Two	Biology, bilateral
di-	Two	Diagonal, diametric

Here are some **suffixes and their meanings**, too:

Suffix	Meaning	Examples
-wards	In the direction of	West-wards, backwards
-ful	Having the qualities of	Careful, faithful
-eer	Career/occupation	Engineer, seer
-ess	Feminine/female	Princess, proprietress
-like	Possessing the qualities of	Childlike, Christ-like
-hood	Empire/state	Chieftdom, fiefdom, kingdom, queendom
-less	Not having/without	Useless, countless
-ship	Condition/status	Studentship, fellowship
-en	Make to be	Straighten, brighten
-ster	Engaged in a job/work (usually evil work)	Gangster, fraudster
-ish	Having the quality or character of	Girlish, snobbish
-ist	Doer or member of	Maoist, communist
-wise	Thinking in the way of	Economy-wise, anti clock-wise
-let	Not important/small	Booklet
-ette	Small female form of something	Kitchenette, usherette
-er	Inhabitant or native of	Hong-Konger, Londoner
-ness	State, quality	Happiness, eagerness
-ism	Principle/attitude	Capitalism/Catholicism
-tion	State/action/institution	Administration, organization
-ment		

Attacking the Nearest-in-Meaning and Opposite-in-Meaning Types of Questions by Using:

THE POSITIVITY / NEGATIVITY METHOD

If you do not know the meaning of an underlined word where you have been asked to find the word nearest in meaning or word opposite in meaning to that word, you may find the following method useful.

Look at this question:

Choose the word opposite in meaning to the emboldened word

The President in his actions has proved to be sufficiently **autocratic** (a) selfish (b) slack (c) unimpressive (d) receptive.

What option did you choose? Eh! Are you sure? How did you arrive at that? Well, let us do it this way; let us use the *positivity* and *negativity* method:

Which of the options is negative; which is positive?

Yes – *positive*: **d** . *Negative*: **a, b** and **c**

Can you see that a pattern is already emerging in the word options and that, most probably, the answer can be easily seen? Well, wait a minute. What about the emboldened word in the question (**autocratic**): Is it positive or negative? Sure! Sure!! *Auto* means *operated only by self* and from *cratic*, *tic* is suffix (and an adjective). From *cratic*, we find *cracy* as base/root, which means *administration* or *government* which is run by characteristically self-opinionated people and authoritarians as different from a *democratic* government. For this, *autocratic* (not working with other people's contributed ideas but only by one's own ideas!) is a negative word. Since you are to look for an opposite word to it, it means that you are to find a positive word. Now, look at the four options whose statuses you have earlier identified; which one is positive? Yes. **D**. And gladly, that is the answer.

NOTE: Not all questions may give you the opportunity to use the principle of negativity and positivity, though!

In 2011 question 29: look for the word nearest in meaning:

The mistake brought the show to an **ignominious** end. (a) a good (b) a palatable (c) a disgraceful (d) a satisfactory
Now, look and give the status (+ or -) of each of the options: (a), (b) and (d) are +ive, but **disgraceful**; (c) is negative, so, only **c** is negative. You will quickly suspect that **ignominious** is also negative. Yes, it is negative and the equally negative option **c**, is the word nearest in meaning to it. Please, be very, very careful in using this method.

GRAMMATICAL COMPOUNDS AND PLURALS

When a word has two parts, it is called a compound word, e.g. *tea + spoon = tea-spoon*; *Accountant + General = Accountant-General*. How can these compounds be pluralised? Should we say: *Accountant-Generals* or *Accountants-General*? Should we say: *teas-spoon* or *tea-spoons*? The simple rules that guide this are the following:

1. Positions and Titles such as *Director General*, *Head of State*, *General Secretary*, *Secretary General*, etc. are to be pluralised by adding **S** to the noun part of the compound. In *Director General*, *General* is an adjective while *Director* is a noun, therefore, the plural is *Directors General* not: *Director GeneralS*
2. If the two or three words that form a compound word are all nouns, it is the last noun that will take an '**S**', e.g. *head-masters*, *tea cups* not: *heads-master (x)* or *teas cup (x)*
3. If one of the words that form a compound is an adjective, e.g. *General* in *Secretary General*, do not pluralize the adjective (*General*). Pluralize the noun, that is *Secretary*: *Secretaries-General*
4. Sometimes when the two words that form a compound are both nouns, it will be found that one of the two is performing the function of an adjective, describing the second noun, e.g. *Girl Guide*; *Boy Scout* where *Boy* only describe the type of scout. Therefore, *Girl* and *Boy*, here, are both adjectives. As you have seen in 3 (above), you cannot add an '**S**' to an adjective. So, do not add an '**S**' to *girl* or *boy*, but add an '**S**' to *Guide* = *Guides* and to *Scout* = *Girl Guides* and *Boy Scouts*.

Other compounds include:

Notaries public (Lawyers) *Brothers-in-law*, *Sisters-in-law*, *Parents-in-law*, *Auditors-General*, *Chiefs-of-staff*, *Chief-Security-Officers*, *Accountants-General*, *Boy-Brigades*, *Bitter-Sweets*, *Heads-of-State*, *Bye-laws*, *Ante-rooms*, *face-cloths*, *on-goings*, OR *Goings-on*, *Justices-of-the-peace* *on-lookers*, *By-Standers*, *post-offices*, *Skirt-Sleeves*, *Deaf-Mutes*, *Ante-Rooms*, *walking-sticks*, *Bye-Elections*, *Record-Players*, *Call-Girls*, *Dance-halls*.

Past Questions

1988 question 61; 1989 question 74; 1994 question 56

UNUSUAL PLURALS

We have looked at how to pluralise two or three words that make one compound word. Below here are other delicate words for the purpose of pluralisation. For example, what is the plural of *deer*, *sheep*, *banjo*, *wharf*, *roof*, *pik*, *phenomenon*, *oasis*... do you know?

"VES" PLURALS

The following words will end in **ves** just as *knife* is pluralised as *knives*, ending in **ves**: *sheaf*, *thief*, *calf*, *half*, *elf*, *life*, *self*, *wolf*, *shelf* and *loaf*, e.g. *loaf* – *loaves*; *calf* – *calves*.

PLURALIA TANTUMS AND THE FINAL S

Some words always appear with **s** after them. Without the **s**, the word will have no meaning at all. With the **s**, the words are NOT plurals; they are normal words. They include: *pyjamas*, *scissors*, *shears*, *spectacles*, *scales*, *binoculars*, *glasses*, *bells*, *tongs*, *pliers*, *suspenders*, *flannels*, *fight*, *shorts*, *pants* and *pincers*. The following rules apply to them:

- (1) A pair or three pairs etc can come before any of them to show number, e.g. Three pairs of pants (not: three pants) (x).
- (2) Remember to put an **s** after each of the words above otherwise, they will lose their meanings. Please note that:

A pair of shorts is on the floor

is correct and,

Five pairs of scissors are on the table

is correct, too.

Also,

- *A pair of binoculars makes vision clearer*
- *Two pairs of trousers look* (not; looks) *dirty*

TANTUM PLURALS:

There are words which look like those (above). They are always written with final **S**. They are:

riches, *odds*, *auspices*, *arrears*, *troops*, *premises*, *firework*, *ashes*, *particulars*, *entrails*, *spirits*, *bowel*, *holiday*, *outskirts*, *funds*, *goods*, *banns*, (usually marriage), *annals*, *regards*, *remains*, *headquarters*, *quarter*, *surroundings*, *wages*, *wits*, *spirits*, (feeling/mood) we may have *in good spirits* / *high spirits*, *game spirit*.

The following rules apply:

- (1) Do not remove the final **s** in the words, or they become meaningless, e.g.
 - I live in *Quarter* number **7(x)** but
 - I live in *Quarters* number 7.
- (2) Use only the plural verbs with the word above. Plural verbs are;
Are/were/have/had/do/did/take, speak, write etc. (Without an **s**, e.g.: The army **headquarters are** far away
The **premises look** (not looks) dirty.

PLURALS OF QUANTITY

To show quantity or number, we usually use: ***hundred, thousand, and million, dozen, head and stone.***

The following rules apply:

1. Do not put an **s** after *hundred, thousand* etc. if a figure comes before *hundred/thousand*, e.g.

Five hundreds (Wrong)

but;

Five hundred.

Two thousands (Wrong) but: Two thousand

- If however no figure comes before *hundred, thousand, million* etc. these words of quantity can take an '**s**' after them, e.g. *Hundreds of candidates* OR *thousands of candidatse* are going to sit for the coming UTME with me
- *Dozens of eggs* broke when they fell on the floor last night

PLURALS ENDING IN 'OES' AND 'OS'

Make sure these words end in **oes**: ***torpedo, hero, embargo, echo, veto, Negro*** and ***potato***, e.g.

- Many **Negroes** ride on **buffalos** but cannot eat **potatoes**

Make sure these words end in **os**: ***buffalo, commando, cargo, volcano, motto, banjo, Archipelago***, e.g.

- The eruption of **volcanoes** gives **echoes** of the attacks of **commandos** of last year.

VOWEL-CHANGE PLURALS

Some words change their plurals by simply dropping some vowels, including:

Tooth-teeth; man-men; woman-women; mouse-mice; goose-geese.

PLURALS FOR BORROWED WORDS

Some words that are used in English today have been borrowed from some other languages which are close to English. They include:

COMPARISON

Any time we mention 'comparison', we talk about adjectives and the different levels of their quality, for example, there are three girls in a class, with different heights. *Tall* is the adjective. The different levels are *tall*, *taller* and *tallest* (for the third one). However, not all adjectives can be easily classified into the levels they belong in. The following rules will enable you classify them appropriately.

Rules

1. Every time we use a comparative adjective, **than** must come after it. In other words, once you use **than**, you are expected to use a comparative adjective, e.g. He is **taller** than she is. (Here, we use **taller** (a comparative adjective) because **than** appears in the sentence) it is wrong to say: she is **tall** than she is. Do you get it?
2. Monosyllabic adjectives take **er** and **est** as the **comparative** and **superlative** levels as discussed below:

Word (Adjective)	Comparative	2 nd Degree	Superlative
1. Short	Shorter	Much shorter	Shortest
2. careful	More careful	Much more careful	Most careful

A question for you: Why do we have **shorter** but not **carefuller**?

A monosyllabic adjective is one that is so short that it can be pronounced at one breadth: *short, tall, big, small, old, young*, etc. The comparative adjective for all these must be adjective + **er**, e.g. *smaller, younger*, etc. while the superlative must be adjective + **est**, e.g. *smallest, youngest*, so we could have *young – younger – youngest*.

3. If we consider a **bisyllabic** adjective (an adjective that is pronounced at two heart-beats) or a **trisyllabic** adjective (an adjective that is pronounced at three heart-beats) or a **polysyllabic** adjective (an adjective that is pronounced at more than three heart-beats, the *comparative* form will, be **more** + the adjective while the *superlative* form will be **most** + the adjective, e.g.:

Word = **careful** (a two-syllable, bisyllabic adjective)

Comparative = **more** careful

Superlative = **most** careful

4. We do not use a superlative adjective when only **two** things are compared, e.g. do not say:

Lolly (1) and sherry (2) are fat but Sherry is the **fattest** (x)
say:

Sherry is the fatter.

5. Do not use adverbs of degree, that is (**too**, **very** or **so**) before a comparative or superlative adjective, e.g.

:
She is **too** fatter than Mary (x)
He is **very** shorter than Michael (x)
It is **so** uglier than mine (x)

6. Do learn the forms of the following irregular adjectives

Adjective	Comparative	2 nd degree	Superlative
Many	More	Much more	Most
Little	less	Much less	least
Good	Better	Much better	best
Bad	worse	Much worse	worst
Ill	Worse	Much worse	worst
Well	Better	Much better	best

7. Do not use **than** or a **comparative** or **superlative** adjective with any of the following adjectives because they are of the highest level of adjectives and so, cannot be compared. They include: **right**, **triangular**, **superior**, **circular**, **triangular** and **paramount** e.g.:

This chair design is more **inferior** **than** that one (x) wrong,
but:

This chair design is **inferior** to that one (correct).

8. Use **as** with **as** in comparative structures, e.g.: this is **as** good as that.

9. **Any** may be used before a comparative adjective, e.g.: "oh, Lagos is not **any** busier than Abuja (not by any stretch of imagination)

10. Use **very many more...than** to express a sharp difference in quantity comparative structures, e.g.:
We read **very many more** books in class four

Past Questions

1985q 88, 1987 q 96, 1988q 99, 1992 q 90, 2001 q 60, 2002 q 91

PRONOMINAL ITEMS (I): Reciprocal

Look at this:

- (1) **She loves me**
- (2) **I love her**

This is a sense of symbiotic reciprocity: This means, you do it to me, I do it to you! Pronouns that show this sense are only two. They are **each other** and **one another** and they are called, *Reciprocal Pronouns*.

If the sense of a one-to-one relationship is not shown in the sentence, do not use any of the above two.

Could you go back to (i) and (ii) above. Would you say the speakers in (i) and (ii) love (a) **themselves** (b) **each other** (c) **one another** (d) **their selves**

No, no, no... No! Not *themselves*.

The answer is **each other** and **one another**. Both are correct. The two are the same and mean the same thing. Now you are asking if **one another** and **each other** both appear as answer options to a question, what happens?

Yes, choose **each other** because there are two people involved. If *more than two* people / things are involved, then choose **one another** e.g.

- Mr. Adamson's four children love **one another**

But:

The newly married couple love **each other** dearly.

Note that, **themselves** means that one individual is particular about himself or herself (not about the other person or people), for example:

- At Adam's party, the ten guests enjoyed *themselves*.

Meaning: each person enjoyed himself / herself

Would you like to practise with the following past questions?

Past Questions

1999q 75, 1995 q 83

PRONOMINAL ITEMS (2): Reflexive

It is easy to identify reflexive pronouns. All reflexive pronouns end in **self** or **sel**. They are:

Subject pronoun	Object pronoun	Reflexive pronoun
He	Him	Himself
She	Her	Herself
It	It	Itself
I	Me	Myself
We	Us	Ourselves (not: ourself)
You	You	Yourself or yourselves
They	them	Themselves (not: theirselves)

Rules:

- For **one**, use oneself, e.g.;
One needs to see things by **oneself** (not: *himself*)
- For more than one person including you, use **we ourselves**
- for more than one person excluding you, use; **they themselves**
- Do not start a sentence with any reflexive pronoun, e.g.
a) *Myself* and Maryam are friends (x) wrong.
SAY:
(b) Maryam and I myself are friends (correct).
- For a non-living thing, use **itself**
- When the gender / sex of the referent is unknown, use "**himself/ himself**", together
- For someone and Angela, use **yourselves**
- For Angela alone, I will say to her: **yourself**

Would you like to practise with the following past questions?

Past Questions

1981 QUESTION 66

Asmau, did you see the snapshot of _____? (a) yourself (b) you (c) yours (d) yourselves

Answer: Read the rule above. Mentioning **Asmau** shows that only one person is involved here.

Would you see **yourself** or **yourselves**---referring to Asmau, one person only?

1990 QUESTION 75

Dan and Tina met on the ship and greeted _____ (a) one another (b) themselves (c) each other (d) theirselves

Answer: Read rule _____ above.

Note that there are two people involved and it was a do-it-to-me-and-i-do-it-to-you event.

1995 QUESTION 83

did the boys enjoy _____ when they went on vacation? (a) each other (b) one another (c) themselves (d) theirselves

Answer: Read rule _____ above.

Since you have not been told that the boys are two, you should assume that they were more than 2

2002 QUESTION 49

If one perseveres, _____

DETERMINERS:

WORDS THAT CONTROL NOUNS

Let us start with nouns. Do you still remember what a noun is about? Great! Under this topic, we shall not discuss nouns strictly but we shall critically examine words that go with nouns.

There are three types of noun to be learnt:

- (a) **singular count nouns**, e.g. Boy, child, girl, lady
- (b) **plural count nouns**, e.g. Boys, children, girls, ladies
- (c) **Uncountable Nouns or Non – count nouns or mass – count nouns**.

These three terms mean the same thing and include:

water (and all liquids), information, furniture, work, damage, luggage, baggage, equipment, money, cloth, staff, traffic, news, advice, fruit, all abstract nouns including: knowledge, ignorance, happiness, sadness, strength etc. Do you understand? Great!

So, **Boy, women** and **equipment** are in different noun categories. Good! There are some words that "walk along with" nouns. These are called **Determiners**. But, note that singular count nouns have particular types of determiners and plural count nouns have different determiners that go with them.

Uncountable nouns also have different determiners that "walk along with" them. In other words, these words that come **BEFORE** nouns usually "determine" what kind of noun (singular / plural / uncountable) that should come before it. For example:

This is a determiner. Once we have this word, it is already telling us, or "determining" what type of noun should come next, or would you say: **This** + boys / women / children / ladies? No! **This**, "determines" that *boy / woman / child / lady* should come after **this**. Are you following? Goodness!

Listed under here are the different determiners that go with different categories of noun:

DETERMINERS----and the Nouns that Go with them

Determiners

SINGULAR COUNT NOUNS, e.g.

This (not "these")
That
 My
 Your
 Our
 His
 Her
 Its (belonging to it: not, it's)
 Their
 a
 the
 each
 every
 one
 "some", either, neither, any, no

+

Boy
 woman
 teacher

 house
 school etc,

Examples

- * **This** + boy / woman (not, women / boys)
- * **Each** + boy / woman (not, women / boys)
- * **Every** + boy / woman (not, women / boys)

Another, first / second

Determiners

PLURAL COUNT NOUNS, e.g.

These
Those
 My
 Your
 Our
 His
 Her
 Its
 Their
 the
 some any, few, a few, no, first

lots of
 many
 more
 most
 all
 several
 a lot of
 a great many
 both

+

Boys
 women
 children
 teachers
 houses
 lorries etc;

Examples

- * **These** + boys / women (not, boy / woman)
- * **many** + boys / women (not, boy / woman)

Determiners

UNCOUNTABLE NOUNS, e.g.

some
 little (-)
 a little (+)
 This
 That
 My
 Your
 Our
 his
 her
 its
 their

a great deal of
 much
 any
 no
 a lot of

+

Fanta,
 equipment
 furniture
 advice
 money etc,

examples

- * **A little** + water / Fanta / furniture
not:
A little + houses / lorries X
- * **Much** + water / Fanta / furniture
not: **Much** + boys / people / children X

Determiners: The Rules

Always choose the appropriate type of noun for a given determiner e.g.

A few + (a) boy (b) boys (c) water

Choose "B".

Some (pronounced as / sim /) can be used with a singular count noun, e.g. **boy / teacher / man** etc on the condition that, that noun (mentioned) is unknown in identity to the speaker, e.g. If a man (whose name or identity I do not know) knocks at my neighbour's door, I may call my neighbour's attention, telling him or her, "Hello, some / sim / man / boy is at your door".

Apart from the condition given above, use **some** with only plural count nouns or uncountable nouns, e.g.

I saw some **boys** (plural count)

I got some **water** (uncountable noun)

4. **Few (-)** means, not many in number. If 30 children are in a class but only four came to school, that's **few students** (not many).

5. **A few (+)** means, many in number. If 30 children are in a class but 28 came to school, that's **a few students** (many).

So, try answer this:

I don't know who removed the chairs in the hall; I met just ----- there

(a) few (b) a few. Answer? No! No!! Not a **few**, a - haa, Yes: **few**: not many.

Always remember to be sure that, wherever you find **few / a few**, the noun in front of it is a plural count noun, e.g. **children / boys** not, **water / Fanta**.

6. **Little (-)**, means, not much in quantity of mass. If a drum should be full of water but we discovered only one quarter of the drum filled, that is **little water** (not much).

7. **A Little (+)** means, much. If a drum is supposed to be completely filled with water and it is discovered that it is three - quarters filled (only one quarter portion is empty), that's **a little + water** (much water). Answer this.

I didn't get to hear about events in the country up till yesterday when I bought a radio for news, so now, I will get — information (a) a little (b) little. Answer? Yes yes, yes!! Yes, it's **a little**.

Note: Remember to be sure that wherever you have **little / a little**, the noun is uncountable e.g. **coke, equipment, news** etc.

8. Do not use **(a)n** with an uncountable noun, e.g.

an information has been received **X** (wrong)

I gave him **an advice** **X** (wrong)

Note: To quantify (give number of) an uncountable noun, use **an item of / three items of / a piece of + uncountable noun**

three pieces of + uncountable noun, e.g. **three pieces of advice**

9. When **series**, group (not **groups**) set (not **sets**), **association**, **collection** **is** involved in determiners, choose **a** or **an** as may be appropriate, e.g. **a series of lectures** (not: series of lecture's...)
10. Do not use **every** with plural count nouns:
every boys **X** every Thursdays **X**
11. Do not pluralise any uncountable (non - count) nouns, e.g. informations, baggages, luggages, advices **X**: Use **a piece of**; two **pieces of**... luggage etc. Even when you use pieces of + a non - count noun, the non - count noun should not be in plural form: pieces of luggages **X**; pieces of equipments **X** (wrong) but **pieces of luggage**; **pieces of equipment** etc.
12. **Small** is not a determiner but **little** is.
-

Past Question References

1993 question 82

You think she hasn't got any friends? Of course, she's got -----

- (a) many more (b) quite much
(c) quite a few (d) few

Solution: Remember you are dealing with the noun: **friends** (plural count).
Use Law 5

1993 question 85

Do you think all ----- not enough to help the investigations?

- (a) these informations are
(b) this informations is
(c) this information is
(d) these informations are

Solution: You are dealing with **information**.
Use the appropriate determiner.
Use rule 1

1991 question 59

The Board has been having ----- series of meetings lately

- (a) some (b) a (c) a lot of (d) many

Solution: Use Law 9

1987 question 61

----- guests enjoyed Joy's birthday party

- (a) The whole (b) All the (c) Every
(d) Those very

Solution: The noun you are dealing with is **guests** (plural count).

Check under plural count nouns and look for the appropriate determiner.
Also use law 10.

1986 question 72

I'm sorry I can't give you any of the oranges. I have ----- left

- (a) few (b) little (c) only a little (d) a few

Solution: Use laws 4 and 5

1986 question 94

He decided to wait for the bus because he had -----

- (a) too many luggage (b) many luggages
(c) a lot of luggage (d) plenty luggages

Solution: Use laws 1 & 11. See the table of determiners and nouns.

1984 question 77

The principal went to buy some ----- for the physics laboratory

- (a) equipment (b) pieces of equipments
(c) equipments (d) items of equipments
(e) list of equipment

Solution: Use law 11

1983 question 64

I can't offer you another loan, I have ----- money left in my account

- (a) a few (b) a little (c) little (d) few
(e) some

Solution: You are dealing with **money** (an uncountable noun). Use laws 1,6 and 7

1981 question 64

Although the problem was simple -----
Students were able to solve it

- (a) little (b) small (c) few (d) a few
(e) a lot of

Solution: The noun in question is **Students** (plural count noun).

The fact that the problem was "simple" means **that** a lot of students should have been able to solve it but **although** as used, introduces surprise that the opposite (of **a lot of**) is the case. What is the

opposite of **a lot of**? Use laws 4 and 5.
Also use Law 12.

1981 question 83

----- Lawyers enrolled at the Nigerian Bar
last year ----- this year
(a) as much / as (b) very many / than
(c) more / than (d) some / as
(e) as many / than

Solution: Can you use **much** with **lawyers** (plural count?) Use law 1. Note, wherever there is comparison, **than** must be in the statement.

MODAL AUXILIARIES: The Laws

In what "mood" is a speaker when he or she speaks to another person: From the utterance, would you say that the speaker is the boss / superior officer to the person being spoken to? For example,

"You must not go out". One word in this clause tells us that the speaker has "social authority or power", as in the case of a boss to a junior officer, or a father to his son. The "mood" of the speaker, therefore, is "authoritative command" mood. Words that show the mood of a speaker are known as "modal auxiliary verbs". First note that these verbs are also known as "weak" verbs — another word for "auxiliary". You have seen Registered Nurses (RN) before at hospitals in white uniform. They are "main", real nurses that have undergone real, recognised training. There is another category of nurses that wear blue / green. These are of lower grades and they only help those in white uniform. In the same way, the under listed modal auxiliary verbs only "help" main verbs. Modal auxiliaries cannot stand on their own. We cannot, for example, have:

- (a) "She **will** tomorrow" or
- (b) They **can** next week

The two clauses (above) make better sense when we introduce main verbs:

- (a) She **will** + **swim** tomorrow or
- (b) They **can** + **travel** next week. Do you understand? The modal auxiliaries are the following:

	Present Tense	Past Tense
1	Can	could
2	may	might
3	shall	should
4	will	would
5	must	* had to
6	dare	dared
7	need	need
8	ought to	* had to

Take note that **had to** is the past form for both **must** and **ought to**. **Had to** is not a modal auxiliary.

Functions of Modal Auxiliary Verbs

First, study the table below. It shows you that **we** and **I** are the only "person" that can be used with **shall**.

Persons	Will	Shall
I	✓	✓
We	✓	✓
He	✓	X
She	✓	X
it	✓	X
You	✓	X
They	✓	X

- .So, (a) They **shall** travel tomorrow X (wrong)
 (b) They **will** travel tomorrow ✓ (right)
 (c) I / We **shall** travel tomorrow ✓ (right)

(1) **Will: functions**

- (a) To indicate future action
 (b) To show determination or willingness
 (c) To show consistent action of the moment
- (a) **Future action:** She **will** sing in church tomorrow
 (b) **Determination:** I **will** gain admission this year
 (c) **Consistent action:** Moriamon **will** cry and cry, day after day

Would: functions

- (a) Past tense of **will**: He **said** yesterday that he **would** (not **will**) pass his examination
 (b) It is used in polite request: **Would** you like to open the window = please open the window

(2) **Shall: functions**

- (a) **To indicate future action** of the first person, we and I only:
 We / I **shall** see you tomorrow
- (b) **To issue court or official commands**
 High Court Judge (to the accused): "You **shall** serve seven years imprisonment with hard labour for rape".
Note: Ordinarily, **shall** should not apply to **you** as indicated in the table above but if it is a court order, **they / you / he / she / it** can be used with **shall**.

Should

- (a) It is past form of **shall**:
 I promise that I **shall** pass my examination this year.
 I promised that I **should** pass my examination last year.
- (b) **To express what is expected:** You **should** keep your hair short, as a young man (it is expected of you to keep your hair short...).
- (c) **To express duty or obligation**
 You **should** not allow any car to park by the gate

- (3) **Can**
(a) **To express ability:** I **can** drive a car (I have the ability to drive a car)

Special Note: When **can** is used to show ability, **be able** should be avoided, e.g.
I **can** + **be able** to drive **X** (wrong)

But, either: I **can** drive ✓ or,
I **am able** to drive ✓

- (b) **To express opportunity**
If Tinu comes, she **can** see the Professor once and for all (she can take the opportunity of her coming to...)
- (c) **To ask permission and to give permission**
A: **Can** I open the box? (am I permitted...)
B: Yes, you **can**! (you are permitted)

Could

- (a) **To express past ability**
NOT: This man **can** drive before **X** but:
This man **could** drive before but **cannot** drive again
I **could** (not: **can**) when I was young

- (b) **To express request**
Could you show me the way to the post – office

(4) May: Functions

- (a) **To ask permission politely**
May I use your umbrella?
- (b) **To give permission**
You **may** use my umbrella whenever you need it
- (c) **To express wish or prayer**
May God bless you!
- (d) **To show possibility**
It **may** rain before night fall (it is possible...)

Might: Functions

- (a) As past form of **may**
I **asked** him if I **might** (not: **may**) use his umbrella (because of "asked")
- (b) **To express possibility**
He **might** see you; keep off (it is possible for him to see you if you do not keep off)

5. Must: Functions

- (a) **To give commands of force**
You **must** report to this office everyday!
- (b) **To establish a rule, fiat or law**
All pedestrians **must** climb the footbridge; no one is allowed to cross at the busy road!

(c) may have being (d) will have been

Solution: Use law 1

2003 question 29

If you saw the photograph of the man ----- you be able to identify him?

(a) could (b) would (c) can (d) will

Solution: Remember you cannot use **could** or **can** with **be able** (law 4). Now use Law 1

1991 question 85

He ----- by now, I can hear all the people shouting

(a) would have arrived

(b) must have arrived (c) has arrived

(d) should have arrived

Solution: Use Law 8

1990 question 65

The lecturer said that we ----- be able to finish the next chapter this evening

(a) must (b) can (c) shall (d) should

Solution: Use Law 1. note the use of **said** above in the question

1990 question 64

I would have been off to see Biola at Festac Town by the time you ----- tomorrow

(a) returned (b) return (c) are returning

(d) would have arrived

Solution: Would (past modal) is already used. Your answer should be a past tense main verb, in line with law 1.

1987 question 72

We have done three quarters of the journey already. We ----- as well see the end of it.

(a) can (b) might (c) could (d) may

Solution:

The action expected above (to finish the journey is still in the future). Which would you rather choose: **past** modal or **present** modal? **Present** modals are for the future use rule 9. Check the functions of **may** and **can** again to choose as appropriate.

1987 question 84

Student: must we complete the assignment before lunch?

Teacher: No, you -----

(a) needn't (b) mustn't (c) can't

(d) shouldn't

Solution: Note the use of **must**; use law 6

1985 question 80

Gone are the days when he ----- enjoy patronage

(a) would (b) will (c) used to (d) could

Solution:

Will is used for habitual action: e.g. The girl **will** come here and cry and cry and cry (means, it is her habit). However, notice from the tone of the question "gone are the days..." so, **will** should change to? Use law 10

1984 question 88

Evelyn: I've submitted eight copies

Joseph: You ----- eight. Three would have been enough

- (a) can't have submitted (b) couldn't have submitted (c) didn't need to submit
(d) needn't have submitted
(e) must have submitted

Solution:

In what other way can this be put: You need not have submitted eight copies?

1983 question 91 The mechanic said that he ----- mend my car before Saturday

SPELLING RIGHT

	WORD/PHRASE (CORRECT)	WORD/PHRASE (INCORRECT)	COMMENTS
1	Length	Lenght	th not ht
2	Strength	Strenght	th not ht
3	modern	mordern	no r before dern
4	maintenance	maintainance	maintain (verb) is correct
5	Grateful	Greatful	Grateful. Not :Greatful
6	Dining (table / hall)	Dinning	Dining means, relating to, eating
7	Christian	Christain	ti not ta
8	Convenient	Convinient	e, not i
9	Grievances	Grieviances	no i before ances
10	Mischievous	Mischievous	no i before ous
11	Argument	Arguement	no e before ment
12	lovable	Loveable	no a before ble
13	occurrence	ocurence / occurrence	oc ² + r ²
14	Recurrence	Reoccurrence / reoccurrence	re + c ² minus o + r ² notice no o before ur
15	occur	occour	g + ea, not, g + a
16	changeable	changable	ti, not ta
17	Digestible	Digestable	gea, not ga
18	Marriageable	marriagable	
19	Travelling	Traveling	Traveling is American
20	Kidnapped /	Kidnaped /	English, use ll (British).
21	Kidnapping	Kidnapping	Kidnaped is American
22			

23	Equalled	Equaled	English; use
24	counsellor	counselor	PP (B r E).
25	colour	color	Equaled is AmE; use ll (BrE)
26	Humour	humor	Counselor is AmE; use ll (BrE)
27	favour	favor	Color is AmE; use ou (BrE)
28	labour	labor	Humor is AmE; use ou (BrE)
29	habour	harbor	favor is AmE; use ou (BrE)
30	axe	ax	labor is AmE; use ou (BrE)
31	plough	plow	diarrea is AmE; oea. ea r²
32	programme	program	Encyclopedia is AmE; use
33	sceptic	skeptic	hemoglobin is AmE; use ae (BrE).
34	Catalogue	catalog	ter is AmE; use ter (BrE)
35	Diarrhoea	diarrhea	ter is AmE; use ter (BrE)
36	Encyclopaedia	encyclopedia	ter is AmE; use ter (BrE)
37	Haemoglobin	hemoglobin	ger is AmE; use gre (BrE)
38	kilometre	kilometer	
39	centre	center	
40	theatre	theater	
41	Meagre/ Rheumatism	meager rheumatism	
42		rheumatism	
43	Debris	debri	Debri is pronounced: /deh-bri/
	Receive	recieve	ei not, ie
44	Deceive	decieve	ei not, ie
45	Bouquet	bounquet	Bouque (of flower) is pronounced as / buu – kei / (improvised pronunciation).

46	Wednesday	Wed-nesday	Wednesday is pronounced: / wen – s – dei /.
47	Lieutenant	Lutanant	pronounced: /lef – te – nant/.
48	Committee	Comitte /committee	e: $m^2 + t^2 + e^2$
49	Connoisseur	Conisseur	note: $n^2 + s^2$
50	Chauffeur	Chaufeur	chauffeur is pronounced as / shor – for /.
51	Rendezvous	rondevous	rendezvous is pronounced as/ ron – di – vu /.
52	Corps	cops	corps is pronounced as / kor – or /.
53	Corps member	corper	there is no word as corper in English.
54	Martyr	Martiah	Martyr is pronounced as mar – ta – ia
55	Diaphragm	diaphram	(note the g before m)
56	Etiquette	etiquete	$t^1 + t^2$, not $t^2 + t^1$
57	Sergeant	sergent	ea not e
58	Pneumonia	nimonea	not the p and eu
59	Champagne	champein	champagne is pronounced as / sh – am – pe – in /, not / cham – pag – neh /.
60	Cologne	colone	cologne is pronounced as /ko– lo – un/, not /ko–log– neh/
61	Accommodation	Acommodation Accomodation Accommondation	$= CC = C^2 + mm = m^2$
62	Pronunciation	pronounciation	note: pronounce = noun but pronunciation = nun
63	Privilege	priviledge previlege privelege	no d at all. Also, ri – vi not re – vi or ri – ve

63	Guitar	jitar	Guitar is pronounced with the g as the g in girl: / giita /.
64	Forty	fourty	or not our but four is our
65	Thief	theif	ie not ei
66	Truly	trully	l¹ not l²
67	Psalm	sam	(do not pronounce the p : / sam /)
68	Psychology	sychology	(„ „ „ the p : / saikoloji /)
69	Asthma	Asma	note the th
70	Separate	Seperate	pa not pe!
71	Manoeuvre	Manovre	note: oeuvr not, ovr
72	Depot	Depo	Depot is pronounced as
73	Neighbour	Neibough	/ deh – pou /.
74	Ceiling	Cieling	ei not ie
75	Catarrh	Cartagh	... r² + h minus gh
76	Hippopotamus	Hipoppotemus	pp + p¹ = p² + p¹. ta (not: te)
77	Comm	Commision/ comition	m² + s²

63	Guitar	gitar
64	Forty	fourty
65	Thief	theif
66	Truly	trully
67	Psalm	sam
68	Psychology	sychology
69	Asthma	Asma
70	Separate	Seperate
71	Manoeuvre	Manovre
72	Depot	Depo
73	Neighbour	Neibough
74	Ceiling	Cieling
75	Catarrh	Cartagh
76	Hippopotamus	Hipoppotemus
77	Comm	Commision/ comition

Guitar is pronounced with the **g** as the **g** in girl: / giita /.

or not **our** but **four** is **our**

ie not **ei**

l¹ not **l²**

(do not pronounce the **p**: / sam /)

(„ „ „ the **p**: / saikoloji /)

note the **th**

pa not **pe**!

note: **oeuvr** not, **ovr**

Depot is pronounced as / deh – pou /.

ei not **ie**

... **r² + h** minus **gh**

pp + **p¹** = **p² + p¹**. **ta** (not: **te**)

m² + s²

HOMOPHONES: THE SAME-SOUND WORDS

Comments

Word	Similar sound	Comments
78 Thrown	Throne	Thrown is past participle of throw Throne is the seat of a king
79 Their	There	Their means, belonging to them; There is opposite of here
80 This	These	This is used for a singular noun These for a plural noun: This boy; these boys
81 stationEry	stationAry	Stationary means, static, stagnant, not moving while stationery is paper, pads, pen etc.
82 seat	sit	sit is verb but seat can be both a verb and a noun: I had my seat (not sit) near the door. I took my seat = I sat down. The car can seat (verb) five people.
83 section	session	section is "a part" of a longer thing while session is the period of an activity, e.g. schooling session / court session.
84 safe	save	safe means far away from danger while save means, prevent from wastage. Safe journey! Save your money.
85 sell	sale	Sell is verb: give something in exchange for money: He sells shoes Sale is a noun. The sale of shoes gives him daily bread
86 price	prize	Price is the cost of something; Prize is a gift that is usually won after a competition.
87 order	other	Order means, "so as to" / in line with e.g. I went to school in order to be educated. Other means, second version of a thing already mentioned: This is one; that is the other one

88	nationalise	naturalise	If someone takes the citizenship of another country, they are naturalised but to nationalise is to make something belong, as "property" to a nation. Mr. Ghandi from India has naturalised in Nigeria. After this, the Indian government protested by nationalising his house.
89	Juncture	Junction	Juncture means, a point in discussion or stretch of time but Junction is a place where two or more roads meet. At this juncture (not, junction) of our nation's history, we should play good politics.
90	Knee	Kneel	Knee is noun, meaning, the hard part below the thigh of an animal while kneel is verb meaning, bending the leg, resting on the knee. This is also genuflect.
91	Guard	Guide	Guard is, protect; guide is to tailor or lead towards something. The house is guarded by Alsatian dogs. This book can guide you to the university.
92	faith	fate	faith is belief in an idea, concept or percept but fate means, destiny: He has faith in God. He met a terribly bad fate last night in the hands of armed robbers.
93	cease	seize	cease is to stop; seize is to confiscate, hold; prevent owner of something from having it: The noise that went through the night has ceased. No one can seize my books; they belong to me.
94	Border	bother	Border is, to "partain to", to "have to do with" while bother is to trouble someone, e.g. Our discussion bordered on passing the UME. Andy bothers me with petty problems.
95		coerce / course	Coarse means, rough, unrefined, rude

(esp. of voice) while **coerce** means, to "force". **Course** is the period of action or an area of academic study in a college.

Both are verbs. **defuse** is to make a bomb unable to explode while **diffuse** is to make something (like tear gas) to be released in different directions).

Running means, one, following the other or the act of athletics and sprinting while **runny** refers to the excessive production of water in the eyes or mucus in the nose, as a result of infection or cold.

Whereas **querulous** (r¹, l¹) means, uncomfortable, irritated, complaining **garrulous** (g + r² + l¹) means, speaking too much.

While advise is a verb, advice is a noun.

While **sheer** means, "ordinary" **share** means, to divide and apportion things to people. **Shears** is an instrument like scissors for cutting grass and flowers while **cheers** means, greetings.

While **respectful** means, (of a person) showing regard and respect to others, **respective** means, one tallying with its appropriate partner, e.g. Tae and Kehinde have gone into classes two and four, **respectively**. This means, Tae went into class two, Kehinde into class four. **Respectable** means, deserving to be given respect, e.g. Governors are respectable individuals.

Walks of life (from different areas of human activities). **Works** on the other hand means, artisan's engagement e.g. shoemaking, electrical repairs etc.

Moral means, having to do with manners. **Morale** means, 'sense of courage', while **mural** means, painting done on a wall.

104	Live / laive /	Live / liv /	Live / laiv / means, (of activity) done at the present time of its viewing. Live / liv / is the present tense of lived while Life / laif / means, existence.
105	rite	right / rights	Right is opposite of left or it means, not wrong; correct while rite means special ceremony. Rights means, entitlement or authority (over something).
106	robbing	rubbing	Robbing is carrying out the activity of stealing while rubbing is passing one's palm over a surface as if caressing it.
107	site	sight / cite	Cite is to mention, site is a new place for building a housing project while sight is the power of seeing with the eyes.

Past Question References

2006 question 32

Did you have ----- when you went to visit the medical doctor?

(a) diarrhoea (b) diarrhae (c) diarhoea

(d) diarhea

Solution: Use resource number 33 above.

2005 question 84

A nursery rhyme is used to teach pupils how to spell the word -----

(a) hipoppotemus (b) hippoppotemus

(c) hipoppotamous (d) hippopotamus

Solution: Use resource number 76

2004 question 36

All God's prophets were given the great

(a) commision (b) commition (c) comission

(d) commission

Solution: Use resource number 77 (above)

2003 question 43

I have the ----- of meeting the president

(a) priviledge (b) privelege

(c) previlege (d) privilege

Solution: Use resource number 62

2003 question 44

The Sergeant spoke to me in a ----- manner.

(a) coarse (b) casual (c) coerce

(d) course

Solution: Use resource number 95 (above)

2001 question 93

The police came early enough to ----- bomb planted by the rioters

(a) diffuse (b) insulate (c) detonate

(d) defuse

Solution: Use resource number 96 (above)

1999 question 60

The visitor was very uncomfortable because of his ----- nose

(a) runny (b) running (c) watery

(d) flowing

Solution: Use resource number 97

1999 question 57

They were all behaving like a bunch of ----- children

(a) querulous (b) querrulous

(c) querrullous (d) quarrelous

Solution: Use resource number 98 (above).

1994 question 97

My ----- is for you to refuse the ----- of the wicked

(a) advise / advice (b) advice / advice

(c) advise / advise (d) advise / advise

Solution: Use resource number 99

1992 question 61

The physicians have more people in ----- waiting rooms than ----- have ever had

(a) his / he (b) there / they

(c) their / they (d) them / them

Solution: Use resource number 79

1991 question 81

The attitude of my students to ----- baffles me.

(a) pronounciation (b) pronounciation

(c) pronouceation (d) pronounceation

Solution: Use resource number 61 (above).

1991 question 80

The patience is suffering from -----

(a) reumatism (b) rheumantism

(c) rhuematism (d) rheumatism

Solution: Use resource number 40

1991 question 79

The story on the lost jewel was quite -----

(a) unbelievable (b) unbeliveable

(c) unbelieveable (d) unbelivable

Solution: Use resource A2

1991 question 78

Ebun Ojo ----- international fame as an actress

(a) aquired (b) acquired (c) acquared

(d) acquired

Solution: Use resource A1 (above)

1991 question 77

The man rose to an important position as a result of ----- hard work

(a) sheer (b) cheer (c) share (d) shear

Solution: Use resource number 100

THE VERBAL GROUP (VG) :

VERBS, AND HOW THEY ARE USED IN SENTENCES

Verbum! That is the Latin word for *verbs*. *Verbum* means, the most important word. This means that, verbs are very important in written or spoken communication. If there is a group of words that has no verb, the group is like tea without sugar, soup without salt or a body without a head. There is no meaningful communication without a verb, e.g.:

- All in the name of fashion
- On the streets and in the house
- The man in white shirt

All above are messages that are not complete in sense because none of the three has a verb. But imagine:

- Girls **wear** skimpy dresses, all in the name of fashion
- Peace **is** on the streets and in the house
- The man in white shirt **has** a blue car

The three above are made complete in sense because of the introduction of **wear**, **is** and **has**, which are in different categories of verbs.

Let us quickly look at the different types of verb:

- (a) **Primary Auxiliary:** Be — is / was / are / were / am / been / being
Look at this table:

Noun (phrase) Singular	Pronoun	Present Tense (now)	Past Tense (yesterday)
Austin	He	is	was
Cinderella	She	is	
The car	it	is	
Self	I	am	
Plural	Pronoun	Present Tense (now)	Past Tense (yesterday)
Austin and Ojo	They	Are	were
Linda and I	We		
Other people	You		

is

We use **is** to refer to only one thing, person or place, if what we are talking about is still present, e.g. she / he / it **is** in the house, **now**.

was

This is the past form of **is** just the way **went** is the past form of **go**. It is also used for only one thing, person or place, if what we are talking about is already past. So, look at the difference:

He **is** here **Now**.

He **Was** here **Yesterday**.

Please always watch out and be careful. Consider when the action you are talking about takes place – is it in the present time or in the past? Then, choose between **was** and **is**.

Are

Are is used for at least, two people, things or places if what we are talking about is still in the present. For example,

We / they / you + **are** here **now**.

Now shows it is still present.

Were

Were is used when we refer to at least two things, places or people, if the action we describe is already past. In other words, **were** is the past form of **are** and they are both used when there are two or more nouns or if the pronoun is plural, for example,

We **were** there **last year**

last year shows past time, **we**, shows plurality.

but,

We **are** here **now**. (**Now** shows present time).

Am

Is is used to refer to yourself only, if what we are talking about is still in the present tense for example,

I **am** dancing **now**

The past form of **am** is **was**. For example,

I **am** here **now**. I **was** here **yesterday**.

yesterday shows past time.

I think you now understand!

A little trick I will teach you for using primary auxiliaries or verbs in general is, whenever you make any statement, do indicate the time of action at the end of the sentence. For example,

I **know** him **now**.

I **knew** him **yesterday**.

I **will** see him **tomorrow**.

Doing this will enable you correct yourself if you have used a wrong verb. Now, under verbs, the four categories of verbs you can have are, again:

Lexical, anomalous, modal auxiliary and primary auxiliary verbs.

Please learn all of them properly.

(b)

Modal Auxiliary verbs

These verbs are eight in number, with their present and past forms, totalling 16:

1991 question 46

Jimoh is noted for his ----- attitude to his seniors at school

- (a) receptive (b) respectful
(c) respective (d) respectable

Solution: Use resource number 101

1990 question 72

I have the -----of meeting him

- (a) previlege (b) privilege
(c) priviledge (d) previledge

Solution: Use resource number 62

1989 question 68

Many unrelated issues were touched upon in the ----- of the discussion

- (a) cause (b) course (c) coarse (d) curse

Solution: Use resource number 95 (above)

Other past question references include:

1987 questions 60, 59 and 92. **1986** questions 85, 84, 83, 82, 79 and 70. **1985** questions 95, 93, 92, 91 and 90. **1984** questions 100, and 61. **1983** questions 87 and 54. **1982** question 46. **1981** question 41 and 27. **1978** question 94.

Present Tense**Past Form**

Will
may
can
shall
ought to
must
dare
need

would
might
could
should
had to
had to
dared
need

Please note that **had to** is not a modal auxiliary verb but it is the natural past form for **ought to** and **must**, e.g.

- (a) **Now:** I **must** attend the meeting (present time)
(b) Last week, I **had to** attend the meeting (past tense). Is this clear?

(c) Lexical Verb

This is a verb which shows real action, e.g. 'speak', 'write', 'dance', 'smoke', you can see the action practically or you imagine it.

A verb can be singular or plural.

- i. It is **singular** if it carries 's' at the back e.g.
takes, writes, sings. **Formular = Lexical Verb + 's'**.
ii. It is **plural** if it does not carry 's' at the back e.g.
take, sing, etc.

Formular = Lexical Verb minus 's' = LV - s

(b) Anomalous Verb

The set includes: **has, have** and **had**.

Now, dear, note that:

- i. **Has** is singular.
ii. **Have** is plural.
iii. **Had** is the past tense of both 'has' and 'have', just the same way 'went' is the past tense of 'go'.
- He **has** a car **now**.
 - He **had** a car last year.
 - We all **have** our cars.

Here '**had**' above shows that what is described is past and so we use 'last year'.

Noun/Noun phrase	Pronoun	Singular	Plural	Past
Bill Milly London	He She It	Has		had
James and John Tim, Jim and myself (Addressing) other people Self	They We You I		Have	had

So from this table, we can conclude that it is wrong to say: 'He **have**' or 'They **has**', because in front of 'he', 'she', 'it', we have **has** and in front of 'they', 'we', 'you', 'I', we have, **have**. But we can say 'he', 'she', 'it' + **had**. Or 'they', 'we', 'you', 'I' + **had**. So 'had' can be used with both a singular noun and plural noun.

Had is the past tense of 'has' and 'have', provided that what we are talking about is already past.

Is it clear up to this level? If you are not sure, go over it again.

Under this topic, structure questions which test the candidate's ability to use the appropriate type of verbs: **is / was / were / am / been / being / will / shall** (etc), **goes** or **go**, takes or **take / come** or **coming**, **went** and **gone** etc are found.

In other words, when can we use the **ing** verb? when can we use the past tense **went**? When can we use the past participle verb **gone**? When can we use **being** and when can you use **been**? Do you follow? The following laws may be of help:

1. Use **been** when you have **has / have** or **had** before, e.g. He has + been. Do not use **been** if you have **is / was / are / were / am** before **been**, e.g. He is + been X (wrong)

2. Use **being** when you have **is / was / are / were** or **am** before **being**, e.g. We are + **being** (not: **been**) beaten now.

Do not use **being** if you have **has / have** or **had** before **being**, e.g. They **have** + **being** X (wrong)

3. Use the past tense verb if

(a) **It is a subjunctive mood.** The subjunctive mood is the unreal situation of "assumption", e.g. I am a man, not a woman. However, I can "assume" that I am a woman, to be able to explain off a point.

In that case, **am** will change to **past: was** or **were** (both are correct, here):

If I **was / were** a woman, I would dazzle my husband. Notice the use of **would** in the second part of the sentence, not **will** (which is present tense).

(b) **Use past tense** if the event has gone past in time:

I **am** here → I **was** here

We **are** there → we **were** there

I **see** you → I **saw** you.

Do you understand the simple law?

(c) Use the **past tense** once you use **I / we / you / they + wish + subject**, So, the formula is:

I / we / you / they + wish + subject + past tense

e.g. **we** wish **we** learnt French in school.

(d) Use the past tense with: **It is time / it is high time**, e.g.

• It is **time / high time** they stopped (not, stop) disturbing us

But consider:

She **said** it was time / high time she **left** (not: leave)
 She **says** it is time / high time she left (not: leave)

(e) Use the past tense with **would rather**:

formula =

person + **would rather** + subject + past tense +

- | | | | | |
|-------|------|---------------------|-----|---|
| | ↓ | ↓ | ↓ | ↓ |
| (i) | She | would rather | we | went (not: go) next week |
| (ii) | I | would rather | she | accepted (not: accept) to marry me |
| (iii) | They | would rather | he | knew (not: know) the answer |

However, if there is no subject after **would rather**, the structural formula changes, like this:

person + **would rather** + ∅ subject + past tense +

- | | | | | |
|-------|------|---------------------|---|----------------------------|
| | ↓ | ↓ | ↓ | ↓ |
| (ii) | I | would rather | — | go (not: went) tomorrow |
| (iii) | They | would rather | — | come (not: came) next week |

(f) Use the past tense with past modal

Once one of the two clauses of a sentence starts or contains **would** (past for **will**), or **should** (past for **shall**), or **could** (past for **can**), or **might** (past for **may**) etc, the verb of the second clause must be in past form, too:

e.g.: If I **saw** (not: see) you I **would** (not: will) greet you.

If I **see** (not: saw) you, I **will** (not: would) greet you.

This principle is called **Verb Sequence** or tense balancing: the tense in clause A determines the tense in clause B.

So, always watch and determine the tense (present, or past) in which the verb of clause A is, to choose the appropriate verb in clause B. Okay?

So use the present tense modal when you have a present tense main verb, e.g. **says**.

4. Do not use the **ing** with the following verbs. The verbs are called **Stative Verbs**. This means that they are not physically demonstrable verbs. An example is **understand**. If you "understand" something, it is difficult for another person to see the action of "understand" in your brain. But if you "walk", everybody sees your action — walk is physically demonstrable. It is a "dynamic" verb. Stative verbs are the following:

(a) **Verbs relating to feelings:**

love, like, adore, hope, hate, detest, abhor, prefer, want, dislike, feel, desire, forgive, mind (do not accept).

(b) **Verbs relating to brain action:**

know, understand, agree, doubt, recognise, trust, see, remember, recollect, believe, find, hear.

(c) **Verbs not classified:**

possess, resemble, seem, need, contain, have, matter, suffice, stand, belong, consist.

It is therefore grammatically wrong to say, 'speak on, I am **believing** you' or, I am **hearing** you, speak on X. instead, say, I **believe** you, speak on, and:

- I (can) hear you, speak on.
I am **seeing** you for the second time **X** (should become: This is the second time I have **seen** you).
5. After **has / have / had**, the verb to follow must be past participle, e.g.
Not: They **have went** **X** (wrong) but:
They have **gone** ✓
He **has + left** the house ✓, not:
He has **leave** the house **X** (wrong).
6. After **do / do not / does not / did, did not /**, use a present tense verb:
 - I **did + see** (not: **saw**) them last night
 - He **does not + know** (not: **knew**) the answer
 - We **did not + speak** to them yesterday, not:
 - We **did not + spoke / spoken** to them **X** (wrong)
7. Use **since** with **have**
I **have** been in school **since** (not: **for**) the morning
8. Use **for** with a stretch of time, e.g.
They have been on the queue **for** four hours (stretch of time)
9. Use **is / was / are / were / am + supposed + ...**

↓ ↓
 (a) I **am supposed + to go now**
 Not:
 (b) I **suppose + to go now**

 Note **supposed** in clause 9a. Not: I am **suppose** **X** or I **suppose ... X**
10. Use **asleep**, not **sleeping**
She is **sleeping** **X** but
She is **asleep** ✓
Also, not: she has **slept** but:
She **has gone** to bed
11. Do not use **can** and **be able to**, together:
I can be able to do it **X** (wrong) say:
 (a) I **can do** it ✓ OR,
 (b) I **am able to do** it, never **can be able** together
12. Use **shall** with only **I** and **we**.
He **shall go** **X** but
He **will go**
I **shall go** ✓
We **shall go** ✓
They **shall come** **X** but:
They **will come** ✓
So, of all: **he / she / it / we / you / they**, only **I** and **we** can attract **shall**
13. **With a view to + ing verb**

She went to France **with a view to learning** French. Notice that, after **to** in the statement above, an **ing** verb follows. Under normal circumstances, after **to**, the next verb should be present tense, learn:

I want **to + learn** (not: learning) French ✓
So, when an **ing** verb comes after **to**, it is a special condition. So, **with a view to** is a special condition. Other special conditions for an **ing** verb after **to** are: **swear to, confess to, object to, is / was / are / were / am + used to, look forward to, admit to, is / was / are / were / am + accustomed to, feel up to, is / was / are / were / am + limited to**

Note: after each of the expressions above, use an **ing** verb, e.g.
They **admitted to + stealing** votes during the election

One can admit **to not + ing** e.g. she admitted **to not praying** enough

14. After a preposition, use the **ing** verb, e.g.
for / by / on / in from / at / over / against / between / concerning / under / beneath
/ before / in front of / through / past etc, + **ing**, e.g.
For coming (not: come) late to school, he was punished
By caring (not: care / cared) for the poor, mother Theresa became popular.
15. Like / hate / mind / help + **ing** verb
I like **sprinting** but hate **jumping**
After the tough football match, I could not **help shaking** the player's hands
(meaning, "I found it very appropriate to shake ...")
16. If the verb in clause 1 is in present tense the verb in the second clause should be in present tense but if the verb in clause 1 is in past form, the verb in clause 2 should be in past form: I **looked** on as he **washed**
He **looks** on as she **washes**
Do you understand? Never:
I **looked** on as he **washes** X (wrong)
17. When a future time is denoted or shown by the use of **by** + the future time, **will + have + a past participle** verb must be used, e.g.
By December this year, I **will + have + gained** admission to a university.
18. In some cases, the two clauses that make up a sentence may each have modal auxiliaries. They must however follow "verb sequence", that is, be balanced in their tenses: If you **would** cook my meals I **should** recommend you for promotion (**would** and **should** are both past modal forms).
19. If an activity is habitual or frequent, use the present tense
Ajantala always ----- in the morning before going to school
(a) prayed (b) **prays** (c) being pray (d) pray. **B** is correct
20. After **having**, a past participle verb must be used, e.g.
Having **eaten**, he went out
In case of an occasion to choose between **been** and **being** after **having**, choose **been**, please!
21. **Had** may sometimes be used to mean **got**. **Had**, as used here may be used after **has** or **have**, e.g. He **has had** a chance

They **have had** a child. **Had** can come before **had** provided there are two events to report: He **had had** (got) my message before he left the house. (2 messages).
Haven't can come before **had** (got).
 We **haven't had** a rest since the morning

22. Primary auxiliaries + **ing**, (that is, **is / was / are / were / am + ing**) may be used to indicate future action:

She **is going** to dance tomorrow at the concert

23. When **used to** is used, the activity was in the past; no more. If **is / was / are / were / am** comes before **used to**, an **ing** verb must follow **used to**, e.g.

I am
 We are
 She is } used to shouting everyday

There is no English expression as "use to"

24. After **has / have / had**, the verb to follow must be past participle

He **has gone**

They **have stolen** it (not: **steal** it)

25. In passive sentences, **is / was / are / were** and **am** are to have past participle verb in front of them

The car **was** + driven (not: **drive** or **drove**)

The schools **were** + built (not: **build**)

26. **Lie**, that is to put oneself in a sleeping position has **lay** as past tense and **lain** as past participle. I **lay** on my bed yesterday.

I had **lain** before Tankeh came in.

When **lie** means to say untruth, **lied** is both the past and past participle forms of it.

When, however, a bird produces eggs, **lay** is present, **laid** is both past tense and past participle. The duck **laid** its eggs near my window.

27. **Hang** is a verb which means, to raise up high and left to dangle. If a human being is involved, the past tense is **hanged**, past participle, **hanged** but if non-living things are involved, **hung** is past tense, **hung** is past participle.

His clothes have been **hung** (not: **hunged / hanged**)

Past Question References

2007 question 87

My father has been away on a journey but my mother says she ----- he ----- this Friday

- (a) expects / would arrive
 (b) expected / will arrive
 (c) expects / will arrive
 (d) expected / would arrive

Solution: Apply Law 3F

2007 question 82

I look forward to ----- you next week

- (a) seen (b) seeing (c) be seeing (d) see

Solution: Apply Law 13

2007 question 75

If he arrived late, everyone ----- him

- (a) would have blamed (b) will blame
 (c) would blame (d) must blame

Solution: Use Law 3F

2007 question 72

He says he ----- find me a job, but will accommodate me

- (a) could not (b) was not able to
 (c) is not able to (d) cannot be able to

Solution: Use Law 11 and 3F

2006 question 33

Your performance will improve if you ----- hard

- (a) are practising (b) practical
 (c) would practice (d) practise

Solution:

2006 question 37

I watched him as he ----- the hole

- (a) dug (b) digs (c) is digging
(d) dugged

Solution: Apply Law 16

2005 question 82

By the end of the football match today, we -
----- the best player

- (a) could have known
(b) might have known (c) will have known
(d) would have known

Solution: Use Law 17

2005 question 75

We won't leave until it ----- raining

- (a) will stop (b) stopped (c) stops
(d) has stopped

Solution: Use Law 3F

2005 question 41

If you would do me this favour, I ----- be
very grateful

- (a) should (b) would (c) shall (d) will

Solution: Apply Law 18

2005 question 49

Adika ----- a message from the club
regularly

- (a) receives (b) had received (c) receive
(d) has received

Solution: Apply Law 19

2001 question

----- told of his impending arrival, I worked
hard to make his short stay very
comfortable

- (a) Have being (b) Having been
(c) Have been (d) Having being

Solution: Use Law 20

2001 question 89

This villagers ----- to grow rice

- (a) used (b) are used (c) were used
(d) use

Solution: Use Law 23

2000 question 42

We are all hungry, we ----- anything to eat
since morning

(a) didn't have (b) hadn't had
Solution: Use rule 21

1999 question 52

After two years of courtship, Jide is finally
----- Ngozi next week

- (a) being married to (b) marrying
(c) married to (d) being married by

Solution: Apply Law 22

1998 question 96

I have already ----- the picture on the
sitting - room wall

- (a) hanged (b) hunged (c) hang
(d) hung

Solution: Use Law 27

1996 question 86

The driver of the car admitted ----- a
licence

- (a) to not having (b) not having
(c) not to having (d) not to have

Solution: Use Law 13

1996 question 85

Her mother said to her 'I ----- the dinner
now'

- (a) would rather you cooked
(b) would rather you cook
(c) would rather you not cook
(d) would rather you have cooked

Solution: Use Law 3E

1996 question 84

It's time the room ----- . It looks awful

- (a) is redecorated (b) was redecorated
(c) is being redecorated
(d) has being redecorated

Solution: Apply Law 3D

1996 question 75

What saved her was that she ----- to the
side of the boat

- (a) had clinged (b) clung (c) clinged
(d) clang

Solution: Use Law 16. You have
already found **saved**. Look
for the other part.

1994 question 89

School buildings that ----- in 1950 -----

(a) were build / are (b) were built / are
(c) were built / is (d) are built / are
Solution: Use Law 25

1994 question 69

The old man couldn't help ----- at his grandson's babblings

- (a) to laugh (b) that he laughed
(c) laughing (d) in laughing

Solution: Apply Law 15

1994 question 62

If the boys arrived early enough, the match -----

- (a) would have been played
(b) will be played (c) will have to be played
(d) would be played

Solution: Apply Law 3F

1993 question 86

Do you prefer ----- my rickety car

- (a) going on foot to taking
(b) to go on foot to taking
(c) going on foot than taking
(d) to go on foot than taking

Solution: Use Law 13

1992 question 63

Four engineers ----- on this system since March

- (a) worked (b) are working
(c) had worked (d) have been working

Solution: Apply Law 7

1991 question 70

How I wish ----- my mother's advice

- (a) had heeded (b) have heeded
(c) heed (d) will heed

Solution: Use Law 3C

1991 question 92

Asabe is overdue for retirement as she ----- in this college since 1954

- (a) is teaching (b) has been teaching
(c) taught (d) was teaching

Solution: Apply Law 7

1991 question 91

Sibi ----- novels since she came home

- (a) is reading (b) had been reading
(c) has read (d) has been reading

Solution: Apply Law 7

1990 question 74

Now I am used ----- bread without butter

- (a) to eat (b) in eating (c) of eating
(d) to eating

Solution: Use Law 13

1990 question 61

After Jerry had made the bed, he ----- on it

- (a) layed (b) laid (c) lied (d) lay

Solution: Use Law 26. You need a past tense verb there.

1989 question 96

Although I am watching television, I ----- what you are saying

- (a) am hearing (b) can hear
(c) have heard (d) was hearing

Solution: Use Laws 4A, B & 4C

Other Past Question References include:

2004 question 37, 41. 1998 question 97. 1993 question 95. 1988 question 66, 74, 79 and 89. 1986 question 100, 95 and 90. 1985 question 84, 81. 1984 question 97, 85, 84, 83, 82, 81, 80 and 69. 1983 question 93, 69, 67, 66, 63, 62, 57, 56, 55, 47, 45 and 42. 1982 question 78, 75, 62, 60, 59, 54, 50, 40, 38, and 36. 1981 question 72, 71, 66, 36, 34 and 33. 1980 question 84, 64, 62, 57, and 55. 1979 question 89, 84, 83 and 30. 1978 question 93, 91, 89, 63, 61 and 49.

APOSTROPHE and POSSESSIVE NOUNS:

The Laws

Possessive nouns are used in showing what human beings and animals have (possess). They are not applicable to possessions of non – living things. For example,

- (a) the house of the man
- (b) the leg of the table

In a (above), who possesses the house? Yes, **the man!** (a human being---a living thing). In b, who possess "the leg"? Yes, **the table** (a non – living thing).

Have you got the distinction between both?

Also, you are to note what a plural or singular possessor is.

- (c) The house of the man (possessor = **man** (singular possessor)
- (d) The houses of the men (possessor = **men** (plural possessor)
- (e) The leg of the table (possessor = **table**: singular possessor)

Is this clear as well? Now, the laws:

Law 1: When an animal or human being possesses something, avoid the use of **of**, e.g. The house **of** the man **X** (wrong) but:

The man's house ✓ (correct)

Law 2: When a non – living thing is talked about, use **of** to show the possession

The table's leg **X** (wrong) but:

The leg **of** the table ✓ (right).

Law 3: In the case of human beings and animals, to show what they possess, first write down the identity of the possessor: is it "the **man**" or "the **men**", or "the **boy**" or "the **boys**", or "Mr. Andrew" or "The Adebowales" (the members of the Adebowale family) or "The **Lady**" or "the **ladies**", or "the **child**" or "the **children**"? First identify the owner of the thing and write it down. After that, put an apostrophe (') **after** the owner's identity, e.g.

- (a) Three boys have a house
- (b) One lady has a bag
- (c) Five children have a ball

a (above) will **not** be written as "the house **of** the three boys", but we will ask: who has the house?

Answer: **The three boys**. Now, take the second step: apply an apostrophe (') **after** the identity above: not: The three **boy's** house but:

The three boys' house (note

that the apostrophe comes **after** the possessors: **The three boys**. On the other hand, if it is one boy, then, it is, The **boy's** house. Other examples are:

Ten virgins have lamps = The virgins' lamps ✓

One lady has an earring = The lady's earring

Three ladies have shoes = The ladies' shoes

Two children have parents = The children's parents.

Law 4: Do not put an apostrophe on possessive adjectives, e.g.
It is our's **X** (wrong) it is **ours** (right)
They are **yours'** / **your's** **X** (wrong) They are **yours**
Other possessive adjectives include, mine, theirs, hers, his, its.

Law 5: Avoid "my own" **X** but, **mine** ✓
"your own" **X** but, **yours** ✓
"their own" **X** but, **theirs** ✓

You may have: It is Ade's, to mean, Ade's possession. Ade has a car. It is Ade's.
As said before, do NOT apply an apostrophe (') to **yours** or **theirs**.

Law 6: Supposing the owners of a thing are a family? Their identity should be their family name:

The + their family name + S + apostrophe after the name

↓ ↓ ↓ ↓
The Adegbola S ,

= The Adegbolas' Vale College

Note that Vale College is the thing / object of possession by the family of Mr. and Mrs. G. Adegbola

Law 7: When referring to something possessed by **someone else**, it is written as **someone else's** and the else's pronounced as / elsiz /. We can also have **anyone else's** (car) or **somebody else's** (shoes).

Law 8: In a situation where a noun only "describes" the activities (in that case, it becomes what is known as denominalised adjective: a noun, functioning as an adjective), no apostrophe should be put on the said noun. For example, there is a classroom where adult learners are taught to read and write. It is not true that adult people "possess" that classroom and, in that case, it is not to be called, adult's class but adult class (without apostrophe on adult — showing that, what goes on in that class is adult education. Others are office for the affairs of students; a camp (programme) for youths etc. Above all, take note not to pluralise the word you are dealing with, e.g. adult class ✓ not adults class.

Law 9: You are to treat the words:
sake and **time** as people who possess things.

Not: For **God** sake **X** or **Gods** sake **X**

But: For **God's** sake.

About **time**, now, look at this: Not I will be with you in **two hours time** **X** but in **two hours' time**.

Still on time and seasons, you are to regard, **New Year** as a possessor: **New year's** eve ✓, **New Year's** day (not: **new year day** **X**)

Past Question References

2003 question 39

It is bad to take ----- property without permission

- (a) someone else' (b) someone else's
(c) someone's else (d) someone's else's

Solution: Apply law 7

1997 question 90

----- been no official reaction to your request yet

- (a) There's (b) There's (c) Theirs'
(d) Their's

Solution: Apply Law 4

1993 question 77

The ----- discouraged me from reading it

- (a) story's lengths (b) length of the story
(c) story length (d) stories length

Solution: Apply Laws 1 and 2

1992 question 95

The choice to go to university or not is -----

- (a) yours' (b) your (c) yours (d) your's

Solution: Apply Law 4

1989 question 89

----- is always superior to any other in town

- (a) There's (b) Theirs (c) Their's
(d) There

Solution: Apply Law 5

1987 question 65

The ----- Affairs Officer is expecting all of us in the dinning room

- (a) Student (b) Student's (c) Students
(d) Students'

Solution: Apply Law 8

1985 question 99

I have received the answer scripts of Peter and John. What about -----

- (a) Ngozi (b) Ngozi's own (c) Ngozis'
(d) Ngozi's

Solution: Apply Law 5

1984 question 96

After we have taken our share, we shall give ----- to them

- (a) their (b) their's (c) theirs (d) there
(e) there's

Solution: Use Law 4

1978 question 67

Invariably, he ends all his letter:

"----- amicably"

- (a) you (b) your's (c) yours' (d) yours
(e) your own

Solution: Apply Laws 4 and

Past Question References

2003 question 39

It is bad to take ----- property without permission

- (a) someone else' (b) someone else's
(c) someone's else (d) someone's else's

Solution: Apply law 7

1997 question 90

----- been no official reaction to your request yet

- (a) There's (b) Theres' (c) Theirs'
(d) Their's

Solution: Apply Law 4

1993 question 77

The ----- discouraged me from reading it

- (a) story's lengths (b) length of the story
(c) story length (d) stories length

Solution: Apply Laws 1 and 2

1992 question 95

The choice to go to university or not is -----

- (a) yours' (b) your (c) yours (d) your's

Solution: Apply Law 4

1989 question 89

----- is always superior to any other in town

- (a) There's (b) Theirs (c) Their's
(d) There

Solution: Apply Law 5

1987 question 65

The ----- Affairs Officer is expecting all of us in the dinning room

- (a) Student (b) Student's (c) Students
(d) Students'

Solution: Apply Law 8

1985 question 99

I have received the answer scripts of Peter and John. What about -----

- (a) Ngozi (b) Ngozi's own (c) Ngozis'
(d) Ngozi's

Solution: Apply Law 5

1984 question 96

After we have taken our share, we give ----- to them

- (a) their (b) their's (c) theirs (d) there
(e) there's

Solution: Use Law 4

1978 question 67

Invariably, he ends all his letter:

"----- amicably"

- (a) you (b) your's (c) yours' (d) yours
(e) your own

Solution: Apply Laws 4 and

ENGLISH AS A SECOND LANGUAGE:

COMMON MISTAKES OF SPEAKERS

Simple Concepts for Correct English:

Before we discuss some rules, you must understand certain concepts. They are as follows:

(a) **Singular subject: (Doer of action that is being reported)**

A subject is singular if there is only **one** thing, person or place, e.g.

He/She/it (each of them is singular)

He/ She/it (singular)

The boy (singular)

(b) **Plural Subject: (Doer of action that is being reported)**

If the doers of the action are more than one, then, we have **plural subject** e. g.

I/We/You/they (*remember we have said "I" is plural in function*)

The men/The women

Lagos and The United States

all of them are plural

Remember, we say I is plural because of its function in sentences

(c) **Singular Verb:**

i. Lexical = (LV)

A lexical verb is singular if it carries **S** at the back, e. g. 'takes', 'writes', 'knows', 'speaks'

ii. The following are singular primary auxiliaries:
is and was only

iii. The following are **singular anomalous** verbs:
has and had only

iv. Please note that **Modal auxiliaries** e. g.
'can', 'may', 'will' etc.

do not have singular or plural. They have only present and past forms

Present		Past	
can	-	could,	may - might
shall	-	should	will - would,
must	-	had to	need - need
dare	-	dared,	ought to - had to

i. A lexical verb is plural if it does NOT have an **S** after it, e.g.

'take', 'write', 'know'.

ii. The following are plural primary auxiliaries:

are, were, am

iii. Plural anomalous are:

'had', and 'have'.

Now, the **RULES**

● LET GRAMMAR WORDS AGREE (I)

Here is a set of rules, which will guide you in writing and speaking correct English:

i. when the subject is singular the verb (*lexical, primary or anomalous*) should be singular too, e.g.

Alice / He / She / It + **is**

Or

was (singular primary)

Janet / He / She / It + **goes** or **stands**

(singular lexical verbs)

● LET GRAMMAR WORDS AGREE (II)

When the subject is plural, the lexical verb or anomalous verb or primary auxiliary verb to follow it should also be plural e.g. they / we / you + **are** or **were** (*plural primary auxiliary*)

I + **am**

(**'am'** is, though singular in form, it functions as plural).

They / we / you / I + **have** or **had** (*plural anomalous verbs*).

They / we you / I + go or dance – plural lexical verbs.

● FRAMING A QUESTION

If you are to ask a question. The rule will change. Do not ever put an **s** at the back of the verb when it is a question

He **goes** = sentence (correct)

They **go** = sentence but: Does he **go**? (not does he goes)

Do they go? (not: do they goes?)

● USING WILL, CAN, MAY and OTHERS

Any verb that follows any modal auxiliary (*whether the modal is in present or past form*) should be simple present tense, without 's'

You cannot say

she **will goes** X or

it **will cries** X

but say:

she **will + go** or it **will cry**

Other examples:

They **should speak**

'We **can write** etc.

make your own example with this rule.

● USE "TO" APPROPRIATELY

Any verb that follows **to** should be in present tense without **S** even if the event you are describing is past – just put a present tense verb after **to**, e.g.

I wanted **to + go** last year

She likes **to + see** you

We need **to + know** him

Look, there are certain exceptions to this rule where you find an "...ing" verb coming after **to**

They **have been** seen

not

He **has** being...

or

They **have** being.

● **AVOID ERRORS WITH HAS, HAVE, HAD**

Any verb that follows has / have / had should be in past participle form e.g.

he + **has** + eaten

(**eaten** is past participle).

I / we / they / you + **have** spoken

(**spoken** is past participle)

(I have advised you to learn by heart, all past tense and past participle verbs so you can use them where appropriate).

● **BEING and its usage**

The words that could come **AFTER being** are **past participle** verbs only e.g.

He is being + **beaten** (not beating)

They are being + **addressed** (not addressing)

It means, at the moment you make the statement the action is going on.

Do not put an adjective in front of 'being' e.g.

He is **being** + handsome (adj.)

She is **being** + beautiful (adj.)

● **BEEN and its Usage**

The words that could come **AFTER been** are:

i. ... ing verbs or

ii. **past participle** verb, e.g. example

for (i) above

They have **been** beating the boys.

Example for (ii) above:

They have **been** beaten by the teacher.

I will tell you later when to use **ing** or **past participle** verb, after **been**.

● **ON, IN, OF, FOR** etc and their Rules

Any verb that follows a preposition should be in **'...ing'** form e.g.

By + coming ... to school

For + dancing well

Without + telling lies

On + getting to school

So, 'by', 'for', 'without', and 'on' are all **prepositions** and they are always followed by **'...ing'**

I think you have not forgotten the other prepositions. **To**, is also a preposition and you have learnt rules relating to it in number 5.

Using **DO, DOES, DID** correctly

Any verb that follows **do / does / did / do not / did not / does not** should be present tense without 's', e.g.

I **do + speak ...** (not speaks)

It **did + cry** (not cries)

It **does + move** (not moves)

After **do, does** or **did**, do **not** put a verb that has an **s** or a verb in the past tense, but the one in the **present tense** only.

Somebody **go** or somebody **goes**?

Any verb that follows the following words should have an **s** at the back, i.e. it should be a singular verb, singular lexical or singular anomalous or singular primary auxiliary,

The words are:

Anybody, anyone, somebody, nobody, none, no one, something, anything, nothing, somewhere, nowhere, everything anywhere, someone, everyone, everywhere, everybody.

Any verb that follows the above-listed words should be in singular, e.g.

everyone

something)

somebody)

nobody)

knows NOT, know

hears NOT, hear

everybody) sees NOT, see

Each of them is called **indefinite pronoun**

So, also should you say

Everybody, everyone, something, nothing

Everywhere, nobody etc. **IS** not: **are** or, everybody/everyone etc **has**, not: have.

Note also that wherever **every** appears, the noun in front of it must be singular.
e.g. **Every problem**, not every problems.

● Buy two *Breads* and three *waters*?

Uncountable nouns are nouns (things) which we cannot count because they are not in single units. They include all liquids.

(water, kerosene, petrol, oil etc.)

Information, equipment, furniture, advice, baggage, work, money, news, traffic, all abstract nouns including love, happiness, knowledge, hatred, determination etc.

As a rule, you should **not** put an **s** at the **back** of any of them e.g.

not: 'Two informations'

but 'two pieces of information'.

not 'some waters are in the bucket'

but Some water **is**

The only situation where we can have **waters** is if we talk of various sources of water: well, tap, stream, brook waters.

● Measles *is* bad or measles *are* bad?

Pluralia tantums are words that appear with 's' at the back as if they were plural nouns, but which, in actual fact are singular. They could be categorized as follows:

(a) School Subjects:

Physics, Mathematics, Economics, Civics, Statistics etc.

(b) Diseases:

'Mumps', 'shingles' and 'measles'.

(c) Games:

'Darts', 'snakes and ladders', 'skittles', 'billiards', 'bowls' and 'draughts'.

Book / Magazine Titles; e.g.

A Tale of Two Cities.

All these are singular subjects so they should have singular verb in front of them

e.g.

Mumps + **is** terrible (singular primary)

Measles + **makes** (singular lexical) one look dirty.

Snakes and ladders + **has** (not, have) a lot of advantages.

Each officer or each officers

"**Each**" should have a singular noun in front of it e.g. each + boy,

the next verb should also be in singular, e.g.

each + girl + **knows** (not know)

each teacher + **marks** (not mark) his / her register.

Beware of each of

"**Each of**" should have a plural noun and a singular verb.

Formula:

"Each of" + plural noun + singular verb, e.g.

"Each of" + the boys + **laughs** (singular verb).

"Each of" + the students + **is** ready.

(singular verb)

"Each of" + the girls + **has** (not **have**) a skirt

Information go round or goes round? Take one!

After all the uncountable nouns mentioned above, (under "Buy Two Breads...") a **singular verb** should follow, e.g.

information + **makes** (singular lexical) the world go round.

Water + **is** (singular primary) important to health.

The news + **has** (singular anomalous) (not: **have**) been broadcast.

Beware of One of

"**One of**" should be treated as "**each of**". They obey the same rule, e.g.

"one of" + my brothers + **looks** (singular lexical) handsome, not: one of my brother

● **Secrets of some of**

"**Some of**" should have a plural noun in front of it and a plural verb.

Formula:

"Some of" + the teachers + know me (plural lexical)

"Some of" + the students + are brilliant (plural anomalous)

But "**some of**" + uncountable noun + singular verb e.g. Some of the water spills on the floor.

● **This boys? How come?**

After **THIS**, the next noun should be singular, and a singular verb e.g.

This **boy**, this **girl**, this stupid **man**, + goes.

not: this boys / this girls, this girls goes

● **That reasons? Impossible!**

After **THAT**, the next noun should be singular + singular verb e.g.

That **boy**, that **girl**, that stupid **man** knows (not know) me.

● **These men, not: man**

After **THESE**, the next noun should be plural, + plural verb e.g. These oranges, these stupid **men**, these bags.

These bags **look** like mine.

● **Those companies, not company!**

After **THOSE**, the next noun should be plural verb, e.g.

Those girls, those oranges, those stupid **women**. Those stupid **men see** (not sees) regularly.

Language is dynamic. This means that it changes over time. What used to be correct in the day of William Shakespeare are not exactly officially correct English today. The British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC) is regarded as world's number one authority on the speaking and writing of English, today. The JAMB and other examination bodies usually take advantage of the fact that many people do not move with change in English as it occurs in lexis and structure. Many students have learnt the obsolete, anachronistic and out dated versions of words, phrases and expressions which are no more today, or, would you like to say which is correct

(1) Who ----- you knows tomorrow? (a) **among** (b) amongst

Or

(2) My ----- sister is going on holiday with me
(a) junior (b) kid (c) younger (d) senior

e treatise under here gives authoritative and prescriptive grammar of the modern day English as the language is spoken in England, the metown of the English Language.

Age Classification

Senior or **junior** does not apply to age:

These are my **senior** sisters **X** (wrong)
but

These are my **elder** sisters ✓

Older is the word to use when comparing two people's advancement in age.
We are classmates but I'm certainly **older** than you.

What about **elder**, then? The difference between **older** and **elder** is that, **older** attracts **than** whereas, **elder** does not:

He is **elder than** me **X** (wrong)

He is **older than** me ✓ (correct)

If positive is **old**, the comparative is **older** and the superlative, **oldest** but, if there is a "group" of people, **eldest** means, the most advanced in age.

Note: To discuss position of authority, e.g., in office, we choose **junior** (officer) **senior** (officer).

2. Happening once in a while

There are many ways of stating what happens occasionally. In other words such a thing happens, is it **atimes** or **at times**? Choose the second one.

3. Drummers and Singers

An artist draws, does sculpture work or paints but an **artiste** (note the **e**) has skills in dancing drumming, singing and acting on stage.

4. It is, it has, it belongs

It's crawled away means, it **has** ...

It's safe means, it **is**

So, to differentiate between both above, see what comes after **it's**: if it is a verb such as **crawled**, then, the **it's** stands for **it has** but if what comes in front of **it's** is not a verb but an adjective such as **safe**, then, the **it's** means, **it is**.

Its, without apostrophe means, 'belonging to it', e.g. (of a chair) **its** legs are broken not **it's** legs are broken.

5. The manager and Me / The Manager and I

Look at this: Choosing between **I** and **me**, **he** and **him**.

Subject level pronouns:

He	it	she	We	you	they	I
↕	↕	↕	↕	↕	↕	↕
him	it	her	us	you	them	me

Complement level pronouns: **him** **it** **her** **us** **you** **them** **me**

Will you choose: The teacher called **Akpan and I**
or
The teacher called **Akpan and me**?

You will need to analyse the clause, like this.

The teacher (subject of the sentence)

called

(verb of the sentence

(—) this is the complement (note that after verb, is complement:
noun or pronoun.

See where the dash (—) is in the question. After analysing, you find that dash (—) at complement, showing you that, your pronoun should be NOT **subject** level pronoun but **complement** level pronoun which is **me** not **I**. Do you understand? Answer this:

Akpan and ----- saw the teacher (a) me (b) I (c) myself (d) himself

First, analyse: **Subject** = **Akpan and -----**

Verb = **Saw**

Object (Complement) = **the teacher.**

So, this means, since the gap is at subject level, your pronoun should be a subject level pronoun. What is it? Yes! Good!

6. Liking something much

If someone likes something much, they are **fond of** that thing. It is different from **fund** (as a verb) which means, to provide money towards executing a project and its past and past participle forms are **funded / funded**.

This is different from **find** which means, to get something by looking for it. The past tense and past participle forms are **found** and **found**.

But **found** can be a present tense verb which means, to establish something, e.g. a church, club, school etc. Its past tense and past participle forms are **founded / founded**.

7. Acting in the opposite way

A small room leading directly to a bigger one is called an **ante** – room from the word **ante** which means, 'before' but **anti** which sounds like **ante** means, in the opposite way to; 'against':

The **anti** – corruption war is going on.

8. Giving Birth

Bear is the simple present tense for the idea of bringing a child into the world through pregnancy. The past is **bore** and past participle is **borne**.

To show that someone is the father / mother of another person, say, **born of** + name of parent or **borne by** + name of parent.

Borne is also past participle of **bear**, which means, to carry someone / something up, off the ground: The goalkeeper was **borne** shoulder – high by his teeming fans.

Note: Wherever you use **born** do NOT use **by**

9. Leaving this world

When I **dye** it means I put a piece of cloth in chemical water that changes the colour of the cloth but when they **die**, they are no more in this world.

I am **dyeing** some clothes

She is **dying** of hunger

She **has died**. She is **dead**

10. Unconsciously leaving something behind

Only things that are abstract can be **forgotten** or that we can **forget**. You cannot **forget** something that you can see with your eyes.

I forgot my pen (physical thing) X

I left my pen; pity! (correct)

But: I forgot your name (abstract thing) ✓

You may also have: "I forgot to take my..." (correct) ✓

I. **Everyone knows their name**

In Modern English, indefinite pronouns usually have the third person plural as the complement / object.

Everyone / everybody / someone / somebody

anyone / anybody / and each are indefinite pronouns that used to attract his / her (his or her) at the complement but now, it is **their / them**

Before:

Everyone knows that "someone can forget his or her name, sometimes".
but

In modern English, it is:

Everyone knows that "someone can forget **their** name, sometimes".

12. **Sometime / Sometimes**

These two are different in that, **sometime** attracts 'ago', **sometimes** does not. **Sometimes** means, not all the time; occasionally while **sometime ago** means, a time in the past.

Note that **sometime** cannot stand without **ago**.

13. **Happening within closed doors**

Scrabble is an **indoor** game because you can play it in your room whereas, **indoors** means "available inside" a house, e.g. The principal is indoors; that's his car outside the house.

Indoor on the other hand is an adjective telling us that something is NOT "available" in the house where it "can be done or carried out".

14. **Defamation of Character**

When someone **says** untrue things about another person in public that is **slander** but if they go ahead to **write such things down and made available for public consumption**, it is **libel**. Both are forms of defamation of character.

15. **Event happening twice in a year**

If an event happens **twice in a year**, it takes place Biannually but if it happens **once in two years**, it takes place biennially.

16. **Twice and Thrice**

Yes **thrice** was once the correct form of **three times** but it is no more correct although we can still have **twice**.

17. **Superior than?**

Superior is one of the adjectives known as *ne plus ultra* or ceiling adjectives. They are high - level epithets or adjectives which cannot be taken "higher" in degree.

So, if something is "Superior", another one cannot be "more" superior. The other one can only be "inferior" to the first one. So, **Superior** cannot ever take **than**. Other adjectives that cannot take **than**, or be compared further include: perfect / right / correct / paramount / ultimate / round / rectangular / triangular.

18. **Cutlery**
These are spoons, forks and knives, put together. **Cutlery** cannot, therefore be pluralised as cutleries but we can have a **set of cutlery**.
19. **Infact?**
Although, **indeed** written together is a correct, one word but **infact** should be two words: **in** and **fact**
20. **Never**
Do not use **never** to mean or, in place of **not** e.g.
I **never** know him X (wrong)
but
I do **not** know him ✓ (correct)
21. **Do you love yourself?**
Themselves and **each other** are two different expressions.
Themselves means, each person doing it to himself or herself, e.g.
Nigerian politicians love **themselves**. This means that they do not love the people who voted them into power but seek their own individual good: Each politician loves himself; he / she doesn't love others.
Each other means, I do it to you, you do it to me.
Politicians love **each other**, means, one politician loves the other, the other loves him too, in return.
22. **That my friend is waiting**
This statement is better reframed as:
That friend of mine is waiting ✓
Those bags of yours are stinking, not:
Those your bags are stinking X
This our friend is handsome X (wrong)
This friend of ours is handsome ✓ (correct)
23. **Do you have a stationery shop or a stationary one?**
Stationery means, letters, envelopes, writing paper and so on while **stationary** means, static, not moving, rigid.
24. **Are you "authorise" to do it?**
The past participle verb must be used in every passive statement, but many people neglect this principle writing something like the one above — which is wrong.
'Are you authorised to do it? Is right.
Consider these
They are **empower** / **empowered** to arrest people
We can be **organised** / **organise** into different groups. Choose **empowered** and **organised**!
25. **Did you saw him?**
When **did** is used, no matter what the situation may be, the verb that follows it must be in present simple tense. So, the above should be:

Did you see him?

Loan and rent

To **borrow** is to **get something for your use** FROM someone else with the intention of returning it while **lend** is to **give something out to** someone for their use, with the intention of taking it back. American English equivalent of **lend** is **loan**. To **rent** is to take possession of something for one's use for some time. The difference between **borrow** and **rent** is that, whereas one does not pay money for "borrowing" something, one pays some amount of money to the owner, e.g. a landlord as **rent**.

One can **lease** (rent) a house or property for a long time but **let** a house or apartment for a usually short period.

Pass Time?

One's leisure or period when one is not working but free to relax and carry out a hobby or avocation is **Pastime** not pass – time or **pass time**.

Loose

Loose is adjective which means, **not tight**.

Loose is also a verb which means, **to make free from tying**.

Loosen is a verb which means, to make not very tight.

Lose is a verb which means, not to be in contact with something or someone anymore.

Lost is the past form of **lose**

Loosed is the past form of (verb) **loose**

loss is the act or value of being parted with something: He **lost** his parents. The **loss** is very great because he has no one else to support him through school.

Inset?

Onset and **outset** both mean, at the beginning (of an activity) but **onset** is now out of language fashion. Always use **outset** in place of onset. **Inset** means, a small image (e.g. a picture) put at a corner in a bigger image).

At hand

At hand means, that which is seen or available. **Off hand** does not exist in English. **Off hand** means, **spontaneously**, easily (said) from the head without racking the brain.

Seek for Admission

Seek is a verb which does not take the **for** preposition. In fact, it doesn't take any preposition: I am **seeking** for admission X

I am **seeking** admission ✓

More Grease to your elbow

The idiomatic way of encouraging someone on an activity is to say, "That's great, more **power** to your elbow" not: more **grease** to your elbow.

Request

Do not use the preposition **for** with request

'I hereby wish to request **for** your support' X

'I hereby wish to request your support' ✓

Comprise

Do not use the preposition **of** with comprise:

The family comprises **of** four boys X

The family comprises four boys ✓

A thing, e.g. class, family etc can be **constituted of** or it can **contain** (without the preposition **of**, people).

35. **Hard currency / soft currency**

Hard currency is the one that has high exchange rate such as the dollar, Euro, pounds while a **soft currency** is the one that has low exchange rate.

36. **Motor Accident?**

The accident that occurs on the road involving vehicles is not **motor accident**; not: **motor vehicle** accident; not **traffic accident** but **ROAD** accident.

37. **conclusive / in conclusion**

To mean, "finally" use in conclusion, not **conclusively**.

Conclusively means, without any doubt

"conclusively", the police officer said, "you, Ajantala, are an armed robber".

In conclusion of my talk, I want to appeal to you to be well – behaved.

38. **Escort**

Do not **escort** your visitors to the gate but **accompany** them to... . You cannot **follow** or **join** someone in the sense of going with someone. Simply choose **accompany**. You can also "**come with**" someone, e.g. Mother, may I come **with** you to your office?

39. **The Lights Quenched!**

When there is power supply (electricity) cut, there is an **outage**. At that moment, one may say, that the lights **went off**, not: the lights were **quenched** or the lights **were taken away** or the lights **came off**. **Power is interrupted** is also correct!

40. **Do you take Hot drinks?**

What is usually called **hot drinks**, that is, alcoholic beverages are actually **hard drinks**. The opposite is, **soft drinks**. Non – alcoholic drinks are not **minerals** but **soft drinks**, e.g. Soda, Fanta, Malt variety

41. **Having a talk**

When **discuss** means, "talk to each other", avoid the preposition: **about**; discuss about X

42. **Move with Bad gang?**

While one can **keep company with** + e.g. bad / good people. One cannot **move with bad gang**. Be careful not to take **keep** to the ing form: **keeping**.

He is **keeping** company with rich people X

He **keeps** company with rich people ✓

43. **in public / publicly**

If you intend to say that something happens in the presence or glare of people, say, **in public** not: **in the public** X or **publicly** X. You can however say, **in the public place**

He disgraced him **in public** ✓ not:

He disgraced him **publicly** / **in the public** X

44. **Pull Resources together**

How can this be? But you can **pool** (gather together) resources together. A popular politician can however **pull crowd** (attract many spectators) say, to a political campaign.

45. **Lift / pick**
 If a car or vehicle has arranged to give you a ride, **pick up**, is the phrase. My father's friend will **pick** us up at the church gate.
 He cannot **pick** us **X**. He cannot **lift** us **X**. He cannot **lift** us up **X**.
 He can however **give us a ride** in his car ✓
46. **"Won't you shake me?"**
 This should be: "won't you shake hands with me?". Be careful not to choose, shake hand with or shake his / her / my hand.
 "come... come and **shake my hand**" **X**.
 "come... come and shake **hands with me**" ✓
 One cannot "shake" another person except in a wrestling duel!
47. **conclude**
 To conclude is to **round off**, not **round up**.
48. **Elites? Impossible!**
Elite is, like **staff** or **personnel**, a collective noun for influential people in a society.
 You should not put an **s** at the back; as **elites**. In one group of **elite**, we can find many people.
 She is in the Lagos / New York / London **elite**
49. **I'm coming / Just A Moment**
 One can be polite as one walks away from a person one has stood or been with by saying:
"Just a moment, please", as one leaves. Do not say "I'm coming". One can however say, too, **I'll be with you in a moment**.
50. **Did not chance?**
 If one does / did not have the opportunity to do something it means he **"does / did not have the opportunity** not that, he / she "did not chance" or "was not chanced" or "was not opportuned". Opportune (without the **d**) means, appropriate. This is an opportune time to fire the shot.

Past Question References

2007 question 89

I ----- to pursue my education

- (a) did not chance (b) did not have the opportunity (c) was not chanced
(d) was not opportuned

Solution: Apply Resource number 50 (above)

2006 question 40

Olu brought his clothes and those of his -----

- (a) senior brothers' (b) elder brothers
(c) elder brother's (d) senior brother

Solution: Apply Resource number 1

2005 question 74

The public library has stopped -----

2003 question 32

The woman is one of the ----- of the society

- (a) elitist (b) elite (c) elites (d) elitists

Solution: Apply Resource number 48

2000 question 62

Raffle draws, like gambling, often end in a ----- for me

- (a) lost (b) loss (c) loose (d) lose

Solution: Use Resource number 28

2000 question 47

The man declared his intention from the -----

- (a) outset (b) inset (c) onset (d) offset

Solution: Apply Resource number 29

2000 question 44

The loquacious young lad reeled off all the names of the players -----

- (a) off head (b) off hand (c) at heart
(d) at hand

Solution: Consider Resource number 30

1999 question 53

I am ----- admission to the university this year

- (a) seeking an (b) seeking for
(c) seeking at (d) seeking

Solution: Apply Resource number 31

1998 question 82

Kindly ----- me your book because my friend has ----- mine

- (a) borrow / borrowed (b) borrow / lent
(c) lend / lent (d) lend / borrowed

Solution: Apply Resource number 26

1995 question 97

This is to congratulate you on your success in the last examination and to wish you -----

- (a) more grease to your elbow
(b) more power to your elbow
(c) some grease on your elbow
(d) some power to your elbow

Solution: Apply Resource number 32

1995 question 92

books to people

- (a) borrowing (b) lending (c) renting
(d) loaning

Solution: Apply Resource number 26

2004 question 26

I shall find time for my ----- when I get ----- with this difficult assignment

- (a) past - time / over
(b) pass - time / over
(c) passtime / through
(d) pastime / through

Solution: Use Resource number 27

2003 question 47

Be careful not to ----- this money

- (a) loose (b) lose (c) lost (d) loss

Solution: Apply Resource number 28

During the examination, a student ----- more answer sheets

- (a) requested (b) requested for
(c) requests for (d) request

Solution: Apply Resource number 33

1995 question 84

I would like to ----- my father to Kaduna

- (a) accompany (b) follow (c) escort
(d) join

Solution: Apply Resource number 38

1994 question 82

The exercise will be easily accomplished by the team if members ----- their -----

- (a) pull / resources together
- (b) pool / resources together
- (c) pull / resources
- (d) pool / resources

Solution: Consider Resource number 44

1994 question 81

When we visited him, he offered us a variety of ----- drinks such as whisky and brandy

- (a) hot
- (b) local
- (c) hard
- (d) soft

Solution: Use Resource number 40

1993 question 99

I was anxious to arrive early for the lecture that I ----- my notes in the car

- (a) forgot
- (b) left
- (c) dropped
- (d) abandoned

Solution: Apply Resource number 10

1993 question 94

The President refused to shake ----- with the visiting Prime - Minister

- (a) hand
- (b) hands
- (c) a hand
- (d) his hand

Solution: Consider Resource number 46

1993 question 72

Ali is crying because his mother was killed in a ----- accident

- (a) motor
- (b) traffic
- (c) motor vehicle
- (d) road

Solution: Apply Resource number 36

1992 question 56

----- sign post words are useful to readers

- (a) conclusively
- (b) to conclude
- (c) in conclusion
- (d) The conclusion

Solution: Consider Resource number 37

1990 question 91

Yemi said, 'I'm coming' to her friend Biola who was waiting for her instead of saying -----

- (a) wait for me in a moment
- (b) I will come
- (c) I will be with you in a moment
- (d) I'll come now

Solution: Apply Resource number 49

1990 question 58

This section of the test will ----- questions on set passages

- (a) consist
- (b) comprise of
- (c) contain
- (d) carry

Solution: Use Resource number 34

1986 question

We were trying to study for the examinations last night when the lights -----

- (a) were taken away
- (b) came of
- (c) quenched
- (d) went off

Solution: Apply Resource number 39

1984 question

Give me a minute to think; I can't remember the answer -----

- (a) out of hand
- (b) ahead
- (c) off hand
- (d) to hand
- (e) off head

Solution: Apply Resource number 30

1978 question 98

A society ----- individuals each of whom has his attributes and distinct characteristics

- (a) is constituted of
- (b) comprises of
- (c) consists of
- (d) contains of
- (e) is made from

Solution: Apply Resource number 34

1978 question 78

We ought to stay away ----- the robbers come back

- (a) provided
- (b) should in case
- (c) although
- (d) in case
- (e) since

Solution: Only one of **should** and **in case** can be used at a time; **should in case** cannot be used together:

We ought to stay away **should** the robbers come back
We ought to stay away **in case** the robbers come back

JAMB PAST QUESTIONS:

1978

Answers and Analyses

...Of all sections of the paper, for each of the years reviewed

1978 COMPREHENSION

Read each passage carefully and answer the questions that follow it

PASSAGE A

- A. All over the world till lately, and in most of the world still today, mankind has been following the course of nature, that is to say, it has been breeding up to maximum. To let nature take her extravagant course in the reproduction of the human race may have made sense in an age in which we were also letting her take her course in decimating mankind by the casualties of war, pestilence, and famine. Being human, we have at last revolted against that senseless waste. We have started to impose on nature's heartless play **humane** new order of our own. But, when once man has begun to interfere with nature, he cannot afford to stop half way. We cannot, with impunity, cut down the death – rate and at the same time allow the birth – rate to go on taking nature's course. **We must consciously try to establish equilibrium** or, sooner or later, famine will stalk abroad again

Question 1.

The author observes that

- A. war, pestilence and famine were caused by the extravagance of nature
- B. nature was heartless and senseless
- C. there was a time when controlled birth made sense
- D. it was wise at a time when mankind did not interfere with normal reproduction
- E. nature was heartless in its reproductive process.

Answer C

This is an **authorial question**, which means that the answer must be in line with what the passage provides. The passage says that, before, people were making more babies and also by organising wars people were killed — to balance the equation. Start from: "To let ... and famine"

Question 2.

Which of these statements does not express the opinion of the author?

- A. mankind has started to interfere with the work of nature
- B. many people had died in the past through want and disease
- C. mankind should not have the maximum number of children possible
- D. mankind should take care of its children
- E. man's present relationship with nature in matters of birth and death is a happy one

Answer E

This is a **refutational question**, where you are encouraged to say "this option is not the author's idea"
Start from "We cannot ... nature's course": We now try to reduce death rate and increase birth rate.

Question 3.

'Humane' as used in the passage means

- A. sensible

- B. wise
- C. human
- D. benevolent
- E. thorough

Answer A

This is a **contextual question**, asking you to give the meaning of **humane** as used. Normally, **humane** means, having pity towards, or behaving well to, human beings. We derive the answer from considering "heartless play" whose opposite is "humane". If "heartless play" of nature seems foolish, "humane" means, sensible. Read, also from "Being human ... senseless waste", meaning that our "new order" is no more "senseless" but "sensible"

Question 4.

'We must consciously try to establish an equilibrium, implies that mankind must

- A. realistically find an equation
- B. strive not to be wasteful
- C. deliberately try to fight nature
- D. try to fight nature
- E. purposely find a balance

Answer E

This is a **contextual question** as well.

Consciously equates with **purposely**, **establish** equates with **find** and an **equilibrium** equates with **balance**

Question 5.

The main idea of this passage is that

- A. nature is heartless
- B. man should control the birth rate
- C. mankind will soon perish of starvation
- D. pestilence causes more deaths than war
- E. man should change nature's course gradually

Answer B

This is a **thematic question**. The "main idea" is the same thing as **theme**. Evidence: Read the last sentence

PASSAGE B

- B. The endeavour to maintain proper standards of fairness in journalism must be pursued. It is fatally easy for the journalist to deviate from the straight path. There is his natural desire to 'make a story' and **insidious** temptation to twist facts to square with his paper's policy. Both are as indefensible as the framing of misleading headlines for the sake of effect. The conscientious journalist must check any tendency to bias, and guard against the danger inherent in personal antipathies or friendships, and in traditional opposition between rival schools of thought.

When a political opponent, whose stupidity habitually provokes attack, makes an effective speech, honesty requires that he be given credit for it. Where personal relationships might make it easier and more congenial to keep silent than to criticize,

the journalist must never forget his duty to the public and the supreme importance of recording the truth.

Question 6.

When may a journalist have to act against his own inclination?

- A. when his friends act stupidly
- B. when he becomes weak and decrepit
- C. when his enemies make a mistake
- D. his political opponents frame misleading headlines
- E. after he has been given a bribe

Answer A

This is a **direct question**. A direct question is one that starts with **Wh: what / where / when / why / who / which**. The answer to the question is solidly found in the passage. The question should be reframed so as to make it clear: **At what time is it likely for the journalist to do things that are not in line with his own beliefs?** Read from "The conscientious journalist... rival schools of thought..."

Question 7.

A journalist would be able to uphold the tenets of his profession if

- A. he seeks publicity
- B. he tries to achieve popularity
- C. he resists temptation to bias
- D. he can manipulate his story to please his employers
- E. he tries to protect his friends

Answer C

This is a **suitability question**, which asks you to look through all options and see which one is in agreement with the provision of the passage.

Evidence for (C) is: "The **conscientious** (professional) journalist must check tendency to bias"

Question 8.

'Insidious' means

- A. subtle
- B. wicked
- C. natural
- D. unusual
- E. wild

Answer A

The question is a **contextual one**, which wants you to find a substitute for **insidious** the place (context) where it appears. **Insidious** means, secret activity that is harmful. **Subtle** means, secret move, underground activity. Do you understand?

Question 9.

A dutiful journalist must

- A. read widely
- B. have political acumen
- C. make no enemies but friends
- D. be able to make an effective speech
- E. be able to recognise merit wherever found

Answer E

This is a **suitability question** asking you to determine which option is suitably correspondent to or alike with the passage. This answer is correct because of "When a political opponent, whose stupidity habitually (usually) provokes attack makes an effective speech, honesty requires that he be given credit for it". This is, "recognizing merit whenever found" (E)

Question 10.

The duty of the journalist to the public entails

- A. giving credit to his political enemies
- B. keeping quiet when necessary
- C. trying to 'make a story'
- D. telling the truth
- E. defending the weak

Answer D

This is a **suitability question** asking you: which one here tallies with the passage facts? It is (D) because of the last sentence: "... the journalist must never forget his duty to the public and the supreme importance of recording the truth"

PASSAGE C

C. So far I have been speaking of science in its universality, viewed from the perspective of the world at large. For in the context of our own country and our **sister developing countries**, many of the factors mentioned earlier are not very important. For example, pollution, deterioration of the environment and population explosion are not serious problems for us in this country.

Let me now turn to a more specific area, namely the question of scientific choice for developing country. There is no doubt that the role which science and technology have played in the uplift of the material and economic well-being of the developed nations will, and does, influence the criteria that the Third World nations must choose in order to establish their science policies and priorities.

But the criteria to be used by these nations do not have to be the same as those which have brought the developed countries to their present stage of evolution. For while human beings have the same problems, their solutions, to be meaningful will have to be sought within some relevant **frame of reference**, such as the availability resources and expertise, social values, place and time in the historical scale.

Question 11.

'frame of reference' in this passage means

- A. point of information
- B. range of authority
- C. economic pattern

The question is a **contextual and substitutional** question. **Frame of reference**, as used in the passage means "consideration of one's individual situation", which is the same as 'context of situation' option (D).

Question 12.

The writer apparently believes that through science and technology our country can achieve

- A. peace and order
- B. progress and material success
- C. social values and universality
- D. wealth and economic progress
- E. military development and power

Answer D

This question is a **suitability** question, asking you to determine which of the options readily relates to the passage facts. (D) is correct because the passage mentions "...the material and economic well-being...". "Material well-being is the same as wealth" while economic well-being is the same as "economic progress"

Question 13.

According to the passage, the basic consideration for developing science and technology should be three of the following:

- 1. technical know-how
 - 2. availability of raw material
 - 3. atmospheric pollution
 - 4. the people's tradition and beliefs
 - 5. population
 - 6. capital
- A. 2, 1 and 6 only
 - B. 3, 2 and 4 only
 - C. 5, 3 and 6 only
 - D. 6, 5 and 4 only
 - E. 5, 2 and 6 only

Answer A

This is an **analytical** question, which entails examining each option in its details for figures and data, number and relevance. It is already stated that factors will include "the available resources (raw materials and money) and expertise (technical know-how)"

Question 14.

The main idea of this passage is that

- A. there is a yawning gap between the haves and the have-nots
- B. there is need to rid his countrymen from the scourges of hunger, disease, ignorance and want
- C. there could be atmospheric pollution and population explosion
- D. the concerns of science and technology are the same in all countries
- E. each nation must plan its development according to its need and resources

Answer E

This is a **thematic** question asking you for the theme otherwise known as "the main idea"

To arrive at the theme, you are simply to narrow down the didactic (lesson / fact) aspect to the most important. In the passage, we are already told that the factors for developing each nation will be "...sought within some relevant frame of reference..." and conditions peculiar to that nation.

Question 15.

The term 'our sister developing countries' implies

- A. Britain, Gambia and Canada
- B. Ghana, Germany and Togo
- C. Russia, Switzerland and America
- D. Liberia, Sierra Leone and Gabon
- E. China, India and Holland

Answer D

This question is an intuitive question, which wants you to rely on your residual knowledge. You knew (before now, on your own) that, all African Countries are "developing countries". In this analysis, only option D puts the right range of countries: Liberia, Sierra Leone and Gabon, all in Africa.

URGENT HELP FOR YOUR NEXT EXAMINATION: COLLOCATION / REGISTERS

SICKNESS, HOSPITAL AND YOU

'She is **allergic** (person reacts to certain foods or environmental substances) to neck laces", the surgeon happily told Nimota, Wura's mother, who was on admission on hospital bed. The allergy had caused her **amnesia** (a condition that causes people to lose their memory) apart from the countless rashes on her back and upper thighs. She had already developed **bedsore** (wounds that develop on a patient's body from lying on a spot for a long time) but she was not **anaemic** (not having enough red blood cells). As the doctor was talking to Nimota, some policemen walked briskly in. They came with the **coroner** (a person who determines the cause of death of a person). The **deceased** (dead person) battled with **dementia** (loss of mental capacity) and had also become so **dehydrated** (in need of water / thin / lean) that she was on **braces** (a device that holds injured body parts in place). Initially, the deceased had fallen off a moving commercial motorbike and had her brain and backbone terribly cut and injured. At first, the wounds were **benign** (not harmful or cancerous). The policemen and coroner moved into the **morgue** (temporary place for dead bodies).

As if by impulse, Nimota turned round near Wura and noticed a woman being wheeled away from the **maternity ward** (a place where pregnant women have their new babies) to the **theatre** (a room where medical operations are carried out by surgeons, theatre nurses and other medical staff). The pregnant woman's unborn baby was **breech** (in a position where the baby's feet are down and head up). She was to undergo Caesarean Section or **C.S** (procedure involving removing the baby by cutting open the woman's lower abdomen).

URGENT HELP FOR YOUR NEXT EXAMINATION: WORD, MEANING AND SYNONYMS

Abatement

Alleviation, extenuation, mitigation, moderation, fading, sinking, deduction, reduction

Abdicate

Abandon,, cede, forgo, forsake, give up, quit, relinquish, renounce, resign, surrender,

Aberration

Deviation, rambling, abnormality, eccentricity, unconformity disorder, hallucination, illusion, instability, delusion .

Baleful

Deadly, calamitous, hurtful, injurious, ruinous.

Balmy

Aromatic, healing, odorous, perfumed.

Banter

Deride, joke, mock, ridicule.

Cacophonous

Discordant, jarring, raucous.

Callous

Hardened, apathetic, indifferent, insensible, obtuse, unfeeling,.

Calumny

Abuses, defamation, detraction, insult, obloquy, vilification, vituperation.

Dastardly

Base, cowardly, cowering, pusillanimous, recreant.

Dauntless

Brave, courageous, gallant, heroic, indomitable, undaunted valorous.

Debacle

Breakdown, collapse, stampede

Ebullition

Boiling, effervescence, outbreak, paroxysm.

Eccentric

Parabolic, abnormal, irregular, odd, outlandish, strange, uncommon, whimsical.

UME 1978: LEXIS and STRUCTURE

Choose the option that best conveys the meaning of the emboldened portion in each of the following sentences.

26. In the match against the Uplanders team, the Submariners turned out to be the **dark horse**
- (a) played most brilliantly
 - (b) played below their usual form
 - (c) won unexpectedly
 - (d) lost as expected
 - (e) won as expected

Answer C The question is from **Idiomatic Expressions**,

A **dark horse** is a person / group not expected to do good but that springs surprises.

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

Andy's father is a **bigfish** in that political party

- (a) the chairman (b) a central figure
- (c) eats sardines and tilapia regularly
- (d) an unrecognized person
- (e) one of the founders of the party

27. Only the **small fry** get punished for such social misdemeanours
- (a) small boys
 - (b) unimportant people
 - (c) frightened people
 - (d) frivolous people
 - (e) inexperienced people

Answer B The question is from **Idiomatic Expressions**

Small fry seems the perfect opposite of **big fish**

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

The woman sitting next to the principal has **blue blood in her veins**

- (a) is suffering from HIV AIDS
- (b) is extremely poor (c) is very wealthy
- (d) has bad temper
- (e) is easily prone to malaria

28. He spoke with **his heart in his mouth**

- (a) courageously
- (b) with such unusual cowardice
- (c) with a lot of confusion in his speech
- (d) without being able to make up his mind

Answer B The question is from **Idiomatic Expressions**

With one's **heart in the mouth** means, fearfully. Another idiom with the same meaning is, **speak with one's tongue in his cheek**

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

The man sitting next to our teacher is a **belted earl**

- (a) a dirty pig (b) an affluent person
- (c) person living in penury (d) fat person
- (e) thin man, so thin he only uses a belt to hold up his trousers

29. The **leader** in today's issue of our popular newspaper focuses on inflation
- (a) president (b) headline
 - (c) editorial
 - (d) columnist (e) proprietor

Answer C The question is from **Cliches** In British English, it is called the **lead story** or **lead article**. It refers to the special opinion of the editorial team of a

newspaper.

Headline is the front, big story captioned in bold, capital points.

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

He is a **freelancer**

- (a) a journalist in charge of free speech
- (b) an independent journalist
- (c) an editorial staff in a media
- (d) an editor
- (e) a person who moves from place to place

30. From the way my friend talks, you can see he is such a **bore**
- (a) rude (b) brilliant
 - (c) uninteresting (d) overbearing (e) humorous

Answer C The question is from **Idiomatic Expressions**

A **bore** brings **boredom**— something not interesting.

Overbearing is, oppressive, bully while **humorous** means, funny, lively, jocular, loving banter

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

Both girls are **green horns**

- (a) evil witches with one horn each on their heads
- (b) experienced (c) inexperienced
- (d) prostitutes (e) exceptionally brilliant

31. His jail terms were to run **concurrently**
(a) simultaneously (b) uniformly
(c) laboriously (d) consecutively
(e) judiciously

Answer A This question is from **Diction**, the choice of appropriate words.

Simultaneously means, happening at the same time, juxtapositionally. If, for example, a criminal is charged with two offences, the Judge may sentence him to five years on the first count and 5 years on the second count. If the judge says, the

terms will run

Concurrently, it means, as he serves one year for the first charge, he is serving one year for the second charge, at the same time, meaning five years term in all. That's **concurrently / simultaneously**.

Laboriously means, with great effort. **Consecutively** means, for example that the criminal will serve 10 years, **consecutive** means, following one another (not, together, at the same time). **Judiciously** means, with sense or sagacity, wisely; perspicaciously

32. There is some obvious **symmetry** in the whole presentation
(a) confusion (b) hesitation
(c) excitement (d) orderliness
(e) dissatisfaction

Answer D This question is from **Diction** **Orderliness**, exactitude, appropriateness, correlation, all describe **symmetry**. The opposite is **asymmetry**

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

There is some notable **asymmetry** in the whole argument

- (a) confusion (b) hesitation
(c) excitement (d) orderliness
(e) dissatisfaction

33. This bill has to wait as we are now **insolvent**
(a) overworked (b) bankrupt

- (c) unsettled (d) insoluble
(e) affluent

Answer B This question is from **Diction**: choosing and using appropriate words in a sentence.

Bankrupt means, having no money, or **in the red**. (Note: **in the green** means having a lot of money in the bank or at hand)

Insoluble means, that, which cannot dissolve in water. Sugar is **soluble** in water while iron is **insoluble**. **Affluent** means, rich, wealthy opulent and solvent

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

She became rather **insolvent** after the incident

- (a) bitter (b) happy (c) poor
(d) extremely rich (e) harsh

34. All his plans **fell through**
(a) failed (b) were accomplished
(c) had to be reviewed
(d) were rejected (e) fell

Answer A This question is from **Phrasal Verbs** which is the combination of verbs with particles

Fall through means, fail. (E) is not correct because a plan cannot **fall** (fell) but fail. A government can fall.

If you were asked the following question at the next examination what would your answer be?

His administration **fell** midway into the term of office

- (a) fell through (b) became a failure
(c) was overtaken by the military
(d) was scattered into bits and pieces
(e) the leader was arrested

35. The balance sheet at the end of the business year shows that it **broke even**
(a) lost heavily (b) made profit
(c) neither lost nor gained
(d) had no money to continue business
(e) were heavily indebted to our

bankers

Answer C This question is from **Idiomatic Expressions**

The Break Even Point in business is the point where your total money invested is the same as the total revenue already realised. Anything from this level is, gain or profit or margin

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

When he saw the government officials, Jantamata knew he was **in deep waters**

- (a) assured of government support
- (b) serious trouble (c) in debt
- (d) going to swim that afternoon
- (e) going to be rebuked for wrong – doing

36. He was appointed specifically to **put the recruits through**

- (a) assign them to work
- (b) train them (c) discipline them
- (d) assist them at work
- (e) supervise them at work

Answer B This question is from **Phrasal Verbs**

To **put** somebody **through** is to show such how to do things (train)

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

The two teams are to **lock horns** at the weekend

- (a) fight (b) display
- (c) confront each other (d) discuss
- (e) entertain people

37. The result of his experiment represents a **breakthrough** in medical science

- (a) an outstanding success
- (b) catastrophe
- (c) an end to such experiments
- (d) a breaking point
- (e) a colossal failure

Answer A The question is from **Phrasal Verbs**

A **catastrophe** is an evil happening / event; **colossal failure** is the opposite of **outstanding success**

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

The man smiled and labelled his brother a **black leg**

- (a) uncooperative fellow (b) a traitor
- (c) a dark complexioned man (d) a devil
- (e) a man of poor destiny

38. Being an optimist, our professor always sees the **bright side** of most things

- (a) charming (b) illumined
- (c) brilliant (d) pleasing
- (e) cheerful

Answer D The question is from **Diction**.

To be able to arrive at the correct answer, do note that all the options are adjectives while the noun phrase each tries to describe is **most things**

You are therefore to consider which adjective is most appropriate in use for **most things**

brilliant? X
pleasing? ✓
charming X (most things)
illumined X
cheerful X

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

One of the most **charming** women of our time is here tonight

- (a) cheerful (b) beautiful (c) brilliant
- (d) illumined (e) generous

39. The State Government appointed a commission of inquiry **to go into** the community's complaints

- (a) investigate (b) search
- (c) look for (d) account for
- (e) ascertain

Answers To 1978 Lexis and Structure Questions Continue After This
"Urgent Help" Section

URGENT HELP FOR YOUR NEXT EXAMINATION:

PHRASAL VERBS
MEANING

**PHRASAL
VERB**

EXAMPLE

Add up	Add	I can add up all the figures
Back up	Support or cause to explode or move backwards	Can you back up your claim with evidence?
Break	Analyse / list the parts separately	Here is a break down of my spending
Count in	Include	Shall I count in this bad orange for dinner?
Count out	Exclude	We have counted out the unfair girls
Keep up	Continue	You started well; keep up the pace
Leave out	Omit	Leave out a line before continuing to write
Let down	Disappoint	I will support but not let you down
See off	Accompany a person to the beginning of a journey	We saw Andy off to the airport
Send back	Send to a former place	The troublesome student was sent back home
Send over	send to where another person is	My parents sent me over to my uncle in America in 1999
Wash off	Wash the surface of	Ajantala washed off the table
Wash out	Wash the inside of	Bimbo washed out the pocket in her dress
Wind up	Tighten the spring or knob of a watch / machine or finish / complete / conclude	I can wind up this work in two hours' time
Drop out	Quit, leave	Peter dropped out of school in 1995
Face up to	Acknowledge/accept	After his parents died, Johnson faced up to his condition
Fall	Lag, not progress as expected	Abram was ill for ten days

43. If my father had not arrived, I would have starved. This sentence means
 (a) My father did arrive and I didn't starve
 (b) I had to starve because my father didn't come
 (c) My father didn't arrive and I didn't starve
 (d) I should have starved but I didn't

//If + subject + had (not) + past participle verb// +//subject + + have + pp verb//
 If my father had not arrived, I would have starved

To interpret the above, it means that my father actually arrived and I did not starve.

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

If I had not arrived, my father would have beaten me. This means that,

- (a) I was beaten because I did not arrive
 (b) I did not arrive but my father did not beat me
 (c) I was beaten although I arrived
 (d) I was not beaten because I arrived
 (e) I did not arrive and my father only arrived

44. The two sprinters were running **neck and neck**

- (a) exactly level (b) very slowly
 (c) very fast (d) together
 (e) with their neck together

Answer A The question is from **Idiomatic Expressions**

To run **neck and neck** is to be at the same level

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

The two boxers stood **shoulder to shoulder**

- (a) Both are of the same height
 (b) Both stood one beside the other
 (c) Both challenged each other
 (d) Both are capable of fighting

- (e) I had starved before my father arrived

Answer A This question is from **Tenses** based on **Conditionals**.

The formula for a structure like this is:

- (e) Both are of the same professional abilities

45. He **stared** at her
 (a) glanced (b) peeped (c) looked
 (d) gazed (e) fixed

Answer D The question is from **Diction**, the choice and use of appropriate words in context.

Glance is one quick look, **peep** is hide and look without steadiness, **look** is, see without particular attention

Gaze is look with particular attention, which is equivalent to **stared** (with eyes, wide open in particular attention). **Gaze** can be further amplified by **fixed**, to show particularity of attention

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

The children **peered** into the bathroom through the key hole.

- (a) stared (b) gazed (c) looked
 (d) glanced (e) fixed

46. When the man was caught by the police, he **presented a bold front**

- (a) he attacked the policemen boldly
 (b) he walked up to the policemen
 (c) he faced the situation with apparent boldness
 (d) he bravely attempted to give them a present
 (e) he frowned at them in a defiant

manner

Answer C The question is from **Idiomatic Expressions**

To present a **bold front** is to face up to a difficult situation with courage.

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

The convicted man at the court trial **held the bull by the horns**

- (a) came to court with all sorts of charms including a black ram and a white goat
- (b) displayed unusual courage
- (c) posed for a photograph outside court premises with goats and rams
- (d) contradicted the charges against him
- (e) accepted guilt like a good citizen

47. I have been able to observe him at **close quarters**

- (a) in government houses nearby
- (b) within a short space of time
- (c) in a small family house
- (d) at close range
- (e) at regular intervals

Answer D The question is from **Idiomatic Expressions**

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

He kept his sister **at arm's length**

- (a) shook her sister's hand
- (b) removed all familiarity between him

and his sister

- (c) Dealt officially with his sister
- (d) avoided coming in contact with his sister
- (e) Held her sister at the arms in cordial embrace

48. At the sight of the ghastly accident the poor woman's hair **stood on end**

- (a) the woman's hair became straight
- (b) the wind blew her hair upwards
- (c) the woman was unmoved
- (d) the woman disarranged her hair
- (e) the woman was frightened

Answer E The question is from **Idiomatic Expressions**

When hair "stands on end", one is afraid.

Other expressions like it are: her / his heart **got into his / her mouth**; **develop goose skin**; **cold feet**

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

When the woman saw the police, she developed **goose skin**

- (a) changed mystically into a bird and escaped
- (b) became exactly like a pitiful goose
- (c) was frightened
- (d) became stubborn
- (e) changed the way she was speaking

behind in		and so, fell behind in his education
Come by	Visit someone in their home	I came by a former teacher at Christmas
Come out	Appear; make social debut i.e. appear for the first time	The musician's album came out two weeks ago
Come over	Come to where one is	My sister asked me to come over to Lagos and I did
Come through	Succeed	All the scientist's efforts came through
Get off	Descend from, leave	The horse rider got off and shook hands with us
Get on	Mount, enter	I got on the bus at Victoria junction
Get on with	Proceed with	I will get on with my efforts toward university education
Pick on	Bully/tease/taunt	The students picked on the fat girl
Play up to	Flatter someone to achieve personal satisfaction	The politician played up to his achievements, as another election began
Put up with	Tolerate	Most people cannot put up with children and their antics
Go on	Continue/happen	The elections will go on even though the voters' register was not found
Go out	Stop burning/leave one's residence	The fire has not gone out be careful
Go over	Go/succeed	Angela went over in the examination
Hang around	Be idle/delay	Some street urchins hang around the street corner to beg for alms
Hang up	Put back telephone receiver on the hook	He hung up after our discussion and refused to call back

1978 Lexis and Structure Answers Continue...

Complete each of the following sentences by choosing the option that most suitably fills the space

49. When the beggar was tired, he -----
down by the road side
(a) lied (b) laid (c) layed
(d) lay (e) lain

Answer D This question is from
Tenses

Lay can be the past tense form of lie (which means, be in sleeping position) its past participle is lain

As a present tense verb, lay may mean, to spread or put something somewhere, e.g. I lay my report card on my father's desk. In this case, the present participle is laid and is usually preceded by has / have / had or is / was / are / were / am.

Lay as present tense may also refer to the process of production of eggs by a bird.

In that case, the present tense is lay, past form is laid and past participle is laid

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

Do not ----- your books on this desk; a hen has already ----- its eggs there

- (a) lie / lied (b) lay / lay (c) lay / lain

- (d) lay / laid (e) lie / laid

50. He did not like ----- leaving the class early

- (a) we (b) us (c) our
(d) ourselves (e) our selves

Answer C. The question is from **Basic Clause Structure**

First note that (e) is unEnglish. **Ourselves** should be written together always. **Ourselves** is not correct because we do not have **we** before it, since, as a reflexive pronoun, **ourselves** must refer (back) to **we**: **we ourselves** know it, not just: **Ourselves** know it

Look at the question again:

He is subject (S) **did not like** is predicator (P) while "----- leaving the class early" is the complement. So, we must put in the appropriate pronoun as complement.

Look at this:

Object Pronoun	Possessive Pronoun
him	his
her	her
it	it
you	your
me	my
us	our
them	their

Verb / Adjective / Noun	Preposition
Accustom(ed), conform indifferent, look opposite according, related, similar, succeed superior, senior, junior, write, reply, tie, bind, reply, agree.	To
Accuse, afraid, ashamed, boast, careful, consist, cure, composed, deprive, die, full, guilty, independent, jealous, proud, repent, sure, suspect, tired, warm, victim, disappoint, confident.	of
different, part, recoil, suffer, return	from
charge, agree, angry, comply, confer, cover, fill, pleased, popular, satisfied, interfere, meddle, shake, abide, shiver, tremble, part, write	with
Exchange, leave, repent(ance), Blame, die, live, feed, spend, sit, insist, come	on
Aim, shoot, throw, point, angry, arrive, connive, disgusted, glad, good, bad, slow, quick, indignant, look, stare, spy, gaze, pleased, rejoice, sit, surprised	at
Absorb, arrive, believe, confide(nce), die, disappointed, dressed, fail, good, interested, sit, succeed, write	in
Abide, benefit, come, walk, take	by
Protest, kick, work, talk, speak	against
Wait	upon
Write, speak, talk, joke	about

Continuation of 1978 Lexi's and Structure

The woman was killed by/through her husband. Who is the agent? Eh? Right! Her husband, a human agent, then, choose **by**. Okay?

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

His father died ----- a surgical operation but his mother was wounded ----- armed robbers combing the wrecked car

- (a) through/ by (b) by / through
- (c) by / by (d) through / through
- (e) by / from

83. The man no longer feared his opponent after their spokesman had assured him that they were well disposed ----- him
- (a) to (b) towards (c) around
 - (d) about (e) for

Answer B The question is from **Prepositions**

(Please check the answer to question 81 and the notes on it. In addition, note that the difference between **toward** and **towards** is that, whereas **toward** is American English **towards** is British English. All your answers must be in line with British English traditions. **Upward** and **upwards** are other words like the above

Cause and Course

Cause is both verb and noun, meaning the reason for an event or action. **Course** is an area of academic study or, process of something. **Coarse** is, not smooth, shaggy. **Cause** may also be an ideal that one believes in, e.g. equality of the male and female genders.

Broadcast – This word has the same form for its past and past participle forms.

I want to **broadcast** it tomorrow

I **broadcast** (not **broadcasted**) it yesterday.

It has been **broadcast**.

Also, **cast** follows the same pattern in its tenses as **broadcast**, where **cast** means, to throw, or to mould, as in iron. **Cast** may also mean to throw on.

By the end of January,

Whenever you find, **by** + future time, the formula anytime for the correct answer is:

// **By** + future time + // * // **Subject** + Will + **have** + **past participle verb** + "

e.g. **By** **Next year,** **you** **Will** **have** **been** **in the university**

4) **Help** / Wherever you find **help**, especially coming before a verb, the verb must come in "ing" form, e.g. He could not **help crying** when he saw the accident.

5) **Equipment** – This is a word from uncountable nouns and should be treated exactly like luggage or baggage. Do not put an **s** after the **t** to pluralise it and do not use a plural verb – use a singular verb, is / was / has / had / comes / takes etc. This equipment **has** (not; have) arrived.

6) **It's worth seeing**: When **worth** is encountered, to mean, "profitable if considered", you are to insert a primary auxiliary verb **is** or **are** or, **were** or **am** or **be** or **was** before it. Without one of the auxiliary verbs, it is incorrect.
The play? Yes! **It worth seeing X**

The play? Yes! It is + worth seeing

- (7) **Can be able?** Never!
Wherever you use **could** or **can** do not use **be able** or it boils down to tautology
e.g. I can be able to do it X
but
I can do it or
I **am able** to do it

- (8) **So"**
When **so** is used as an adverb of degree, a **that** clause must follow it:
He is **so** handsome (that what happens; to what extent / degree)
He is **so** handsome **that** he won the Mr. America contest.

- (9) **Presently**
Presently means, very soon. It does not mean, 'at the moment', or now.
You will pass your exams **presently** (very soon).
I shall be with you **presently** (not: wait. I'm coming)

- (10) **Many**
Many/plenty of/a lot of/a great deal of/some/few/a few/these/those/several/a great many... all these are called determiners and work only with plural count words (nouns) e.g. boys, houses. Not with **water**
e.g. I have **many** houses not
I have **many water** (water is uncountable) but **many** is plural count.
Much is used with uncountable nouns and that is why you cannot have a statement like: The students? Oh! They are too **much**

But

The students? Oh! They are too **many**

However, you say:

The water? Oh! It's too **much** (not: many).

Traffic, equipment, advice, baggage, luggage, information, news, furniture, all liquids, all abstract nouns are uncountable nouns, which you can use **much** with.

Answers to 1988 Lexis / Structure continue here...

In questions 56 to 85, choose the word(s) or phrase(s) which is best fills the gap(s)

56. The child's recent training has not been very effective, he is likely to ---
--- to his old habits
(a) revert (b) convert
(c) reverse (d) revise

Answer A The question is from Diction, the choice of appropriate words.

revert means, come back to the former order of things and cleave to another order. To **reverse** is to move towards the back of one's location while **revise** is to work on something already done with a view to adjusting it where necessary.

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

She was ----- Buddhism to the people's traditional religion

- (a) reversed from (b) revised from
- (c) converted from (d) reverted from

57. The students went on whispering in ----- of the teacher

- (a) dishonour (b) disagreement
- (c) defiance (d) disobedience

Answer C This question is from **Prepositions**. Different verbs or adjectives attract different prepositions. In dishonour **to** but in honour **of**; In (dis) agreement **with**; in disobedience **to**. You can write **to** a person but "write" something e.g. poems, note etc.

You can agree **to** a suggestion or something but "agree" **with** somebody.

You can "**die of**" a disease, illness or a condition of difficulty — he died of asthma.

One is "confident **of**" oneself or others but have "confidence **in**" oneself or others.

"Popular **with**" means "loved **by**" e.g.

He is popular with girls, means, he is loved by girls. It does not mean that he has popularity among them.

One can write **with** a writing material, e.g. pen, pencil

One can write **in** ink, or paint

One can die **for** a cause or what one believes in e.g. Stephen died **for** Christ

One can die **on** a guillotine

One can "live **on**" "feed **on**" food or money or a means of livelihood e.g. The old man lives **on** his monthly pension dues (he survives by spending his monthly pension dues).

"Good **at**" shows proficiency or expertise in something e.g. He is good **at** games.

One can "abide **by**" a regulation = keep a law or regulation.

But one can "abide **with**" a person = live or stay with, e.g. If I go to London, I will abide **with** friends.

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

He punished his subordinate because he was ----- fond of acting in ----- his boss

- (a) defiance to (b) dishonour of
- (c) disobedience to (d) agreement to

58. You can never find Okwu; he is a very ----- person

- (a) delusive (b) elusive
- (c) illusive (d) deceptive

Answer B This question is from **Diction**. In other words, which word will you choose from many others, to describe someone not easy to find?

delusive means, untrue or unreal; not to be relied upon, misleading while **illusive** means, like delusive, not real, capable of deceiving. **Deceptive** means, that which is done to deceive or a person who has no quality of truth or integrity.

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

The police discovered the hide out of some fraudsters whose operation is ----- and calculated to cheat people

- (a) illusive (b) elusive (c) delusive
- (d) deceptive

59. You could see that Akpan did not give his evidence -----

- (a) honestly completely
- (b) complete honestly
- (c) honest completely
- (d) completely honestly

Answer A The question is from **Adverbs** and the order of arranging misordered adverbs. The shorter usually precedes the longer adverbs.

***If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?**

He spoke -----

- (a) intermittently quietly
- (b) quietly intermittent
- (c) intermittently quiet
- (d) quietly intermittently

60. The suspect defrauded his victims of large sums of money

- (a) suspected (b) unsuspecting
(c) unexpected (d) unexpectd

Answer B The question is from **Diction** "Victims" are almost always "unsuspecting" of their oppressors, otherwise they would not fall "victims".

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

The ----- guest has not arrived although, all of us are eager to receive him

- (a) suspected (b) unsuspecting
(c) expected (d) expecting

61. The ----- of the participating countries will hold a preconference on the eve of the conference

- (a) Auditor Generals
(b) Auditors General
(c) Auditors Generals
(d) Auditor General

Answer B This question is from **Plural Compounds**.

Note the following: Girl Guides, Boy Scouts, Boy Brigades, Heads of State, Secretaries General, Parents – in – law / sisters / brothers / sons / daughters – in – law, Notaries public, Justices of the Peace, Major Generals call Girls, on – goings, bitter sweets, commanders – in – chief, Accountants General, Directors General, Tissue paper will not change from tissuepaper walking sticks deaf mutes, Financial Secretaries, Chief Judges, Chief Justices Chiefs of Staff.

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

Many people graced the occasion among whom were four ----- and eleven -----

- (a) Accountant Generals / financial Secretary
(b) Accountants General / financials Secretary
(c) Accountant Generals / financial Secretaries
(d) Accountants General / financial Secretaries

62. The drummers struck their drums with great efforts and the surging crowd of dancers ----- and ----- the grounds around the palace
(a) structed / thumped
(b) kicked / stamped
(c) thumped / licked
(d) stroked / thumped

Answer D This question is from **collocation**, the company that words keep. To **stroke** is to match on something repeatedly while **thump** is to touch, in rhythmic sequence, a surface of the ground. Both go together as do **lock, stock and barrel**, through **thick and thin**, **hook line and sinker**

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

He took the deceptive information

- (a) lock, stock and completely
(b) lock, thin and barrel
(c) lock, door and key
(d) lock, stock and barrel

63. The chairman's laughter was with no - ----- to ridicule the applicant
(a) intention (b) intend
(c) intendment (d) intent

Answer D This question is from **Diction**. **Intention** is a plan on one's mind, **intend** (a verb) is to plan to do something; **intent** (n) means, aim (and is different from **intention** (plan)). **Intendment** is used only in poetry as a figurative word for intention.

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

His ----- was to capture the thief alive

- (a) intent (b) intendment (c) intention
(d) intend

64. The water is not good for drinking; it's been ----- by the dead rabbit
(a) contaminated (b) infested
(c) spoilt (d) diseased

17. I have been trying to locate you -----
(a) since five day (b) five days now
(c) since five days now
(d) for five days

Answer D This question is from
Prepositions

Since and **for** are both prepositions but there are different rules governing the use of each in sentence formation.

To use **for**, there must be a number and a time unit mentioned:

for ten (number) years

for two (number) months / minutes / days / weeks.

Time units are: **months** / **weeks** / **days** / **seconds** / minutes

However, when using **since**, you are to avoid number and specific time, but insert specific time of action e.g.

Since + yesterday / last year / Friday / 12 noon

Do you understand the distinction? No?

Okay, look at this formula:

for + number + month(s) / minutes / weeks /



for **three** **minutes**

clear now? Yes? Good!. Now, the second are:

since + no number + definite time e.g.



(yesterday/the morning)

since +  + yesterday

Never: since +  + minutes ago

If you were asked the following question at the next examination, what would your answer be?

I have been watching you

(a) since three hours ago

(b) for three hours now

(c) since three hours now

(d) for three hours since

answer be?

I have been watching you

(a) since three hours ago

(b) for three hours now

(c) since three hours now

(d) for three hours since

78. The host insisted on ----- what he called "a little gift"

(a) me to accept (b) me accepting

(c) my accepting

(d) my acceptance

Answer C This question is from **Basic Clause Structure**. The question wants you to differentiate between a pronoun and a gerundive nominal at the complement position. Let us analyse:

The host = subject

Insisted on = predicator

What he called a "little gift" = complement

Since the gap (for the answer) is found at the predicator (verb level), you will avoid object pronouns such as me/him/her/them

but use the possessive adjectives

their/my/his/her/our/you/its + accepting"

SUBJECT**OBJECT**

He
She
We
They
it
you

me
him
her
us
them
it
you

URGENT HELP FOR YOUR NEXT EXAMINATION: LEXIS AND STRUCTURE

The story's length / The clothe's width

Here let us recognize two categories: living things and non – living things.

When we discuss non – living things, the "possession" of such things is shown in a structure containing the **possession** plus **of**, e.g. The length **of** the **cloth** (cloth is a non-living thing)

Not:

The cloth's length

But

If human beings are discussed in terms of the possession, **of** should be avoided:

The man's head ✓ (correct), not;

The **head of** the man X

Sister – in – laws?

This compound noun should be; sisters – in – law.

Others are; fathers – in – law, etc, Accountants – General, Directors – General, Chief – Justices, Attorneys – General, financial secretaries, post – offices, Justices – of – the peace, Heads of state, Commanders in chief.

Motor accident

This expression is actually **road accident**

Yours'/ It's your's

Belonging to you = it's **yours** (without apostrophe) = **it is yours**✓

Belonging to us = it's **ours** (without apostrophe) = **it is ours**✓

Hers, his, ours, yours are known as possessive adjectives and should not have any apostrophe.

Our principal and chairman is here

When a single person holds two positions which we are describing in one sentence, the second position he holds will not take **the** before it. For example, our principal is also chairman of the Association of conference of principals. So we structure it as 'The/our principal and Chairman of principals' association (only one person is referred to) knows (singular verb) me, not: **The principal and the chairman of ...** the second **the** makes it two people instead of one (occupying two positions) intended.

Elite / elitist

Elite is pronounced **ei – liit** or **e – LIIT**. Note that the second syllable is stressed.

Elite means, the group of influential people in society while **elitist** denotes a person in this group. **Elitist** is also used as an adjective to describe the attitude of such people.

It is therefore clearly seen that we cannot refer to a single person as **elite** but we can refer to a person as **elitist** in behaviour or is an elitist.

Elite is like the words; **staff** or **personnel** which cannot be pluralized; elites X (wrong).

Many a ...

Wherever you find **many a**, the next noun should be singular, e.g. many a **boy**...

The verb that follows the noun (boy) should be singular, too; many a boy knows (not; know) her.

The above is interpreted as;

Many boys know her. Take note of the statement and grammatical rule — and the interpretation, since you can be asked for the interpretation in an examination.

Wrong	Right
I am seeing you for the first time.	This is the first time I have seen you.
Sir, sir, now, I am understanding the answer.	Sir, I now understand the answer.
I am now loving her.	I now love her.

(9) **In pains**

To be **in pains** is to experience actual sensation of discomfort while **at pains** means, difficult.

He is **at pains** (he finds it difficult) to explain the kind of pains (sensation of discomfort) he is going through.

(10) **I'm coming**

While yet walking away from another person, it is inappropriate to say **I'm coming** but "**I'll be with you in a moment** or simply "**just a moment!**"

Answers to 2010 UTME Past Questions continue here

In each of the questions 51-65, choose the option nearest in meaning to the word or phrase in *italics*.

51. A political *impasse* does not offer the best opportunity for merrymaking A. manifesto B. Party C. gridlock D. rally

Answer = C

Reason: *Impasse* is pronounced as /umpas/ - (improvised pronunciation) and means logjam, disagreement, debacle, and **gridlock**. **Manifesto** is a plan of action of a political organization or candidate in an election.

If you were asked this question at your next examination, what would your answer be?

The faces of the women of easy virtue arrested by the police yesterday had already **sagged** (a) peeled (b) glowed (c) shrunk (d) darkened

52. We were all *enthusiastic* as we awaited the result of the election.

A. bemused B. agitated C. elated D. nervous.

Answer = C

Reason: to be **elated** is to be lively, enthused, happy, buoyed and enthusiastic. Being **agitated** is feeling worried and angry over an issue to be resolved while **bemused** means being confused or in a state where one does not know what to do, **nervous** means emotionally not coordinated; anxious, not being in one's usual, normal behavioural senses; afraid; behaving strangely.

If you were asked this question at your next examination, what would your answer be?

We were **agitated** over government's plan to stop our salaries (a) rioting (b) blamed (c) worried (d) confident

53. The uniform makes the guards look absurd A. dirty B. smart C. sensible D. ridiculous.

Answer = D

Reason: **Absurd** means stupid, foolish and this is like **ridiculous** which means creating or capable of bringing ridicule; laughable, foolish.

If you were asked this question at your next examination, what would your answer be?

The woman's email message to her husband was **tardy** (a) quick (b) unusual (c) late (d) unclear

54. The law is often **tardy** in reacting to change in attitude
A. quick B. slow C. exclusive D. generous.

Answer = B

Reason: **tardy** means, late or slow. **Generous** means kind while **exclusive** means many things, one of which is, used or owned by only one person or group of people. If something is **exclusive**, it is said to be available only to the rich and powerful.

If you were asked this question at your next examination, what would your answer be?

Alan's explanations to his boss was exhaustive a) false b) full c) scanty d) true

55. Isa and Ilu ate **sumptuous** meals on their brother's wedding day. A. expensive B. foreign C. insipid D. cheap.

Answer = A

Reason: **Sumptuous**, when used in the context of a meal as in this question means, of the highest quality, expensive and royal while **insipid** means, of little taste; tasteless, not palatable; jejune or cheap.

If you were asked this question at your next examination, what would your answer be?

The authorities of saint Anthony's catholic church **excommunicated** the Knight (a) praised (b) lost (c) expelled (d) honored

56. Kaltume **crouched** over the papers on her desk A. wrote on B. stood on C. walked over D. bent over.

Answer = D

Reason: to crouch is to bend over something such that one's belly almost touches the object.

If you were asked this question at your next examination, what would your answer be?

Omoye genuflected as he approached the church door (a) knelt (b) prayed (c) soke (d) sighed

57. The **panacea** of a country's economic mess lies in systematic planning and hard work. A. cures B. hope C. foresight D. trouble.

Answer = A

Reason: **panacea** is what cures an ailment while an **antidote** reverses the effect of a poisonous substance already swallowed. In medical science, the **therapeutic** medicine is the science of treating diseases while **prophylactic** medicine is, guarding against the occurrence of illness

If you were asked this question at your next examination, what would your answer be?

I prefer prophylactic medicine to the therapeutic (a) curative (b) preventive (c) bitter (d) Surgical

58. Thousands of workers have been victims of **retrenchment** since the military came back to power A.

In each of questions 66 to 85, choose the option that best completes the gap(s)

66. Lemoti ... as a painter, but also as a sculptor A. is gifted only not B. is not only gifted C. is gifted not only D. is only gifted.

Answer = C

Reason: This question is from **correlative conjunctions**. These are conjunctions that have two parts, e.g. both ...and; either ... or ...; not only ... but also ..., so, what will come before it (as you could see above) is not only, which is its first part. Do you understand?

Sometimes, the question may show you the first part, e.g. *either*. You should supply the second part: **or**; or you are given **both**, you should supply the second part **and** – and that is why it is important you know the correlatives by heart. You may also want to learn correlative adverbs which are as follows, although, please note that these correlative time adverbs are not what we are discussing at the moment; they come in other structures. They are 1. **No sooner ... than**, as in: **no sooner** had I left home **than** the robbers came

Hardly had ... when, as in: **hardly had** I left home **when** the robbers came

No more ... than as in: The news is **no more** shocking **than** I have told you.

Between ... and, as in: The contest takes place **between** 3 o'clock **and** (not: *between* ... "**to**") 5 o'clock.

From ... to, as in: The contest takes place **from** 3 o'clock **to/ till** is **until**. Note also that **until** is written with one l but **till** will two l's.

68. The boy told his mother ... A. that was the girl he told her about B. that was the girl I told you about her C. that was the girl I told her about D. that his the girl I told her about

Answer = A

Reason: This question is from **reported Speech**. A boy (he), in this question, is reporting a message to his mother in the indirect speech method.

This is how to turn a message into indirect speech:

- i. The original message must change in some of its parts.
- ii. No inverted commas will be used because we are not reproducing the original message.
- iii. The original speaker's identity + *said/asked/opined/told* must be written

In this question, the boy told his mother something. Hear it: "This is the girl I told you about". Someone is now reporting to the class what the boy told his mother.

Now the message must change

The following are the things that will change

... change

AT THE SUBJECT LEVEL

- I will change to **He/she**
- **We** will change to **they**
- **Our** will change to **their**
- **You/it** will change to **you/it**
- **This** will change to **that**
- **These** will change to **those**

AT THE PREDICATOR LEVEL

- **Will** will change to **would**
- **May** will change to **might**

• **Can** will change to **could**

• **Must** will change to **had to**

• **Ought to** will change to **had to**

• **Need** will change to **need**

• **Dare** will change to **dared**

All action (lexical) verbs must change to past,

e.g.

• **Go** will change to **went**

• **Know** will change to **knew**

• **Has** will change to **had**

• **Is** will change to **was**

Note: **Come** will change to **go**

AT THE COMPLEMENT LEVEL

• **Me** will change to **him/her**

• **Us** will change to **them**

• **This** will change to **that**

• **These** will change to **those**

AT THE ADJUNCT LEVEL

• **Now** will change to **then**

• **Here** will change to **there**

• **Today** will change to **that day**

• **Tomorrow** will change to **the following day**

• **Yesterday** will change to **previous day**

• **Last week/year** will change to **the previous week/year**

URGENT HELP FOR YOUR NEXT EXAMINATION:

LEXIS AND STRUCTURE

- (1) **Either....or**
When **either** is used, it is the last noun (or noun/pronoun) **after** that determines the choice of the verb: either the teachers or the principal **is** (not; are) telling lies. This principle applies to **neither ... nor...**, too
Under no circumstances are you expected to change these compound conjunctions from;
Either ... or to **either....nor**, or from **neither ... nor** to **neither ... or**.
- (2) **Request for**
Request + something/somebody, not request + **for** + something / somebody
I requested his help later
- (3) **Consist of** – is correct whereas **comprise** does not take **of**. It consists **of** nine students or it **comprises** nine students.
- (4) **Advice/advise**
Advice is the noun, advise, the verb.
I want to (perform action i.e. verb) advise you.
Take note that when you use advice (noun), it is an uncountable noun and it observes all laws relating to uncountable nouns, thus:
- Do not add an **s** to it, as **advices** X
 - Do not put a number before it: **two** advices X but two **pieces of** advice. ✓
 - Use only a singular verb with it, including **is / was / has / had**, **takes**, **speaks**, **gives** etc.
- 5) **Electronic / electronics**
Electronics is the area of engineering that deals with gadgetry which brings out sounds. It also refers to this type of products.
Electronic is the adjective that describes these things mentioned as **electronics**, e.g. electronic (adjective describing) handset / watch / camera.
- 6) **Personal effects/affects** there is no such thing as **personal affects** but **personal effects** which means, items of possession belonging to people such as clothes, undies, shoes, shaving sticks or all of these and more, packed together.
- 7) **% in grammar**

Whenever percentage is mentioned in grammar – (sentence making), the noun or pronoun that the percentage refers to must be known. If it is a countable noun e.g. **students** will be the subject, attracting a plural verb, e.g. **go, come, go, (not; goes /**

comes or goes) X

But if the noun/pronoun which the percentage stands for is uncountable or an abstract noun, use a singular verb,; is/was/has/had, goes, comes etc.

(8) Never or do not

never cannot and should not take the place of **did not**. Not; I **never** know him (this is pidgin English)

but ; I **do not** know him

to make the use of **never** safe, ensure that you have **has / have / or had** before **never**;

I have **never** seen this kind of thing before

(**never**) here, means, **not happened before now**

(9) escort: To go out of your own house with a visitor who has just come visiting, you should not choose to **escort** him / her (even if you are a professional soldier), neither can you **follow** or **join** him / her to the gate or any other such place, but simply **accompany** him / her out or to the doorstep.

(10) Hot Drink?

How very hot? Alcoholic drinks are **hard** drinks, not hot drinks although, they sometimes produce hot or warm sensation in the mouth.

ORAL ENGLISH:

Laws for Pronouncing Words

There are different methods of asking questions of the oral forms. However, there are certain principles and laws that are capable of leading you to the answer where you have questions.

For example, UME 2007 questions 62, 63 and 64 are questions that border on appropriate pronunciation of words based on the principle of syllabication and stress. What is the answer to each of the following questions? — Attempt them before learning the laws. Re – visit them, after learning the laws.

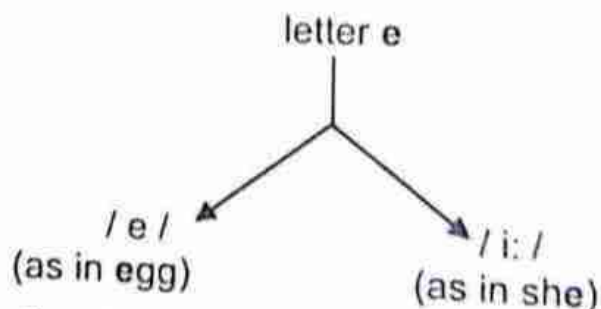
2007 UME: In each of questions 62 to 64, choose the appropriate stress pattern from the options. The syllables are written in capital letters.

62. Capitalism
(a) capi**T**alism (b) capita**L**ism (c) ca**P**italism (d) **C**Apitalism
63. association
(a) a**S**SOciation (b) associa**T**ION (c) associ**A**Tion (d) **A**ssociation
64. advertisement
(a) ad**V**ERTisement (b) advertise**M**ENT (c) adver**T**ISEment
(d) **A**Dvertisement

What are your answers? Write each down.

Now, let us look at the laws. Before that, let us look at some important concepts that we cannot escape:

- (a) **Letter:** There are twenty – six letters in the English Language, also called the alphabet: A B C D ... Z.
- (b) **Sound:** Note that a letter, e.g. **e** is different from a sound e.g. / e /. When we discuss sound, we usually have two slanting lines bordering it in front and behind. So
- (i) **e** is a letter
- (ii) / **e** / is a sound. Do you understand? The difference is the / / (slanting lines). Yes, **one** letter can produce two, three or more sounds



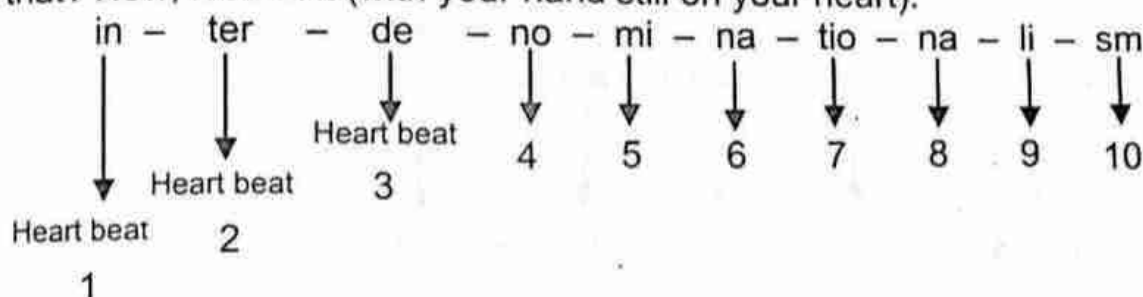
From the above, notice that **letter e** produces two **sounds**

- (a) / e / as in egg
 (b) / i: / as in she. It is the **e** in **she** and the same **e** in **egg** that has produced / e / and / i: / sounds.

(c) **Stress:** Stress is the pitch, that is the height of your voice as it goes up and sounds deeper on a syllable in a word than other syllables. This means that, one word may have many syllables and you are expected to pronounce one syllable **LOUDER** than the other syllables (of the same word) if the pronunciation must be right.

It therefore means that, stress cannot be discussed without having discussed **SYLLABLES**.

(d) **Syllable:** A syllable is the amount of speech sound that can be produced at one heart beat. Now, how many times (place your hand on your heart) will your heart beat before you complete the pronunciation of the longest word in the dictionary: interdenominationalism. How many times? No, No!! Not six. How did you arrive at that? Now, look at it (with your hand still on your heart):



So, it means, there are 10 syllables in that word. Do you truly understand? Good! Now, how many syllables are there in the following?

1. communism
2. old
3. internal
4. father
5. recuperation

Answers

- 1 = 4 syllables
- 2 = 1 syllable
- 3 = 3 syllables
- 4 = 2 syllables
- 5 = 5 syllables

So you got everything? Great! Okay, now that you know syllables, let us discuss **STRESS** a little deeper.

Look at **father** as a word. To pronounce the 2 syllable word, one of the two syllables must be pronounced louder than the other. Look at the syllables:

fa - ther. Which syllable will therefore be pronounced louder than the other? Yes, **fa** (pronounced with the "miii" tone, sounding like: faaa ... The second syllable will be pronounced low, with the "doouu" tone. So, to pronounce father correctly, it can be written in two ways:

FA - ther (miii - do) — make sure the **ther** sounds only faintly while the **FA** sounds very high. Try it. Ah ha! Yes, yes; you got it. Do it again. Great!!

A second way of writing out the pronunciation of **father** is by putting a small mark on top **before** the syllable that is "stressed", and that is the dictionary way of teaching learners pronunciation. So, **father** in the dictionary is written for pronunciation purposes as: / transcribe /. The stroke (/) on top of **f** shows that, the first syllable should be pronounced louder than the second.

Now, how do you determine, at any time, where, on a word, you are to put the stress - mark? In other words, which syllable should you **STRESS** in a word. JAMB gives three words: **capitalism**, **association** and **advertisement**. So which syllable is stressed (pronounced louder than the other syllables) in the word? The principles are the following:

Law 1: WORDS ENDING IN "SM"

If a word ends in **SM**:

The formula is: **STRESS** + $\emptyset$ + $\emptyset$ + $\emptyset$ + **SM**

This means that, if there is a word ending in **sm** it is the **FIRST** syllable that must be stressed.

Look at the $\emptyset$ + $\emptyset$ + (in the formula above).

They represent three syllables. You may have two, three, four, five, six or more syllables before **sm**. Each of: the $\emptyset$ is not stressed.

So, in other words, federalism will be pronounced as:

FE	-	de	-	ra	-	li	-	sm
↓		↓		↓		↓		↓
STRESS +		$\emptyset$	+	$\emptyset$	+	$\emptyset$	+	sm

Do you understand?

So, what is the answer to UME 2007 question 62? Whao! Great, "D". Happy for you!

Try pronounce and stress the following, too:

Fascism, nepotism, feudalism, socialism, nationalism, mannerism, communism, activism, tribalism, feminism, etc.

Law 2: WORDS ENDING IN "IST"

Formula = **STRESS** + $\emptyset$ + $\emptyset$ + $\emptyset$ + **ist**

↓	↓	↓	↓	↓
FEU	da	-	-	list.
or feu - dalist = FEU - da - list				

This means that words that end in **ist** are treated much the same way **sm** word are treated: stressed on the first syllable.

Consider these, too: industrialist, communist, nationalist, socialist, activist, federalist and fascist. How are they stressed?

Law 3: Words with prefix and **sm**

If a word has a prefix, e.g. **re** before a word that ends in **sm**, the formula is:

e.g. prefix + **STRESS** + Ø + Ø + Ø + sm
 (a) re VI sio ni - sm = reVIisionism
 (b) pan A fri ca ni sm = panAfricanism
 Consider: revivalism, postcommunism, antirheumatism.

Law 4: Words with prefix and ist
 If a word has a prefix, e.g. **re** or **ante** or **anti** or **pro** or **pan** etc before a word that ends in **ist**, the formula is:

prefix + **STRESS** + Ø + Ø + Ø + ist
 pan A fri can - ist

Law 5: Reflexive Pronouns
 All reflexive pronouns end in **self** or **selves** — and these are the syllables to stress in words such as:
 Them**SELVES**, my**SELF**, your**SELF** / your**SELVES**, her**SELF**, him**SELF**, it**SELF**, our**SELVES**.

Law 6: Teen words
 All words ending in **teen** are to be stress on the **teen**:
 six**TEEN**, nine**TEEN**, thir**TEEN**.

Law 7: Ty words
 Numbers ending in **ty** are stressed on the syllable **BEFORE ty**:
FORty, **NINE**ty.

Law 8: Words with ion ending
 Mostly, nouns end in **ion**. Where does the stress fall in accommodation, for example? The law in formula is:
 Ø + Ø + Ø + **STRESS** + **ion**. This means that, it is the **syllable BEFORE ion** that must be stressed. So, accommodation is written as
 a - cco - mmo - **DA** - tion.
 Other **ion** words are: communication, negotiation, decision, complexion, transportation and realisation. Can you try pronounce each, right?

Law 9: Words with ic ending
 The law in formula is:
 Ø + Ø + Ø + stress + **ic**
 This means that, like words ending in **ion** (above), it is the **syllable BEFORE ic** that must be stressed, e.g. republic, photographic:
 re **PUB** lic, pho - to **GRA** phic
 Others are, fantastic, specific, pathetic, dramatic, nationalistic, economic.

Law 10: Words with ics ending
 As with law 9, a word ending in **ics** will be stressed on the syllable before the **ics**

= Ø + Ø + Ø + stress + **ics**.

Words that obey this law include:

Economics, semantics, Mathematics, Civics, mechanics, linguistics.

Law 11: Words with **ial** or **ian** endings

The formula is:

Ø + Ø + Ø + stress + **ian / ial**,

The stressed syllable is the one **BEFORE** **ian** or **ial**, as in:

politician, commercial

= po - li - **TI** - cian, com - **MER** - cial

Other words in this category include:

Civilian, industrial, authoritarian, Mathematician, official, palatial, electrician, judicial

Law 12: Words with **ient** ending

Mostly adjectives use the - **ient** suffix.

Appropriate stressing is as follows:

Ø + Ø + Ø + stress + **ient**

e.g. Recipient, efficient = re **CI** pient, e **FFI** cient

Other words like the above are: convenient, deficient, proficient.

Law 13: Words with **um** or **ium** ending

The formula for syllable stressing here is:

Ø + Ø + Ø + stress + **um / ium**, e.g:

equilibrium, ultimatum = e - qui - **LI** - brium, ul - ti - **MA** - tum. Other such words include: presidium, symposium, addendum, corrigendum, compendium, memorandum, pandemonium.

Law 14: Words ending in **ious** or **ual** or **uous** or **eous**

e.g. Formula = Ø + Ø + Ø + stress +
unusual = un - **U** - sual
continuous = con - **TI** - nuous
extraneous = ex - **TRA** - neous
industrious = in - **DUS** - trious

ious
eous
uous
ual

Law 15: Words with **ical** or **al** ending

Adjectives are the most likely words ending in these ways (suffixes)

Formula: Ø + stress + Ø + , e.g:

mechanical = me - **CHA** - ni - cal

fanatical = fa - **NA** - ti - cal

directional = di - **REC** - tio - nal

↓ ↓ ↓ ↓
Ø + stress + Ø + Ø

Other words are: political, inaugural, identical, mathematical, departmental

Law 16:

Words ending in (i)ble

Adjectives are the most likely class of words ending in **ible** or **ble**. Stress the third syllable to the end.

Formula: $\emptyset + \text{stress} + \emptyset + \text{---}$

e.g. impossible

= im - POS - si - ble
 $\downarrow \quad \downarrow \quad \downarrow \quad \downarrow$
 $\emptyset + \text{stress} + \emptyset + \emptyset$

Other words in this category include: compatible, illegible, admissible, permissible, etc

Law 17:

Words with -sis ending

Nouns are more likely to end in **-sis** than any other word class. Stress the third syllable to the end

Formula = $\emptyset + \text{stress} + \emptyset + \text{sis}$ e.g.

osmosis = OS - mo - sis (third syllable to end, stressed)

paralysis = pa - RA - ly - sis (" " " " ")

Other words in this category are:

hypothesis, analysis, photosynthesis, synthesis, parenthesis, elephantiasis.

Law 18:

Words with ity ending

The suffix **ity** is used mostly for nouns. Words that end in **ity** are stressed on the third syllable to the end of the word.

Formula = $\emptyset + \text{stress} + \emptyset + \text{-ity}$, e.g.

heredity = he - RE - di - ty
 $\downarrow \quad \downarrow \quad \downarrow \quad \downarrow$
 $\emptyset + \text{stress} + \emptyset + \text{ty}$

Others in this category are:

plurality, paternity, morality, activity, quality, community, impossibility.

Okay, now, pronounce **impossibility** with the appropriately stressed syllable.

No! Ah, why? Take it again: Yes!: im - pos - si - BI - li - ty

$\downarrow$
 (third syllable to the end, stressed)

Law 19:

Words with ship ending

Some nouns end in **ship**.

Such words are stressed on the third syllable to the end.

Formula = $\emptyset + \text{stress} + \emptyset + \text{ship}$, e.g.

$\downarrow \quad \downarrow \quad \downarrow \quad \downarrow$
 dic - TA - tor - ship (third syllable to the end, stressed)

Other words in this category include:

fellowship, relationship, partnership, etc.

Law 20:

Words with ise or ize ending

Verbs sometimes end in **ise** (British English) or **ize** (American English). Remember, British English is regarded as the standard English, the world

over and is the one used in Nigeria, Ghana, The Gambia, Ireland, Australia and the United Kingdom.
Whenever a word ends in **ise** or **ize**, the stress will fall on the third syllable to the end.

Formula: $\emptyset$ + stress + $\emptyset$ + , e.g.

customise = cus - tom -

disorganise = dis - or - gan -

ise
ize

Other such verbs include: internationalise, rationalise, nationalise, naturalise, organise, commercialise.

Law 21:

Words with **-ate** ending

Adjectives and verbs are mostly found in this category. Such words ending in **-ate** are stressed on the third syllable to the end.

Formula: $\emptyset$ + stress + $\emptyset$ + **-ate**, e.g.

commemorate = com - **ME** - mo - rate



(third syllable from the end, stressed)

Others are: congratulate, accommodate, etc.

Exception: Note that, if a **sh** sound / transcribe / comes before the **-ate**, e.g. appreciate, the syllable to be stressed will **not** be the **third** from the end of the word but, the second syllable from the end:

So, **appreciate** will become

ap - **PRE** - ciate

Others to be treated in this manner include: differentiate, negotiate. Do you understand?

Law 22:

Words with **ent** or **ant** or **ence** ending

For words ending in **ent** or **ant** or **ence**, the syllable to stress is the third one from the end. Formula = $\emptyset$ + stress + $\emptyset$ +

e.g.

independence = in - **DE** - pen - dence

arrogant = **Ar** - ro - gant

diffident = **DI** - ffi - dent

ant
ent
ence

Other such words include:

irrelevant, magnificent, irrelevance, magnificence

Law 23:

Words with **-fy** ending

Verbs may end in **-fy**. Where to stress such words? Easy: on the third syllable from the end.

Formula: stress + $\emptyset$ + **-fy**, e.g.

mortify = **MOR** - ti - fy

Other verbs include: demystify, qualify, electrify, simplify, classify

Law 24:

Words with **ment** ending

A noun sometimes ends **ment**. Such word is stressed the way you would have stressed it in its base form. For example, **Management**. Where does the stress fall? Simple! Remove **ment**, leaving you with **manage**. How would you stress manage — 2 syllables? Yes! on the first syllable, of course!

MA – nage ✓ so, to stress management,:

MA – nage – ment (first syllable stressed).

Try pronounce the following, too:

Bewilder**ment**, government, establish**ment**, deployment, appointment, discouragement.

To stress **advertisement**, remember, you must return the word to its smallest possible form (base word) and then apply the stress, like that. So, the base word for **advertisement** is **advert**.

How do you stress that? **AD** – vert. So, **advertisement** is pronounced as **AD** – ver – tise – ment.

To stress **discouragement**, first stress **courage** (the base word)

Law 25:

Read these laws everyday and store them in your skull.

Summary of Stress – Placement Laws

Category 1:

Formula	Example
1. Stress + Ø + Ø + Ø + sm e.g.	CO – mu – ni – sm
2. Stress + Ø + Ø + Ø + ist e.g.	NA – tio – na – list

Category 2:

3. prefix + stress + Ø + Ø + Ø + sm , e.g.	re – CA – pi – ta – li – sm
4. prefix + stress + Ø + Ø + Ø + ist , e.g.	pan – A – fri – ca – nist

Category 3:

5. Ø + stress (SELF / SELVES), e.g.	my SELF
-------------------------------------	----------------

Category 4:

6. Ø + stress ("teen" number ending in 'teen'), e.g.	NINE teen
--	------------------

Category 5:

7. Stress + Ø ("Ty") numbers ending in "ty", e.g.

FORty

Category 6:

8. Ø + Ø + Ø + stress + **ion**, e.g.

a-cco-mmo-**DA**-tion

9. Ø + Ø + Ø + stress + **ic**, e.g.

pho-to-**GRA**-phic

10. Ø + Ø + Ø + stress + **ics**, e.g.

E-co-**NO**-mics

11. Ø + Ø + Ø + stress + **ian**, e.g.

Po-li-**TI**-cian

12. Ø + Ø + Ø + stress + **ient**, e.g.

su-**FFI**-cient

13. Ø + Ø + Ø + stress + **um** or **ium**, e.g.

e-qui-**LI**-brium

Ø + Ø + Ø + stress + **ious/eous/uious/ual**

con-**TI**-nuous

Category 7:

15. Ø + stress + Ø + **ical / cal**, e.g.

me-**CHA**-ni-cal

16. Ø + stress + Ø + **ible / ble**, e.g.

im-**POS**-si-ble

17. Ø + stress + Ø + **sis**, e.g.

a-**NA**-ly-sis

18. Ø + stress + Ø + **ity**, e.g.

ac-**TI**-vi-ty

19. Ø + stress + Ø + **ship**, e.g.

re-**LA**-tion-ship

20. Ø + stress + Ø + **ise / ize**, e.g.

RE-cog-nise

21. Ø + stress + Ø + **ate**, e.g.

a-**CCO**-mmo-date

22. Ø + stress + Ø + **ant / ent / ence** e.g.

DE-pen-dence

Category 8:

23. Stress + Ø + **fy**

GRA-ti-fy

Category 9:

24. — ment words = apply stress as it would appear on the base word, e.g.

es-**TA**-blish =
es-**TA**-blish-ment

Category 10:

25.

$\emptyset + \emptyset + \emptyset + \text{stress} + \text{logy}$, e.g.

ge – ne – **A** – logy

Note: As you go through from section to section in this book, many other hints are given. These hints, if followed properly will deliver all the marks under **oral forms** to your hands. As you study this treatise and the section – by – section hints, attempt past questions and arrive safely at correct answers.

Past Question References

2007 questions 62, 63 and 64 (as featured at the beginning of this Oral English Treatise)

Solution: Use laws 3, 8 and 24 respectively

2006 questions 46 & 47

Choose the appropriate stress pattern from the options. The syllables are written in capital letters

question 46

Genealogy

(a) genea**L**Ogy (b) gene**A**logy

(c) ge**NE**alogy (d) Genealogy

Solution: Use law 25 (category 10)

question 47

catholicism

(a) ca**TH**olicism (b) **CA**tholicism

(c) catholi**C**ism (d) catho**L**icism

Solution: Apply law 1

Grammatical functions in the clause

The description of word classes, phrases, and clauses in terms of their structure is part of the study of form. We now turn to the study of grammar from the perspective of function: this notion refers to what words, phrases and clauses do as units of language.

Grammatical functions are the roles that different constituents (strings of words acting as units) play in clauses. Examples are Subject and Object (also called Direct Object).

NOTE: We use initial capitals for functional terms like Subject and Object, to make it easier to distinguish them from formal terms like noun, noun phrase, verb, etc.

Understanding how clauses are formed and how constituents work together is important in developing both close reading and effective writing skills.

Compare the following examples. How do they differ in meaning?

- *The police attacked the demonstrators.*
- *The demonstrators attacked the police.*

In the first example, the police are the ones doing the attacking, whereas in the second the police are the ones being attacked.

- *The police attacked the demonstrators.*
- *The demonstrators attacked the police.*

In the first example, the police are the ones doing the attacking, whereas in the second the police are the ones being attacked.

Grammatically what's happening here is that the same noun phrase, *the police*, occurs with a different grammatical function in each example:

- *The police* attacked the demonstrators.
[Subject]
- The demonstrators attacked *the police*.
[Object]

In the first example, the noun phrase *the police* is positioned before the verb and functions as Subject. In the second, it is positioned after the verb and functions as Object.

The form is the same (*the police* is a noun phrase in both cases), but the function is different.

The examples we looked at describe an action of attacking, involving two participants: the agent carrying out the attack and the patient (or 'undergoer') affected by the attack.

But what about this example? Is there an action with an agent and patient?

- *The students know the answer.*

This example involves 'knowing' – which is not an action but a state of affairs. The students are not agents 'acting on' the answer.

But this clause has the same kind of grammatical pattern as the 'attacking' examples. It has a Subject (*the students*) before the verb and an Object (*the answer*) after it.

This means we can't define grammatical functions purely in terms of meanings such as agent and patient.

Instead we need to look at the grammatical behaviour of phrases, for example:

- What is their position in the clause?
- How do they relate to other elements?

The most central element in the clause is the verb. It has the function of Predicator:

- *The police attacked the demonstrators.*

The main verb generally tells us what kind of 'situation' is involved – for example, an action like 'attacking' or 'eating', or a state like 'knowing' or 'believing'.

The Predicator can combine with various other functional elements to make different clause patterns.

One simple clause pattern consists of a noun phrase functioning as Subject, followed by a verb functioning as Predicator.

Examples are:

- *She laughed* [W2F-018 #189]
- *The scrum collapses.* [S2A-002 #180]
- *The head of the company died.* [S1A-018 #130]

Here the Predicator indicates the type of situation (laughing, collapsing, dying) and the Subject tells us who or what is involved in the situation (who or what is laughing, and so on).

We can show the structure of these examples as follows. The first line of the table shows the form labels and the second line shows the function

We can show the structure of these examples as follows. The first line of the table shows the form labels and the second line shows the function labels.

<u>form</u>	noun phrase	verb
<u>function</u>	Subject	Predicator
example 1	<i>She</i>	<i>laughed</i>
example 2	<i>The scrum</i>	<i>collapses</i>
example 3	<i>The head of the company</i>	<i>died</i>

This simple pattern is often extended by one or more phrases which specify a circumstance of the situation – such as when, where or how it happens. These phrases function as Adverbials:

- *It rolled beautifully*. [S1A-057 #316]
- *Once upon a time I walked into a law school*. [S2A-044 #20]
- *The icecap soon reforms*. [W2B-025 #66]

Adverbials are typically preposition phrases or adverb phrases. They can be found in various positions in the clause.

Grammatical Functions of English Nouns and Noun Phrases



Linguistics Girl
"The Linguistic Librarian"

*Grammatical Functions of English
Nouns and Noun Phrases*

- Noun phrase head
- Subject
- Subject complement
- Direct object
- Object complement
- Indirect object
- Prepositional complement
- Noun phrase modifier
- Determinative
- Appositive
- Adjunct adverbial

Nouns are traditionally defined as “persons, places, things, and ideas.” **Noun phrases** are defined as phrases that consist of a **noun** or **pronoun** and any number of constituents including adjectives, determiners, prepositional phrases, verb phrases, and adjective clauses.

Noun Phrase Head

The first grammatical function that nouns perform is the **noun phrase head**. A noun phrase consists of a noun including a pronoun plus any determiners, modifiers, and complements. For example, the following italicized nouns function as noun phrase heads:

- the big blue *ball*
- *someone* to love
- an old *woman* who lived in a shoe

Subjects

The second grammatical function that noun phrases perform is the **subject**. A subject is a word, phrase, or clause that performs the action of or acts upon the verb. For example, the following italicized noun phrases function as subjects:

- *The baby* cried.
- *Dogs and cats* make excellent pets.
- *I* will have extensively studied English grammar.

Subject Complements

The third grammatical function that noun phrases perform is the **subject complement**. A subject complement is a word, phrase, or clause that follows a copular, or linking, verb and describes the subject of a clause. The terms **predicate nominative and predicate noun** are also used for noun phrases that function as subject complements. For example, the following italicized noun phrases function as predicate nominatives:

- My grandfather is *a farmer*.
- Our favorite pets are *dogs with short hair*.

- My grandfather is *a farmer*.
- Our favorite pets are *dogs with short hair*.
- The woman whom you are looking for is *she*.

Direct Objects

The fourth grammatical function that noun phrases perform is the **direct object**. A direct object is a word, phrase, or clause that follows a transitive verb and answers the question "who?" or "what?" receives the action of the verb. For example, the following italicized noun phrases function as direct objects:

- The children ate *all the cookies*.
- My professor recommended *an extremely captivating book*.
- The woman has always hated *mice and rats*.

Object Complements

The fifth grammatical function that noun phrases perform is the **object complement**. Object complements are defined as nouns, pronouns, noun phrases, adjectives, and adjective phrases that directly follow and modify the direct object. For example, the following italicized noun phrases function as object complements:

- We consider our puppy *our baby*.
- My aunt calls my uncle *sweetheart*.
- America recently elected Barack Obama *president*.

Indirect Objects

The sixth grammatical function that noun phrases perform is the **indirect object**. An indirect object is word, phrase, or clause that indicates to or for whom or what the action of a ditransitive verb is performed. For example,

the following italicized noun phrases function as indirect objects:

- My husband bought *me* flowers.
- The child drew *his mother* a picture.
- The salesman sold *the company suffering from the scandal* new computers.

Prepositional Complements

The seventh grammatical function that noun phrases perform is the **prepositional complement**. A prepositional complement is a word, phrase, or clause that directly follows a preposition and completes the meaning of the prepositional phrase. For example, the following italicized noun phrases function as prepositional complements:

- My husband bought flowers for *me*.
- The students studied during *their spring break*.
- Because of *the lengthy delay*, we missed our flight.

Noun Phrase Modifiers

The eighth grammatical function that noun phrases perform is the **noun phrase modifier**. A noun phrase modifier is a word, phrase, or clause that modifies or describes a noun including a pronoun or a noun phrase. For example, the following italicized noun phrases function as noun phrase modifiers:

- The *child* actor won an award.
- The carpenter fixed the broken *table leg*.
- We reserved twenty *hotel* rooms.

Determinatives

Determinatives

The ninth grammatical function that noun phrases can perform is the **determinative**.

Determinatives provide information such as familiarity, location, quantity, and number.

Possessive nouns – which are a noun, pronoun, or noun phrase and the possessive clitic (**apostrophe s or s apostrophe**) – function as determinatives. Possessive nouns indicate possession of or some other relationship to another noun or noun phrase. For example, the following italicized noun phrases function as possessive modifiers:

- *My brother's* apartment is small.
- I found *everyone's* reports informative.
- *The man who stole my purse's* car has been towed.

Appositives

The tenth grammatical function that noun phrases perform is the **appositive**. An appositive is a word, phrase, or clause that modifies or explains another noun phrase. For example, the following italicized noun phrases function as appositives:

- My grandfather, *the farmer*, bought more farm land.
- The teacher, *my uncle*, assigns a lot of homework.
- The musician *Stevie Nicks* is a singer in the band *Fleetwood Mac*.

Adjunct Adverbials

The eleventh grammatical function that noun phrases perform is the **adjunct adverbial**. An adjunct adverbial is a word, phrase, or clause that modifies an entire clause by providing additional information about time, place, manner, condition, purpose, reason, result, and concession. For example, the following italicized noun phrases function as adjunct adverbials:

- *Today* the children woke up early.
- *Yesterday* the children slept in late.
- We decided to go *home*.

The eleven functions of noun phrases are noun phrase head, subject, subject complement, direct object, object complement, indirect object, prepositional complement, noun phrase modifier, determinative, appositive, and adjunct adverbial.

The brown dog ran quickly towards the black cat.

The rules by which we arrange words to convey meaning are called **syntax**.

Different words, depending on where they are in the sentence, or what endings we attach to them, perform different functions in a sentence. Simplified for the purpose of this grammar, these functions are:

- **Subject** **Subjects**: The subject is the "doer" or "actor." In the sentence "*Alfred* ate the cakes," "*Alfred*" is the subject.
- **Verb** **Verbs**: The verb is the action being done. In the sentence "*Alfred* ate the cakes," "*ate*" is the verb.
- **Direct Object** **Direct Objects**: The direct object the receiver of the action. In the sentence "*Alfred* ate the cakes," "*cakes*" is the direct object."
- **Indirect Object** **Indirect Objects**: The indirect object is the secondary receiver of the action. In the sentence "*Alfred* carried the sword to the *battle*," "*battle*" is the indirect object (and "*sword*," which is receiving the action, is the direct object). Indirect objects are often called "objects of prepositions" because in Modern English we use prepositions to indicate the sort of action being secondarily received: in the phrases "*to the battle*," "*with the sword*," "*under the thorn tree*," "*by the river*" "*battle*," "*sword*," "*tree*," and "*river*" are the objects of their respective prepositions.
- **Modifier** **Modifiers**: Modifiers describe subjects, verbs and objects. Adjectives describe subjects and objects; adverbs describe verbs. In the sentence "*With his old sword, Alfred quickly* killed the viking," "*old*" is an adjective that modifies "*sword*," (it describes the condition of the sword), and "*quickly*" is an adverb that modifies "*killed*" (it explains how the killing was done). Adjectives describe subjects and objects; adverbs describe verbs and adjectives.

In Old English certain pronouns (demonstratives) are used as modifiers: In the sentence "*this* sword belongs to *that* man," "*this*" describes the sword and "*that*" describes the man. Likewise "a," "an," and "the," which we call articles in Modern English, are, in Old English grammar, special pronouns (demonstratives) that are used as modifiers: "*The* sword" is different from "a sword" because the modifiers "the" and "a" are providing different descriptions.

Genitives are an important sub-set of modifiers in Old English. Genitives are possessives: they indicate ownership. A noun with a genitive ending, like the Modern English 's, is used as an adjective to modify another noun. In the sentence "Alfred's sword was old," "*Alfred's*" is a genitive: a noun (Alfred) has had the genitive ending ('s) added to it. A good rule of thumb for dealing with the genitive is to translate it as "of X" where "X" is the noun that has the genitive ending. Thus "Alfred's sword" could be translated as "the sword of Alfred."

-  **Function Words:** What we are calling "function words" are prepositions and conjunctions that don't mean anything in themselves but serve to indicate the ways other words relate to each other. Prepositions indicate relationships, and conjunctions join things together. In the sentences "Alfred fought *with* the vikings and won the battle *by* the thorn tree," "*with*" and "*by*" are prepositions that indicate relationships (where the battle was fought and whom it was fought against) and "*and*" indicates that two parts of the sentence are joined together.

The above description of word functions is radically simplified, but it should be enough to explain the concepts in the grammar and get you translating Old English as soon as possible. The important point to

remember is that we will need to use certain orders of words or put certain endings on words in order to indicate what roles they are playing in a sentence. We will go over these concepts in more detail in the following sections, but first take a few moments to practice identifying the word functions in the exercises.

[Click here](#) for some exercises to practice recognizing the parts of speech.

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